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Aoun to meet Trump, push for pressure on Israel deal

First visit by Lebanese president to White House in nearly 20 years

Reuters
Beirut, July 19

LEBANESE PRESIDENT Joseph Aoun will make his first trip to the White House this week to present a plan to US President Donald Trump on how to disarm Iran-backed militant group Hezbollah and secure Israel's withdrawal from Lebanon.

Aoun, who served as commander of Lebanon's US-backed army before being elected president last year, is the first Lebanese head of state in nearly 20 years to visit White House, where he will meet Trump face-to-face for the first time.

Tuesday's meeting comes at a crucial moment for Lebanon: Israeli troops are occupying a swathe of the country's south, hundreds of thousands of Lebanese remain displaced following Israeli strikes and Hezbollah has firmly rejected the government's direct talks with Israel — and efforts by the state to strip it of its arms.

In comments published by his office last week, Aoun said he would ask Trump to "exert the necessary pressure on Israel" to implement a US-brokered June 26 agreement between Lebanon and Israel.

Six dead, 21 injured after two earthquakes in Peru

Reuters
Lima, July 19

AT LEAST six people were killed and 21 injured after two earthquakes struck a mountainous region of Peru, the country's civil defence chief said on Sunday.

The quakes, measuring magnitudes 5.1 and 3.7, hit on Saturday night in Chupaca province in the Junín region, about 300 km east of Lima, according to Peru's National Seismological Center post on X. The first quake struck at a depth of 24 km and the second at 18 km, center said.

The European-Mediterranean Seismological Centre earlier reported that the first earthquake had a magnitude of 5.6.



A destroyed house following the earthquake of magnitude 5.6 that struck Central Peru on Saturday. REUTERS

That deal aims to disarm Hezbollah, see a progressive Israeli troop withdrawal and set the stage for peaceful ties between the two countries.

A Lebanese official said Aoun would present Trump with a written proposal on how to decommission Hezbollah's massive arsenal.

The official said Aoun believes only Trump possesses the leverage needed to pressure Israel to withdraw its troops and help Lebanon restore its sovereignty.

Aoun, 62, became president last year just before Trump began his second term in the White House. The US welcomed Aoun's election.

Aoun is a Maronite Christian, as required by Lebanon's sectarian power-sharing system which stipulates the prime minister must be Sunni Muslim and the speaker of parliament must be Shi'ite Muslim.

A career soldier, Aoun was wounded twice and still carries a shrapnel wound. His rise reflected a major shift in the power balance in Lebanon, following a devastating Israeli offensive against Hezbollah in 2024 and the ousting of Hezbollah's Syrian ally President Bashar al-Assad — seismic events that weakened the group and its long-decisive hold over the state.

At his swearing-in ceremony, Aoun vowed to affirm "the state's right to a monopoly on arms". His presidency's first year was defined by a government bid to secure the disarmament of Hezbollah.

PROTECTION AGAINST BALLISTIC MISSILES IS A TOP PRIORITY: ZELENSKY

In major ballistic barrage, Russia hits Kyiv with 41 missiles, 18 shot down

7 killed in strikes on Kyiv, Kharkiv and Zaporizhzhia

Reuters
Kyiv, July 19

RUSSIA BATTERED Ukraine's capital Kyiv overnight with one of its biggest ballistic missile barrages of the war, killing at least one person and wounding 16 others, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Sunday.

A series of powerful explosions thundered across the darkened city in an attack that involved 41 missiles of various types, the air force said, ravaging buildings across several districts and sparking fires.

Residential buildings, warehouses, a supermarket and a dormitory were among the structures damaged, said Kyiv Mayor Vitali Klitschko, adding that three people were in a serious condition.

Separately on Sunday, four people were killed and 19 wounded in a strike on a postal depot outside the northeastern city of Kharkiv near the Russian border, the regional governor said. At one location in western Kyiv, emergency workers picked through smoldering debris and doused bombed-out apartments.

A resident who identified



A firefighting helicopter drops water over the site of a Russian missile strike in Kyiv on Sunday. REUTERS

himself as Vlad told Reuters he had been inside his apartment when a blast tore off his balcony door, which smashed him in the head. "My grandmother lives with me, and she can't walk. How could I run away and leave her behind?" he said.

Closer to the city centre, the strikes damaged a frequently targeted metro station and destroyed an underground pedestrian passage nearby, leaving a pile of rubble.

On Sunday evening, rescuers in the southeastern city of Zaporizhzhia were digging for survivors

after Russian bombs struck residential buildings there, authorities said, killing at least two people and wounding 14.

Russian forces have stepped up ballistic missile strikes on Kyiv and other cities in recent weeks as Ukraine struggles with a critical shortage of US-designed air defences.

Kyiv's military said it had shot down 18 missiles in Sunday's attack, which was aimed primarily at the Ukrainian capital. It added 108 out of 125 drones had been downed.

Last week, Zelenskyy said

the US and Ukraine have reached a political agreement on licences to make Patriot intercepter missiles. He added that he hoped production could begin by the end of the year.

But the mounting Russian attacks in the fifth year of Moscow's full-scale war are heaping pressure on Kyiv's foreign partners to accelerate supply of anti-ballistic defences.

"Protection against ballistic missiles is our constant and top priority right now," Zelenskyy said on X on Sunday.

Brazil's top court bars Milei from visiting Bolsonaro in house arrest

Sao Paulo: A Brazilian Supreme Court justice late Friday rejected a request from lawyers of former President Jair Bolsonaro for him to be visited under house arrest by Argentine President Javier Milei. The encounter was intended to take place in the capital, Brasilia, on July 25.

Justice Alexandre de Moraes, who also chaired the trial that sentenced Bolsonaro to prison for more than 27 years over a coup attempt, said in his decision that the former president has already been barred from any visits of a "political-electoral nature."

Milei is expected to attend the Liberal Party convention in Sao Paulo that will certify Sen. Flávio Bolsonaro. AP



China: Search On For Survivors

Rescuers search through the debris of a landslide in Chongqing, China on Sunday. The landslide buried multiple residential buildings, killing at least eight people and leaving 34 missing, as emergency crews continued rescue operations and authorities evacuated over a 1,100 residents . AP

ICE officers to wear body cams for vehicle stops

Reuters
July 19

IN THE wake of multiple fatal shootings involving US Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers, the agency will require its officers to record vehicle stops with at least one body camera, Trump administration border czar Tom Homan said Sunday.

"They exonerate more law enforcement than they convict, and I want officers to wear body cameras because I want the American people to see what the officers saw when they took that action," Homan said on "Fox & Friends Weekend" programme. Homan's comments come



Border czar Tom Homan during a press meet at White House. FILE

after federal immigration agents fatally shot two men six days apart during traffic stops in Texas and Maine earlier this month. There is no body-cam

era footage from ICE agents involved in those incidents.

In a separate interview on CBS' "Face the Nation" show, Homan said money for the cameras was held up during the partial government shutdown earlier this year. "The cameras have been purchased right now," Homan said. "They're training the trainer in deploying the cameras nationwide."

The agency's tactics came under renewed public scrutiny in recent days after an ICE officer on July 13 killed a driver from Colombia in the coastal Maine town of Biddeford, about 24 km south of Portland. Six days earlier, another ICE officer in Houston fatally shot a

Mexican national.

Homan said last week the agency would temporarily suspend most vehicle stops around the country to review procedures. Within 24 hours of Homan's comments, US President Donald Trump directed federal immigration agents to resume them.

The back-to-back shootings sparked protests in Maine, Houston and Boston and raised questions over ICE agents' lack of body cameras.

ICE launched a body-camera pilot program in 2024 and deployed cameras to officers in five cities: Baltimore, Buffalo, Detroit, Philadelphia, and Washington.

• BRIEFLY

MEXICO

Sheinbaum to attend World Cup final at Trump's invitation



Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum. FILE

MEXICAN PRESIDENT Claudia Sheinbaum said in a message on X that she would attend the World Cup final in New Jersey on Sunday at the invitation of US President Donald Trump along with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney. "I considered it politically important that the three countries hosting the World Cup are involved, and it is also a sign of the strong coordination and collaboration we have with the US government," Sheinbaum said. REUTERS

YEMEN

Tanzania-flagged ship hijacked by Somali pirates

A TANZANIA-flagged tanker was hijacked by suspected Somali pirates off Yemen's coast, security sources and local officials familiar with the incident said Sunday. The *MT ASANA*, a general tanker, was seized on Friday after departing Mukalla, Yemen, according to the sources. The vessel is now being held off the coast of Calaula in semiautonomous state of Puntland's Bari r. AP

GUYANA

67 rescued after ferry carrying 116 capsizes

A FERRY carrying 116 passengers and crew capsized in Guyana, with 67 people rescued so far, authorities said Sunday. The *MV Barima* was sailing from the capital, Georgetown, along the North Atlantic coast to Port Kaituma, said Guyanese Prime Minister Mark Phillips. A distress call prompted a search and rescue operation involving state and private boats. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

4 tourists killed, 1 injured as car falls into ravine

FOUR TOURISTS, including two women, were killed and another was injured as the car they were travelling in plunged into a ravine in northwest Pakistan on Sunday, an official said. The incident occurred in the Mansehra district of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, official said. According to initial reports, the driver lost control, causing the car to veer off the road and fall into the ravine. PTI

SRI LANKA

2 Indians held over cigarette smuggling

TWO INDIAN nationals were arrested at Bandaranaike International Airport in Sri Lanka after the authorities seized contraband Chinese-made cigarettes valued at Sri Lankan rupees 7.98 million from their possession, police said. The police recovered more than 50,000 cigarettes (266 cartons) from their possession, *Ada Derana* media portal said, adding both suspects were released on bail. PTI

Andrew and Tristan Tate arrested in US on new charges of rape, trafficking

Reuters
Los Angeles, July 19

SOCIAL MEDIA influencers Andrew and Tristan Tate have been arrested in United States after British authorities issued 38 new charges against the brothers, including rape, actual bodily harm and human trafficking.

Britain is seeking to extradite the brothers to face prosecution for both the new charges and pre-existing ones.

Britain's Crown Prosecution Service said it was bringing the further charges against Andrew, 39, and Tristan Tate, 38, after identifying four additional victims. The Tates face charges in Britain relating to alleged offences between July 2010 and August 2017.

It said Andrew Tate was being charged with seven further counts of rape, as well as charges relating to sex trafficking and indecent images of a child, while Tristan's charges included two counts of rape and



Andrew Tate (right) and Tristan Tate at the UFC 327 event at the Kaseya Center in Miami. FILE

three counts of arranging or facilitating trafficking for sexual exploitation. "We have decided to prosecute Andrew and Tristan Tate for further offences including rape, arranging or facilitating trafficking for sexual exploitation and offences relating to indecent images of a child," Malcolm McAffie, head of the Special Crime Division at the CPS, said in a statement.

The Tate brothers, who have dual US and British citizenship, have denied any wrongdoing.

• UNDER THE 'COOL BIZ' INITIATIVE, THE TOKYO GOVERNMENT ENCOURAGES WORKERS TO FORGO HEAVY SUITS IN FAVOUR OF POLO SHIRTS, LINEN TOPS AND SNEAKERS IN HOT WEATHER

Hot debate: Men in shorts are challenging Japan's buttoned-down office culture

Javier C Hernández & Hisako Ueno
Tokyo, July 19

FOR MORE than three decades, Noboru Watanabe wore the uniform of the Japanese salaryman: trousers, a starched shirt, a jacket and a necktie.

But last week, Watanabe, 53, an environmental official in Tokyo, ditched the outfit for the unimaginable: a T-shirt and a pair of khaki shorts. He was taking advantage of a new policy by the Tokyo government to allow its workers to wear shorts in the office, after successive summers of record-breaking heat.

"Everyone says I look younger," Watanabe said near

his desk on a recent afternoon. "I seem more approachable. I feel I am helping relax the whole office." The policy is the latest attempt by Japanese officials to persuade the country's millions of office workers to dress down in the summer to make office life more comfortable, reduce the use of air-conditioning and save energy.

Under the "Cool Biz" initiative, the government encourages workers to forgo heavy suits in favor of polo shirts, linen tops and sneakers in hot weather.

But shorts, newly allowed this summer, are a bridge too far for some. The policy has prompted debate in Japan — and inspired delicate conversa-

tions at the office about etiquette and how to deal with the sight of a colleague's hairy legs.

The Japanese news media has even coined a new term — sune-hara, or "leg-hair harassment" — to describe the sense of grievance some women feel when they are forced to observe their male co-workers' legs.

Ruai Sajiki, 23, an employee at the Tokyo government offices, acknowledged that seeing bare legs in a professional setting could be jarring for women. But she offered her blessing when Watanabe, her supervisor, asked if she minded if he wore shorts in the office.

"I've seen my own father's legs, so I'm personally comfort-



Tokyo Metropolitan Government officials wear shorts, T-shirts and sneakers at work as part of the Cool Biz initiative. NYT

able with it," she said. "It can't be helped that there are many opinions, and some women who feel resistance."

Some commentators argue that the policy, while officially applying to both men and women, is unfair. While men are

rarely judged for what they wear to work, women still face pressure to cover their legs with pantyhose, which are still common in Japan, or long skirts.

Atsuko Tamada, a professor of French literature at Chubu University in Japan and online commentator, said women were expected to spend considerable time and money on hair removal, foot care and apparel. "If men are now encouraged to wear shorts or sandals," she said, "should the same standards of appearance apply to them?"

"Cool Biz" was introduced by the country's Environment Ministry in 2005, and it has now spread to almost every workplace in Japan, with varying de-

grees of enthusiasm. The initiative coincided with commitments Japan made under the Kyoto Protocol, the 1997 international agreement to reduce greenhouse gases.

Yuriko Koike, who led the ministry at the time and was elected Tokyo's governor in 2016, said it was important because of rapidly rising temperatures and energy disruptions caused by the war in Iran.

"We have gradually run out of layers to remove," she said at a news conference in April, "reaching a point where we are down to wearing shorts."

In Japan, government workplaces set thermostats to 28 degrees Celsius, in line with na-

tional standards, from May through September. Last summer was the hottest on record, with temperatures about 4 degrees above historical averages. The Japanese Meteorological Agency this year introduced a new term for sweltering days above 104 degrees: *kokushobi*, or "cruelly hot" days.

The embrace of shorts has provided a boon to retailers. Some stores have started marketing shorts specifically for the office, with lightweight fabrics, formal styles and neutral colors.

Yofuku no Aoyama, a prominent Japanese retailer that sells business attire, is marketing a "Cool Biz" line of clothing including nylon shorts. NYT





Happening today

● **THE SUPREME COURT** will hear a batch of separate pleas seeking a fair and time-bound probe into the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

● **J&K'S RULING NATIONAL Conference** is scheduled to hold a protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi to push for the restoration of statehood. The party has invited political leaders from various other states to the proposed protest.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



NATION

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MP: KEN-BETWA PROTEST LEADER DETAINED, 150 OTHERS REMOVED

Donation ‘theft’: SIT’s final report ready, gives temple reform pointers

Anil Sasi
New Delhi, July 19

THE FINAL report of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) constituted by the Uttar Pradesh Government to probe allegations of donation theft at the Ram temple in Ayodhya points to clear evidence of administrative and supervisory lapses, even though the siphoning off of money was restricted to lower level staffers, and the scale limited to this group. According to sources, standard operating procedures with regard to the counting room operations were not followed,

NEET PAPER LEAK, TEMPLE ‘THEFT’ TO DOMINATE MONSOON SESSION

House set to be stormy: Opp walks out of all-party meet

Calling Trinamool rebels irks Opp, Rijiju says Govt’s duty to invite all

Vikas Pathak & Asad Rehman
New Delhi, July 19

THE MONSOON Session of Parliament is set to begin on Monday on a stormy note as the Opposition attempts to corner the government over issues such as exam paper leaks, the protest by activist Sonam Wangchuk, the alleged theft of donations in the Ram temple in Ayodhya, ethanol blending in fuel, and foreign policy.

The first indication of the tumult likely to affect the Session came on Sunday as the Opposition walked out of an all-party meeting for a few minutes in protest against the government’s decision to invite the rebel faction of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) that has merged with a little-known outfit called the Nationalist Citizens Party of India. The DMK and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which have not been attending meetings of the

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RELATED REPORTS, P 6



Union Ministers Arjun Ram Meghwal, Kiren Rijiju, Rajnath Singh, J P Nadda and L Murugan with Opposition MPs Jairam Ramesh, Gaurav Gogoi, Kodikunnil Suresh and Dharmendra Yadav, Sunday. PTI

E. EXPLAINED

Both sides prepared

While issues such as Ram temple ‘theft’ and the NEET paper leak have provided the Opposition ammunition to corner the government, the ruling NDA is bolstered by its strong victories in West Bengal and Assam, along with more support in LS and RS following the recent defections in TMC and Shiv Sena (UBT).

Govt set to bring Bill to criminalise insult to Vande Mataram

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 19

THE GOVERNMENT is all set to bring a Bill in the Rajya Sabha on the first day of the Monsoon Session that will make any obstruction or insult to the national song “Vande Mataram” a criminal offence — at par with the national anthem “Jana

Gana Mana”.

According to the List of Business for the Rajya Sabha for Monday, “The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026” is likely to be introduced by Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

The Bill proposes to amend the Prevention of Insults to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Rain fury kills 18 in J&K

At least 18 people were killed and several others reported missing after landslides and flash floods triggered by heavy rainfall in J&K’s border districts of Poonch and Rajouri, Sunday. PTI

REPORT, PAGE 7

Sindhu answers doubters with Japan Open crown: ‘Had tears in my eyes’

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 19

TOKYO HAS always given P V Sindhu a second wind.

The 31-year-old had not won a Super 750 grade title — the second highest tier after Super 1000s — since her World Championship win in 2019. And the murmurs had grown louder, casually nudging her to retire as

she had achieved plenty.

On Sunday, Sindhu shut out the ear-shattering cacophony of Japanese fans cheering on the home favourite — triple World Champion and World No 3 Akane Yamaguchi — to finally claim the Japan Open with a scorching 21-17, 21-17 win. The World No. 10 also turned down the decibel levels of those

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

GOVT MOVE TO SHIFT HIM TO HOSPITAL NOT ARBITRARY: COURT

HC rejects plea; Sonam wife says his fast will end if House takes up cause

‘He will end strike if leaders meet him, assure they will raise education accountability’

Sohini Ghosh & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 19

THE GOVERNMENT’S action to move Sonam Wangchuk from Jantar Mantar to Safdarjung hospital was “not arbitrary”, the Delhi High Court ruled in a special Sunday hearing, and said the activist “will cooperate” with doctors attending to him.

The court refused to grant any interim relief to Wangchuk’s wife Gitanjali J Angmo, who had asked for her husband’s immediate discharge so that he could be admitted to the private Medanta hospital.

Following the court’s order, Angmo told protesters at Jantar Mantar in the evening that Wangchuk would break his fast on Monday if political leaders assured him that the issue of accountability in education would be raised in Monsoon Session.

“If the MPs and leaders come to meet him tomorrow morning at Safdarjung hospital, and promise him that they would raise the issue of education and accountability in Parliament, only then will he break his fast tomorrow,” she said.

“But if we don’t get this accountability and this is not raised in Parliament, then he

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Sonam Wangchuk’s wife Gitanjali J Angmo with former J&K Chief Minister Farooq Abdullah outside the Safdarjung hospital in New Delhi, Sunday. ABHINAV SAHA MORE REPORTS, PAGE 4

Protesters set out for Parliament today; will not be allowed: Police

Alok Singh, Pragynesh, Drishti Jain & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 19

AS THE Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), led by its founder Abhijeet Dipke, and activists led by Sonam Wangchuk’s wife Gitanjali J Angmo called for a protest march to Parliament on Monday demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, Delhi Police is all set to stop them in their tracks.

CJP spokesperson Vijeta Dahiya told *The Indian Express* that the protesters were expected to leave Jantar Mantar

EDITORIAL PAGE

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IN SONAM, I DO NOT SEE A PROTESTER; I SEE AN EDUCATOR PULLED AWAY FROM HIS WORK

for Parliament around 9 am on Monday. Around one lakh people are expected to join the protest march, he said.

In a speech on Sunday, Dipke claimed the march would be the biggest in independent India, but appealed for a peaceful protest. “Sonam Wangchuk has told me that the protest will only be

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INTERIM DEAL CRUMBLES; HORMUZ TRAFFIC LARGELY STALLED

US strikes to ‘punish’ Iran after 2 of its soldiers killed; Tehran intensifies fire on Gulf states

Missiles launched at Jordan, risk of spillover into Israeli territory, warns Tel Aviv

Jon Gambrell & Sam Metz
Dubai, July 19

THE UNITED States launched more airstrikes at Iran on Sunday in response to the killing of US troops, and Iran fired missiles toward Jordan that risked widening the conflict into neighbouring Israel.

Step by step, the US and Iran have returned closer to all-out war as last month’s interim deal — meant to permanently end the fighting — has crumbled and shipping traffic in the Strait of Hormuz has largely stalled.

The US military said the la-



Kuwaiti PM Sheikh Ahmad Abdullah Al-Ahmad Al-Sabah visits a person injured in the Iranian attack, in Kuwait City, Sunday. REUTERS

test strikes targeted Iran’s paramilitary Revolutionary Guard — a retaliation for Friday’s killing of troops in Jordan. The campaign, now in its second week, has seen the US target bridges, water desalination plants and electrical facilities in Iran. Tehran has hit US-allied countries throughout West Asia.

Kuwait, Jordan and Bahrain

again activated air defences for incoming Iranian drones and missiles. Israel warned that missiles launched toward neighbouring Jordan could cause fire to spill over into Israeli territory for the first time in weeks.

The US Central Command said it hit “Iranian military coastal surveillance and air

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

SHOWPIECE OF MUSEUM IN RS 4,000-CRORE MARITIME COMPLEX NEAR LOTHAL

Coming soon in Gujarat: A life-size Harappan town with markets, dockyards

Divya A
New Delhi, July 19

VERY SOON, visitors to Lothal, one of the most prominent outposts of the Indus Valley Civilisation, will be able to get a feel of walking through Harappan streets, dockyards, markets and civic spaces.

Just a few minutes away from the archaeological site, about 80 km from Ahmedabad, architects are recreating parts of the historic town for a museum that will be part of the Rs 4,000-crore National Maritime Heritage Complex

(NMHC), whose first phase will be inaugurated within weeks.

Lothal is believed to have existed around 4,500 years ago, with excavations at the site revealing the world’s oldest known artificial dock, connected to an old course of the Sabarmati river.

According to officials, the first phase of the complex cost an estimated Rs 775 crore, and includes six museum galleries, a jetty walkway, and a display of maritime artefacts spanning ancient, medieval, colonial and modern times.

But the centrepiece of the

375-acre project, cleared by the Union Cabinet in 2024, remains the recreation of Lothal town.

“Rather than displaying history behind glass, we wanted people to physically walk through reconstructed Harappan streets, dockyards, markets, and civic spaces to understand how advanced these settlements were,” Karl Wadia, Principal Architect at Architect Hafeez Contractor, who is heading the project, told *The Indian Express*.

The firm was signed on to design the project by the Union Ministry of Ports and Shipping, the nodal ministry involved, with the total project cost



Graphic rendering of the upcoming National Maritime Heritage Complex in Lothal. ARCHITECT HAFEEZ CONTRACTOR

pegged at around Rs 4,000 crore, officials said. “The idea

was to create a world-class cultural and educational destina-

tion where visitors can experience India’s 4,500-year maritime history in an immersive, engaging way,” Wadia said.

The complex brings together museums, public landscapes, historic recreations, research facilities, eco-tourism and entertainment programming within a single integrated complex. “Alongside maritime artefacts from ancient, medieval, colonial, and modern periods, we are incorporating large-scale audio-visual projections, tactile exhibits, underwater-themed galleries, suspended ship installations, and digital storytelling environments that trace the

evolution of Indian seafaring traditions,” Wadia said.

Beyond the maritime museum, the complex will include a lighthouse museum, a 5D theatre, children’s galleries, waterfront promenades, public plazas, eco-resorts and themed attractions. “The maritime museum is really the heart of the entire NMHC project. At roughly 7 lakh sq ft, it will be the world’s largest maritime museum. The design is inspired by the archaeological remains of the ancient city of Lothal,” Wadia said.

The museum comprises monumental stone-clad forms raised on elevated plinths, rein-

terpreting the flood-resistant citadels of Harappan settlements. Two inclined forms at the top resemble ship hulls, inspired by the righting-lever principle used in naval engineering, according to the concept.

Inside, visitors will move through 14 interconnected galleries organised around a recreated Lothal settlement. The experience begins in an 18-metre-high arrival hall and unfolds through galleries arranged around a circulation spine, featuring large water tanks with staged displays, immersive projections, suspended

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Expanding Ties

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with Zanzibar President Hussein Ali Mwinyi in New Delhi, Sunday. The two sides discussed expanding cooperation in higher education, capacity building, water supply, health, AI, digital and other priority sectors. PTI

BHANIYAWALA-RISHIKESH ROAD

Plan to cut 4,000 trees on hold, took note of concerns, says Dhami

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, July 19

FOLLOWING PROTESTS and an FIR against dozens, the Uttarakhand government has suspended felling of trees for the Bhaniyawala-Rishikesh road in Dehradun.

The National Highways Authority of India project proposes to widen the 19-km stretch near the airport and had earmarked 4,369 trees for felling.

Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami said he has directed the Chief Secretary and officials to hold detailed consultations with all stakeholders, residents, public representatives, and experts before the resumption of tree-felling.

The NHAI had claimed that it deposited more than Rs 1.97 crore towards compensatory afforestation and its maintenance for the next ten years. And to facilitate compensatory afforestation, 40 hectares of non-forest land have been transferred by the State Government to the Forest Department for the development of new forests.

However, the episode has caused anger among the locals as the road passes through the Shivalik elephant reserve. People tried to disrupt the felling by mobilising in the area. On July 12, an FIR was registered against unknown individuals for allegedly “using criminal force to deter public servants from discharging their duty”.

As the momentum against the road-widening project increased, CM Dhami on Saturday announced that the tree felling will be suspended until a consensus is reached with all the stakeholders. “Over the past

few days, I have taken serious note of the concerns and suggestions expressed by numerous citizens, environmentalists, and residents regarding the Dehradun–Rishikesh Four/Six-Lane Project. This project is an important infrastructure initiative of the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI). Work on the project was being carried out in compliance with the directions of the Hon’ble High Court and after following all required statutory and environmental approvals and procedures,” he said.

Keeping wildlife conservation in mind, the project also provides for a 3.5-kilometre-long elephant underpass and special culverts for the movement of smaller wildlife, he claimed. “Development is essential for us, but no decision will be taken by ignoring public sentiment, the environment, or local interests,” the CM said.

A contempt petition filed before the High Court regarding a stay on the tree felling was dismissed.

Environmentalists say the road widening project will impact the eighth, ninth and tenth corridors in the Shivalik Elephant reserve and parts of the elephant corridors.

In 2020, amid talks of airport expansion, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEF) had asked the Uttarakhand government to consider avoiding sensitive areas of the Shivalik Elephant Reserve while exploring land suitable to use for the expansion of Dehradun’s Jolly Grant Airport. The government had attempted to denyotify the Shivalik Elephant reserve, which was stayed by the High Court.

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House set to be stormy

Opposition INDIA bloc, were among the parties that staged a walkout.

“The Opposition staged a walkout from the all-party meeting for a few minutes. This was a mark of protest against the decision of the Modi government to invite the NCPI, which is a parking place for 20 so-called ‘rebel’ TMC MPs, when a final decision is still pending with the Speaker,” Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh told *The Indian Express*.

Congress Deputy Leader in Lok Sabha, Gaurav Gogoi, said the Opposition had sought discussions on the “theft” of donations at the Ram temple, ethanol blending, student issues, and the situation in Manipur.

TMC MP and Mamata Banerjee loyalist Mahua Moitra, who represented the party at the meeting, said, “Today, the entire Opposition, including the Congress, the Samajwadi Party, the DMK, the JMM, the AAP, the National Conference, the Left parties, and the Shiv Sena (UBT), all walked out of the all-party meeting in protest of the so-called NCPI, which is an unrecognised party. The strength of the All India Trinamool Congress in the list provided by the table office is shown to be 28 members. These so-called 20 rebel MPs, their merger has not been approved by the Speaker.

The 20 disqualification petitions are still pending. We have registered our strong protest and walked out as a symbol of our protest.”

The group of TMC rebels — who in June petitioned Speaker Om Birla about their intention to merge with the NCPI and be recognised as a separate bloc — was represented by Sudip Bandyopadhyay and Kakoli Ghosh Das-tidar.

Samajwadi Party MP Dharmendra Yadav said the Opposition remains united despite the government’s attempts to “engineer defections”, while CPI(M)’s Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas, who represented the party at the meeting, told *The Indian Express* that the Opposition walked out because the “sanctity of the all-party meeting has been sullied as the Trinamool Congress split hasn’t been accepted or adjudicated by the Speaker”.

Hitting back at the Opposition, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said MPs cannot be ignored as they have petitioned the Speaker for recognition and separate seats. “The NCPI requested recognition from the Lok Sabha Speaker. How can you ignore them? It is the government’s duty to invite everyone,” he told reporters.

The Monsoon Session comes at a time when the contours of

the Opposition have changed. Since the two Houses of Parliament last convened in April, at least 37 MPs from four Opposition parties have shifted their allegiance to the BJP-led NDA.

This is likely to help the government shore up the numbers as it looks to reintroduce a legislative package on advancing the implementation of the Women’s Reservation Act and increase the strength of Parliament and state legislatures. Its efforts had failed the Lok Sabha test in April. The subsequent splits in Opposition parties have bolstered the ruling alliance’s numbers but added to the sense of acrimony and rancour in the Opposition ranks.

Sources in the government, however, said it would have to adopt a wait-and-watch approach before introducing the Bill, given the swiftly changing permutations and combinations in Parliament.

The move to break up Wangchuk’s hunger strike at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar and the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) proposed march to Parliament on Monday have also added an edge before the Parliament reconvenes. The Opposition has rallied behind Wangchuk, with Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, and NCP (SP) leader Sharad Pawar among those who have criticised the government.

By attempting to corner the government over the issue of paper leaks, the Opposition will hope to tap into discontent

among the urban “upper caste” and middle-class Hindus, who have been core BJP voters for decades.

The Treasury ranks have swelled even as the Opposition has appeared fragmented in recent days over the Delimitation Bill. While in April the Opposition had come together saying that the government’s aim was to change the electoral map of the country through delimitation — the Bills circulated did not mention a 50% increase in seats for all states despite verbal assurances from the Treasury benches — it has shown signs of disintegrating in the last few days. The government hopes that some of these parties will come around if the Bill incorporates the 50% pro-rata model.

On July 15, NCP (SP) MP Supriya Sule said her party would support the Bill if it expressly mentioned the 50% increase in seats for all states. The DMK, which stridently opposed delimitation last time, has become far more circumspect since losing power in Tamil Nadu and is keeping its cards close to its chest. Following DMK leader M K Stalin’s address to party MPs on July 16, the party’s organising secretary R S Bharathi said if the Centre incorporates their recommendations, “there is no need for the DMK to oppose it”.

However, the ruling party remains cautious. “We will have to see how things appear in Parliament and then introduce the Bills,” said a BJP insider.

Lothal

artefacts and underwater-themed installations.

The narrative spans ancient Harappan trade networks, Indian Ocean commerce, South Indian naval power, colonial encounters and modern Indian shipping, said design firm officials. At the centre of the museum will be an 80m x 80m living-history recreation of Lothal town. “We wanted visitors to engage with history spatially and experientially rather than simply viewing it as an exhibit,” the officials said.

Asked how the project engages with the legacy of the Indus Valley Civilisation, Wadia said Lothal’s history as a significant maritime site made it a natural choice as the project’s grounding site, being home to what is considered the world’s earliest known man-made dockyard. “Historically, Lothal connected the Indian subcontinent to Mesopotamia, Egypt, and West Asia through maritime trade, so origins of Indian seafaring culture are deeply rooted there. We wanted the project to reconnect contemporary audiences with the sophistication, innovation and global outlook of Indus Valley Civilisation,” he said.

Future phases will introduce eco-resorts, museum-hotels, state-sponsored cultural pavilions and themed attractions through public-private partnerships, officials said. India has signed MoUs with over a dozen countries for collaboration in developing NMHC as a global centre of maritime history, according to the Union Shipping and Ports Ministry.

successful if it is peaceful. There will be an even bigger crowd tomorrow (Monday), but that will also mean more responsibility for us,” he said. Dipke has started an indefinite fast since Saturday morning. He raised slogans of “Dharmendra Pradhan *istifa do*, Dharmendra Pradhan *tumko istifa dena hogi*” with scores joining him in chorus.

The police, on its part, have made elaborate arrangements to block the march. An officer said, “Since Section 163 remains in force in the New Delhi district, they cannot be allowed to hold the march.”

In a public advisory issued on Sunday, Delhi Police cautioned that no more than four people would be allowed to gather anywhere in the area

Parliament march

other than the designated protest site at Jantar Mantar. “Delhi Police... categorically clarifies that no permission has been sought or granted for any such protest march/procession,” the advisory said.

“Prohibitory order under Section 163 BNSS (erstwhile section 144 CrP) is in force in the New Delhi district. Accordingly, protest marches, processions, demonstrations and assemblies of five or more persons are strictly prohibited,” the advisory said.

By Sunday night, the area around Parliament had turned into a “fortress” of sorts. All roads and major installations in the area, including residences of ministers, were barricaded heavily and anti-riot vehicles

deployed. More than 12 companies of paramilitary personnel are on standby. Water cannons and jammers have already been positioned around Jantar Mantar, sources said.

Reacting to the police’s advisory, Dahiya said, “We have not asked for permission because we want to challenge these colonial laws where you have to ask for permission from the government to protest against the government, while the government can arbitrarily deny it.”

Meanwhile, the number of protesters at the site swelled to around 4,000 on Sunday — the highest so far in the 20-day-old stir.

On Sunday morning, Wangchuk sent a message from the hospital through his wife. It said, “India’s second freedom movement, march to Parliament — please make it a big success.”

The International Atomic Energy Agency said the site, in the “very early stages of construction,” contained no nuclear material.

Jordan’s military said it shot down several Iranian missiles. The country hosts major US bases and relies on US air-defence systems. The missiles did not cause casualties or damage, according to Jordan’s military.

Israel’s military said Iranian missiles launched toward the Jordanian port city of Aqaba just across the border could spill over, warning Israelis to expect the first air raid sirens in weeks. Eilat, the Israeli city that neighbors Aqaba, cited security officials as saying two interceptors were launched from its outskirts to prevent the fall of debris. “We

US strikes

defense facilities, maritime capabilities and missile and drone storage sites.” It said the attack was designed to degrade Iran’s ability to control the strait and “swiftly punish Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps forces.”

Footage released by the US military appeared to show strikes carried out by fighter jets and by Tomahawk cruise missiles launched from the sea. One target site appeared to be in a valley of a mountainous region.

Iran’s atomic energy agency said US strikes targeted the construction site of a planned nuclear power plant in the south-west, state television reported.

SIT report

entry and exit to areas where donations are handled, specified overalls for earmarked personnel, alongside specific accountability of those responsible for oversight.

The need to barrandom, outsourced personnel from handling donations and bringing in professional staff without any connections or allegiance to the top brass is likely among the suggestions, the sources said.

The panel’s widened remit of inquiry went beyond just probing the alleged theft to identifying systemic shortcomings in the temple’s donation management system, which is part of the final report. “Apart from cash

counting, a process has been instituted to record every artefact that’s come in, weigh it and make a register entry to ensure that this kind of a system stays in place for the future,” the source said.

“Institutional deficiencies enabled these operations to go on undetected over a period of time. But it needs to be kept in mind that this (Ayodhya temple) is just a two-year-old establishment, as compared to the administrators of the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams, who have decades of experience. The culpability here is prima facie restricted to the operational staff at the lower levels, but there can always be a question regarding why those kinds of people were hired and placed in these crucial operations. That is where the

Vande Mataram

National Honour Act, 1971, which makes desecration of or disrespect toward the country’s national symbols, including the national flag, the Constitution and the national anthem, a criminal offence, with a punishment of up to three years’ imprisonment as well as provisions for a fine.

The proposed move drew a sharp reaction from the CPM, with Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas calling for the Bill’s withdrawal, stating in a letter to Shah that it “risks unsettling a delicate constitutional balance founded upon pluralism, liberty of conscience and voluntary patriotism”.

According to a copy of the proposed legislation circulated among MPs, the Bill seeks to substitute the existing Section 3 of the 1971 Act to effectively bring “Vande Mataram” at par with “*Jana Gana Mana*” with regard to alleged acts of preven-

tion or disturbance against singing them, with the same penal provisions — three years, a fine, or both.

“Whoever, intentionally — (a) prevents the singing of the National Anthem or the National Song; or (b) causes disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing, shall be punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to three years, or with fine, or with both,” the Bill states.

Last year, a special discussion was held in both Houses in December to mark the 150th anniversary of the na-

rested and remanded to judicial custody. “There was administrative negligence in hiring some of these people and putting them in charge of the counting-room operations. But does the scope of these thefts go beyond these lower level people? There isn’t much evidence of that,” the source said.

What is undeniable, though, is how this motley group was hired in the first place, and put in charge of operations, without adequate supervisory checks or clearly laid down procedures, the source said. There is an element of sycophancy in the selection of these people, which now needs to be addressed by hiring only qualified professionals to crucial roles, the source added.

tional song, with sittings taking place over four days during the Winter Session.

During the debate, the BJP-led NDA Government locked horns with the Opposition, mainly the Congress. PM Narendra Modi accused the Congress of having truncated the song to appease the Muslim League and Mohammad Ali Jinnah, adding that omitting important stanzas had put the country on the path of “appeasement politics” that ultimately led to Partition.

In response, Congress leader and Wayanad Lok Sabha

Wangchuk

will not break his fast,” she said.

Wangchuk had gone on an indefinite hunger strike on June 28 as part of the protest by the activist youth platform Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) to demand the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan for the leak of the May 3 NEET-UG question paper.

Police picked him up from the protest site on Saturday morning, the 21st day of the fast, invoking an order passed by the High Court earlier in the week, and “on expert medical advice due to the [activist’s] deteriorating health condition”.

After a hearing that lasted for almost 40 minutes on Sunday afternoon, Justice Mini Pushkarna of the High Court observed that “it cannot be said that any force is being used against Mr Wangchuk, or his bodily autonomy is being violated in any manner”, since only oral interventions have been administered so far without his consent, which were deemed to be necessary in light of his “deteriorating” medical condition.

Wangchuk has been refusing intravenous administration of medical intervention in hospital.

Dr Akshay Kumar, additional professor in the department of emergency medicine at AIIMS who has joined the Safdarjung team, told the court that Wangchuk “needs to take vitamins” starting with thymine, but “we cannot give him that since he is not allowing IV (intravenous) access.”

Justice Pushkarna recorded in her order that Wangchuk “will cooperate with doctors in administering any medical intervention as doctors feel”.

While refusing Wangchuk’s request for a transfer to Medanta, the court ordered that Safdarjung hospital shall share his medical records with his family. Angmo had alleged that the hospital was not providing her detailed reports of the medical tests being conducted on her husband.

The court noted that Wangchuk was not in detention and was a free citizen. However, considering that he “on his own volition did not check himself into

any [hospital] facility in view of his deteriorating condition, the government was within its rights to take such action”.

Angmo, who was represented by senior advocate Kapil Sibal, was herself present in the courtroom, and told the court that the family would take Wangchuk’s “discharge against medical advice”.

Additional Solicitor General (ASG) Chetan Sharma, representing the government along with Central government counsel Ashish Dixit, vehemently resisted Angmo’s request. “These are extraordinary circumstances... The government has to be extra careful... Whatever happens to him will have consequences...,” Sharma said.

The court did not make any observation on Angmo’s complaint that the family was “constantly” under police surveillance inside the hospital, including in the room where Wangchuk has been kept, and that police were “eavesdropping” on conversations.

On July 16, the Delhi HC had directed the Centre to ensure that Wangchuk’s health was monitored on a daily basis by government doctors, and to “intervene depending on the medical report”.

Angmo alleged in her petition that police took “undue advantage” of the July 16 order “as a colourable pretext” to remove Wangchuk from Jantar Mantar “without [his] free and informed consent”. She said that at the hospital, Wangchuk had been “kept in a solitary manner, ostensibly under the pretext of medical treatment”. While she had access to her husband, the activist’s “access to his lawyer and his treating doctors was arbitrarily denied, in complete disregard of his rights and those of his family”.

Soon after the court’s order, Angmo told reporters that the proposed march to Parliament would go ahead as scheduled on Monday, and that she would represent her husband.

She alleged that Wangchuk had been removed not out of concern for his health. “They were simply afraid that if Sonam set out on his march, hundreds of thousands of people would join him, not just in Delhi, but across the entire country,” she said.

Sindhu

Indians who had gracefully asked her to leave her stomping ground. Sindhu’s statement win said she’s going nowhere.

After beating her certified nemesis, Sindhu fell to the floor, and shed tears behind her cupped face. “I had tears in my eyes because it was important for me to win,” she said after the title triumph. “I was really really focusing hard and working hard on myself. I kept believing I could do it. Lot of people were like, what’s happening? Is it (career) done? Or whatever it is. But still, I believed in myself and my family and my coaches supported me.”

For some time now, the top step of the podium had seemed out of reach for Sindhu. At the 2021 Tokyo Olympics, after being thrashed in the semifinals by Tai Tzu-ying, she had regrouped to beat He Bingjiao and claim bronze. But Sindhu hadn’t beaten Yamaguchi in a completed match since May 2022. Her last title had been a lowly Super 300, 19 months ago. In fact, this was only her third Super750 plus title of her career, given she has more Olympic and World medals than big triumphs on the circuit.

Sindhu stressed the importance of winning a final. “Playing in the final is one thing. But to win, stand on the podium, win that gold is a different thing altogether,” she said.

Against Yamaguchi, Sindhu deployed all her power, strength and speed as well as defensive stubbornness. Yamaguchi was heart-broken after the loss. “I am so so upset, I tried to make points from my defence, but her attack

was very good. She was so aggressive, the smash so strong...,” the Japanese player said, walking away dejected as the home crowd went silent.

It took Indonesian coach Irawansyah to drag Sindhu out of the defensive zone she had got into after the 2019 world title. Six coaches in the last seven years had come and gone, unable to rewind her attacking instinct completely.

While accepting wishes from celebrities and politicians, Sindhu did not forget to thank her husband Venkata Datta Sai, a sports geek, data specialist and first cheerleader who, she tweeted, had taken on the onerous task of “rebuilding her team”.

Coach Irawansyah made tactical changes — smoothing her movement, sharpening her defence-to-offence transitions, using the net for follow-up kills, activating the drop shots to ease over-reliance on smashes — to give her confidence.

Sindhu also brought in fitness maestro Wayne Lombard, a South African who watched the final on a stream, from his hospital bed while recovering from surgery. The biokinetics PhD holder has worked with India’s boxing and hockey teams. For Sindhu, he designed programmes to primarily increase her strength.

Sindhu also shared that she had worked on staying calm — probably the main reason why previous finals had been fluffed when she got agitated. “Sometimes when leading you want to finish rallies quicker, you tend to make simple unforced errors. But the coach said, ‘It’s OK, focus on the next point’. It let go of what happened, and focused on the next point. That made a difference,” she said.

According to the amendment Bill’s statement of objectives, there is at present no specific legal provision to prevent insults to the singing of “Vande Mataram”.

“Therefore, in order to prohibit any person from intentionally preventing the singing of the National Song (Vande Mataram) or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing, it is proposed to amend Section 3 of the said Act to include the National Song also within its ambit, so as to make such acts punishable,” the objectives state.

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A DAY AFTER ACTIVIST SONAM WANGCHUK'S 20-DAY HUNGER STRIKE WAS DISRUPTED BY POLICE: SUPPORT POURS IN; SECURITY TIGHTER ACROSS CAPITAL



(From left) People throng the protest site on Sunday morning; Abhijeet Dipke at Jantar Mantar; security personnel deployed outside Safdarjung Hospital where Sonam Wangchuk is admitted. ABHINAV SAHA

Delhi turns a fortress ahead of march

Pragnesh & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 19

RIOT CONTROL vehicles, barricades, deployment of over 1,200 Delhi Police personnel across VIP areas and borders of the Capital — Delhi looked like a fortress on Sunday while protesters led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) at a packed Jantar Matar prepared for a march towards Parliament on Monday.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, addressing the crowd which only grew bigger, said that Monday's march will be the biggest the Independent India has seen. "Sonam Wangchuk has told me that the protest will only be successful if it is peaceful. There will be an even bigger crowd tomorrow (Monday), but that will also mean more responsibility for us," he said.

With banners, slogans and the swelling crowd, Jantar Mantar on Sunday night had little space to even walk. Footpaths were lined with tents housing students who were on hunger strike since a day or weeks.

The protestors answered the extremely humid air with



makeshift fans made out of cardboard or scraps of paper found on the ground.

Police presence rose. Officers in batches were seen on both sides of the stage — not a common sight at the site so far.

CJP spokesperson Vijeta Dahiya told *The Indian Express* that they were expecting around one lakh people to join

Monday's march. "We will leave for Parliament around 9 am," he said, adding that some might stay back at the protest site "to protect it". Asked if the Congress will join the march, Dahiya said that he was not sure, but that the CJP has asked all political parties to join.

Meanwhile, on Sunday night, the area around the en-

trance of Parliament was visibly void of any public movement.

A police officer deployed at the protest site said the protesters won't be allowed to even cross the Parliament Street police station — metres away from the protest site — let alone Parliament.

Barricades, meanwhile,



Security personnel and (left) protesters at the site on Sunday night. TASHI TOBGYAL

blocked multiple entry points of roads around the South Avenue Marg.

Policemen and reserve forces, battalions of the paramilitary forces will stand on guard around Jantar Mantar, Parliament, roads leading to them and the border areas of the Capital on Monday, sources told *The Indian Express*. Around three ACP-rank officers, five-six inspectors and 50-100 personnel from the Delhi Police Crime Branch will monitor high-security areas.

Police officers from local police stations will man the borders of Delhi with Uttar Pradesh and Haryana, as the CJP's

call for the march is expected to see participation from farmer organisations as well.

Delhi Police has declared that no permission was sought by the CJP to hold the protest march and imposed prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS.

"As the Monsoon Session of Parliament is commencing from July 20, strict security arrangements are in place to ensure public safety, security of protectees, and the protection of vital government installations," Deputy Commissioner of Police (New Delhi) Sachin Sharma said.

"Any person violating prohibitory orders shall be liable for prosecution under Section 223 BNS and other applicable provisions of law. The Delhi Police appeals to all citizens to respect the law, refrain from participating in any unauthorised gathering or march," the DCP also said.

The CJP-led protest saw a steady rise in the number of participants after activist Sonam Wangchuk's 20-day long hunger strike was disrupted with the police taking him to Safdarjung Hospital on Saturday.

Mohammad Deepak says 'dark time for the country'

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, July 19

people who are not coming. They don't know our history of struggles," he said. Gupta said he planned to stay overnight at Jantar Mantar.

Advocate Ramanand Sagar (34) and Shriti Sagar (27), who are married, took an overnight train from Allahabad and reached the protest site after leaving their bags at the cloakroom at the railway station. They had intended to join the march to Parliament, and were more fuelled to make the journey after police took Wangchuk away, they said.

"I have seen the Anna Hazare andolan (for the Lokpal Bill in 2011), Ramanand Sagar said. "This is a historic movement of the youth. I am happy that the youth of this country have awakened. Many of us from Allahabad will be marching tomorrow morning, and I hope we are not stopped by police. I also hope that Dharmendra Pradhan resigns," he said.

Shriti, who said she had come to Delhi for the first time, said that it was important to ensure that change was brought about, and that future generations did not have to lead similar protests. "*Hamare aane waale generations yahaan par na khade hon, bas*," she said.

It was also important to ensure that religion was not used to divide the protesters, Shriti said. She was holding a poster that said, "Remove the lenses of religion, all of India is in danger."

Sonam's wife: Can govt intervene in our right to choose own treatment?

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, July 19

SOON AFTER the Delhi High Court refused to provide any interim relief to immediately discharge activist Sonam Wangchuk from the government-run Safdarjung Hospital, his wife Gitanjali J Angmo questioned if a citizen of this country has the right to choose their own treatment.

Wangchuk was forcibly removed by the Delhi Police from Jantar Mantar on day 20 of his indefinite hunger strike.

"Yesterday (July 18) we were informed that his potassium was 2.9, which is life-threatening, but we were never given the reports. Around 2:30 am on Sunday, when we were finally shown his reports, his potassium levels were 3.6, which is normal. So we have been misguided, thus we want him to be shifted out of Safdarjung Hospital," she said.

She raised a larger question: "Does a citizen of this country not have the right to choose their own treatment — which doctor they want to consult, which hospital they want to be admitted to — and can the government intervene in that choice?"

Angmo further added, "If the government was really worried about his health, why did they not bring a team of doctors to conduct the tests at Jantar Mantar itself, and only move him to a hospital if there was a genuine risk? The way he was removed from there is illegal. So the question I want to ask is — is Bharat really a democracy?"

As the High Courts order did not provide immediate relief to Wangchuk, Angmo said, "We will file an appeal before a divisional bench tomorrow (July 20)."

On the health updates being shared with the family, she told *The Indian Express*, "When Dr DK and Dr Lamba were monitoring him, for the past 20 days, we used to get his health updates every day. But since Wangchuk has been brought here (Safdarjung Hospital), there have been no regular updates given to us. His exact vitals are not being shared with us transparently or on time. Owing to these lapses, we wanted to move him to a hospital that we trust, and which can provide all these facilities smoothly."

She likened the situation to a "detention without any formal order," drawing a parallel to Wangchuk's 170-day detention in Jodhpur. Angmo said around "30 to 40 police personnel remained constantly pres-



Gitanjali J Angmo outside Safdarjung Hospital on Sunday.

● WANGCHUK STABLE

● Activist Sonam Wangchuk was stable on Sunday but needed round-the-clock medical care and monitoring, said Dr Prof. Manisha Thakur, HOD, Medicine at Safdarjung Hospital.

● Wangchuk's vital parameters were stable and his blood parameters had shown marginal improvement, she said.

ent on their floor, keeping vigil over them, and that she was not permitted to carry her phone inside, while Wangchuk himself had been denied even his Samsung tablet, which he uses to study". She added that a police constable was sometimes present in the room while she spoke with Wangchuk.

On the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) planned march to Parliament from Jantar Mantar on July 20, she said, "The government moved Sonam to a government hospital because they knew the movement would grow much bigger with him at Jantar Mantar. But they did not realise the movement would get double the support after they illegally detained him. Sonam has urged everyone to carry out the march peacefully. Education is the foundation of any country's development. If we want to become Vishwa Guru, we have to work for the education of our children. The education system, which has been broken, needs to be fixed for our country to reap its demographic dividend, and to produce innovators and entrepreneurs."

She went on to say, "If they had allowed Sonam to be shifted to Medanta Hospital, he would have joined the protest, but the government did not allow that. So I will represent Sonam at the march tomorrow (July 20)."

Angmo also issued an advisory to participants of the march, urging them "to be aware of nefarious elements who want to jeopardise the protest, and to remain peaceful at all times".



The crowd grew thicker by the evening. TASHI TOBGYAL

● G BLOCK MARKET'S OLD HARDWARE SHOPS ARE GIVING WAY TO PIZZA JOINTS, CAFES AND COCKTAIL BARS

Cafes everywhere, fading hardware stores: How Hauz Khas G Block market changed

Reva Thakkar & Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, July 19

G BLOCK in Hauz Khas was one of Delhi's go-to markets for hardware, paint, steel and sanitary ware for decades. Today, as you walk in from Aurobindo Marg, the first thing that greets you is a building with a restaurant on every floor: Arisii serving coastal food on the ground floor, Savage, a sandwich shop — which turns into the club Painkiller after 7 pm — on the first, and Bihari restaurant Potbelly on the second.

Shopkeepers estimate that the 16 hardware and sanitary stores that once defined the market, many dating back to

the 1950s, have shrunk to just four. In their place, at least a dozen restaurants and cafés have opened in under two years, with more on the way.

G Block has now emerged as one of South Delhi's newest dining destinations. While restaurateurs see opportunity, the shift has left long-time traders struggling to survive and residents grappling with traffic, noise and parking woes.

For Amarjeet Singh Khurana (56), the ground floor of his G-15 building was a grocery store his father opened before he was

born, one he ran himself for 26 years after taking over in the 1990s. Last December, he leased it out. Today it's NYNY, a pizza joint. Khurana lives on the floor above it, while the second floor is occupied by a commercial office. "Business has been slow since the rise of e-commerce platforms. I was managing the space alone, so I decided to retire," he says.

For the new arrivals, it's been a win-win: a central location with affordable rent.

Amol Kumar (39), founder of NYNY, says he looked at the G-15 space once before 2025 started and passed on it. "It was quite dirty,"



G Block has now emerged as a prime dining destination. ABHINAV SAHA

he says, but eight months later, his realtor brought him back for a second look. "I saw promise... a lot more restaurants were up and running." Next door, Public Supply opened about nine

months ago. Owner Ayush Gulati (29), who returned after spending years in London, says he wanted to introduce "food that feels good to have". He believes the clustering of restaur-

ants has accelerated the market's transformation. "When one big player enters, other big players also come up and the whole market brightens up," he says.

Casa Pasta Bar, which opened in November 2024, was among the first restaurants to bet on G Block. "Hauz Khas offered a central location, with easy access to 70% of South Delhi areas. It also presented a good opportunity in terms of rental value," says Jessica Solomon, brand marketer of Casa.

Since then, their business has grown roughly 20%, with weekend numbers running about 50% higher than weekdays. Most restaurant owners in the market told *The Indian Ex-*

press they expect the last of the hardware shops to be replaced within the next year or two.

"Any customer that came in knew they'd get everything related to hardware here. New customers don't come in anymore," says Mani, owner of Sawan Paints and Electrical. Arun Lakhotia (55), whose grandfather and father started Laxmi Steel Sanitary and Hardware Store in 1965, watched the market empty out from the inside. "About 10 years ago, there were 16 shops... it has now become an eating hub."

Lalit Parakh (69), a jeweller who has lived in B1 for nearly 40 years, says, "The hardware shops didn't require rear entrances, so it was mostly sealed.

But after the restaurants came in, the back entrances were opened, facing our houses." He and other residents say exhaust ducts release fumes into the colony and generate noise well into the night.

Saurabh Taneja of Shiv Sanitary Store has been in the market for 52 years — long enough to remember when rents were Rs 400-500 a month, and leases that stretched past three decades. "Most showrooms [restaurants] here are now paying Rs 3.5-4 lakh for rent a month." By his estimate, property rates in the market have risen roughly two-and-a-half times in the last two-three years. After Covid pandemic, 80% of businesses changed or shut down," he adds.



India-Colombia

DEEPEN

STRATEGIC RELATIONS

With Focus on Trade, Technology and Cultural Cooperation





India and Colombia are looking to inject fresh momentum into their bilateral relationship following the election of Colombia's new President, Abelardo de la Espriella, and a series of high-level diplomatic engagements aimed at broadening cooperation beyond trade.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi was among the first world leaders to congratulate President De la Espriella, describing Colombia as “a close friend” whose partnership with India has steadily expanded over the years. In his message, Modi said he looked forward to working with the Colombian leader to deepen bilateral ties during his tenure.

The exchange comes as economic engagement between the two countries continues to gather pace. Bilateral trade touched around \$4.7 billion in 2025-26, driven by Indian exports of automobiles, pharmaceuticals, chemicals and engineering goods, while Colombia remained a key supplier of crude oil, coal and precious stones.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi was among the first world leaders to congratulate President De la Espriella, describing Colombia as “a close friend” whose partnership with India has steadily expanded

The relationship received another boost in August 2025 with the visit of P. Kumaran, former Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs, to Bogota. During meetings

with senior Colombian ministers, both sides discussed cooperation in digital innovation, cybersecurity, health, mining, trade facilitation and multilateral cooperation. Indian investment in the country has also exceeded \$1 billion mainly in the energy and information technology sectors.

They also discussed ways to create more opportunities for businesses, improve market access and increase collaboration in emerging sectors such as startups and digital public infrastructure. Interactions with industry representatives and policy experts suggest that there was growing interest on both sides in expanding commercial partnerships.

Beyond economic ties, India and Colombia are also working to deepen cultural and people-to-people connections. India will be the **Guest of Honour** at the **Bogotá International Book Fair 2026**, a milestone expected to strengthen literary exchanges, cultural collaboration and broader public engagement between the two countries.

COLOMBIA

STRENGTHENS INDIA'S ENERGY SECURITY



DIVERSIFIED SUPPLY

ENERGY PARTNERSHIP

STRONGER TOMORROW

AS WEST ASIA TENSIONS RESHAPE IMPORT STRATEGY

RELIABLE SUPPLIES

RESILIENT FUTURE

STRATEGIC PARTNERS



COLOMBIAN LNG
A RELIABLE SOURCE FOR A GROWING INDIA

SECURING ENERGY
POWERING GROWTH
FUELLING THE FUTURE

South American nation Colombia is steadily becoming an important pillar of India's energy diversification strategy as prolonged geopolitical uncertainty in West Asia prompts New Delhi to widen its network of reliable fuel suppliers.

The shift has gathered pace with Indian Oil Corporation's first bulk purchase of Colombia's Castilla crude under a long-standing supply arrangement with state-owned Ecopetrol. The initial cargo of around two million barrels signals India's growing willingness to source crude from newer markets as concerns over disruptions to key shipping routes, including the Strait of Hormuz, continue to influence global energy trade.

The search for alternative suppliers has picked up pace for India amid the complex procurement decisions that refiners are facing due to sanctions on Russian energy exports and instability in West Asia.

The partnership is not solely about fuel trade, long-term investments underpin the cooperation. ONGC Videsh is still

maintaining upstream interests in Colombia through joint ventures giving India access to hydrocarbon assets and strengthening bilateral energy cooperation.

Colombia is also a major supplier of thermal coal, adding an extra layer of security of supply as India heads into an era of increased electricity needs. The diversified supply has helped insulate the country from sudden shocks in global fuel markets.

While it has been pushing for a gradual exit from fossil fuels, it has continued to deepen energy ties with India on the basis of shared economic interests. For New Delhi, deepening ties with suppliers across Latin America is part of a larger effort to expand Strategic Petroleum Reserves and cut over-dependence on any one region. As global energy markets remain vulnerable to geopolitical shocks, India's engagement with Colombia is a case in point of an overarching strategy of creating a more resilient, diversified and secure energy supply chain.

THE FIFA WORLD CUP

COLOMBIA 2026

COLOMBIA HOSTING VISION

TOWARDS THE 100TH ANNIVERSARY

UNITED FAN EXPERIENCE

MODERN INFRASTRUCTURE

CULTURAL CELEBRATION

ROAD TO 2030

THE CENTENARY JOURNEY

LEGACY OF 100 YEARS

LEGACY OF 100 YEARS

A CENTURY OF PASSION

FORWARD TO 2030

DEVELOPING TOMORROW'S TALENT

BUILDING THE NEXT CHAPTER

Colombian soccer fans had another opportunity to dream big at the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

Every match was filled with hope, excitement and lots of emotion. The team played with confidence, with the fighting spirit that has made Colombia one of the most respected soccer nations in South America. Despite stronger opposition the players never gave up and their fighting spirit earned them respect from fans around the world. One of the Colombian team's

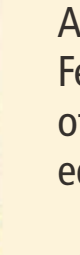
Colombia's performance at the FIFA World Cup 2026 reminded football fans why the nation is respected on the world stage. As the focus turns towards the 2030 World Cup, excitement is building for a tournament that will also celebrate football's rich South American heritage.

best qualities was their mix of youth and experience. It was a joy to watch the Colombian players show their discipline, teamwork and attacking style.

Every World Cup has its moments of glory and despair but the tournament was a great learning opportunity for Colombia as they move forward.

Now, football fans are already looking ahead to the 2030 FIFA World Cup. It will be a special edition because it celebrates 100 years since the first World Cup was played in Uruguay. While Spain, Portugal, and Morocco will host most of the matches, South America will play an important role by staging the opening celebration games. For Colombia, the goal remains clear: keep improving, qualify again, and continue making the country proud on football's biggest stage.

INDIAN TWO-WHEELERS GAIN TRACTION IN COLOMBIA



Reliability, Affordability, Performance

Powering Colombia's Mobility Revolution

Indian Two-Wheelers

Powering Colombia's Mobility Revolution

Colombia's growing motorcycle market is opening new opportunities for India's two-wheeler exporters, driven by demand for affordable, fuel-efficient and reliable mobility. The country registered over 1.1 million new motorcycles in 2025, making it one of Latin

America's largest markets. Industry bodies ANDI and Fenalco describe motorcycles as an "essential means of transport", particularly for improving access to jobs, education and services beyond major cities.

Similar consumer preferences for affordability, efficiency and reliability have helped Indian two-wheeler exporters deepen their presence through exports and local partnerships. The sector is also adding momentum to India-Colombia economic ties, expanding cooperation in manufacturing, mobility solutions and technology.

According to the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), India exported a record 4.3 million two-wheelers in 2025, with Latin America emerging as a growing destination. S&P Global Mobility expects demand for affordable personal transport to remain resilient across emerging markets, supporting India's automotive expansion in the region.



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New Delhi



Atri Mitra
Kolkata, July 19

THIS WAS one case of alleged horsetrading where the cart came before the horse. Now, the horse is catching up.

A month after the little-known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) surfaced as the new home of rebel TMC MPs, becoming in the process the fourth-largest party in Parliament, where it is set to make its debut on Monday, it has got a professionally managed social media presence, a self-claimed network of grassroots workers, and phone calls “by the hundreds” seeking to join it. A president ushered in the wake of the NCPI’s newfound fame, whom no one even within the party knew, Jyotiprakash Chatterji, has also made an appearance.

The surprises end there. Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Chatterji, says that yes, the NCPI’s loyalties — or that of the rebel TMC MPs — lie firmly with



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Union Ministers Kiren Rijiju, Arjun Ram Meghwal and L Murugan during a meeting of the Business Advisory Committee in New Delhi on Sunday. LOK SABHA SECRETARIAT

the BJP-led NDA. “We are committed to strengthening the NDA. Whatever Bill or proposal the NDA brings in Parliament, our MPs will support them.”

Chatterji also cites an old association with BJP, as its youth leader in South Kolkata and a spokesperson. On why he remained faceless so far (literally,

with the NCPI putting up only a silhouette when announcing his name for the post on June 16), Chatterji says: “Whenever the NDA leadership asks, I will surely come out and brief the media. Before that, we have to make a party office in Kolkata and rework our organisational structure.”

Shewly Kundu, Chatterji’s predecessor as NCPI president, says: “We have submitted details of our newly constituted apex committee to the EC as well as shared our symbol (pen with seven rays). We are expecting the EC to clear the same very soon.” An advocate, the 39-year-old practises in the Calcutta High Court.

Her husband and NCPI general secretary Uttiya Kundu, 52, sits at the almost-hidden building in Hatgacha, Howrah, which is the party’s “main office”. Not for long, says Uttiya. Former TMC leader and NCPI parliamentary party head, Sudip Bandyopadhyay, is searching for “a suitable place in Kolkata where our headquarters can shift”, he says. “We were with NDA when we formed the party, and remain an ally of NDA. Anyone not ready to support NDA, has no place in our party,” Uttiya says.

Before that, NCPI’s only electoral record was contesting two seats in 2022 Assembly

polls in Tripura and 11 in 2023 West Bengal panchayat elections, registering barely a blip.

However, Uttiya insists, “We have a huge organisation already. Thousands of people in Bengal and Tripura are our members. Now, after getting 20 MPs, we have got recognition countrywide. All the MPs will be absorbed in our apex committee as per our rules.”

Uttiya is open about having met top leaders of BJP in Delhi before TMC rebel MPs joined NCPI. “I was also in touch with state BJP leaders. We passed a resolution in our party of merger with the rebel TMC MPs before they joined,” he claims.

He admits NCPI old-timers haven’t really had much face time with new joiners. “We are in contact with each other but next week probably we will sit and decide our future plan of action. We are getting a huge number of phone calls, many are eager to join us. But, we are yet to decide who will be included.”

Jail for ‘illegal’ live-in: MP Cabinet clears UCC draft Bill

Set to be introduced in Assembly during Monsoon Session

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 19

THE MADHYA Pradesh Cabinet on Sunday approved the draft Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill, proposing a common civil law for all residents that bans polygamy, criminalises practices such as triple talaq and provides for potential imprisonment of couples in live-in relationships if they don’t declare their status.

The draft legislation is expected to be introduced in the Assembly during the Monsoon Session beginning Monday.

According to the Bill, couples in a live-in relationship will be legally required to file a “declaration of live-in relationship” with the registrar within one month of starting to live together. If a partner is under 21, information about the “start and end of the live-in relationship” will be sent to their parents/guardians”. The registrar will also send this record to the local police station.

The penalties proposed in the Bill include three months’ imprisonment or a fine of Rs 10,000 for not registering the declaration within a month. Giving false information can attract three months’ imprisonment and a fine of Rs 25,000, and failing to file the declaration even after a registrar’s notice can attract up to 6 months’ imprisonment and a fine of Rs 25,000.

The Bill has provisions to

consider children born of a live-in relationship to have full inheritance rights. If the male partner in the relationship deserts the woman, she “can claim maintenance through a competent court just as a legal wife would,” as per the Bill.

The code makes monogamy the norm across all communities. A person may be married to only one living spouse at a time as per the Bill. The minimum age for marriage is fixed at 21 years for men and 18 years for women. Marriages involving invalid consent and prohibited relationships (unless permitted by custom) are banned.

Oral divorce or decisions by informal panchayats are “declared entirely illegal”. A marriage can now be dissolved only on the clear, statutory grounds specified in law. “Accepting, promoting, or forcing degrading or humiliating conditions such as ‘nikah halala’ for remarriage to the same spouse after divorce will be treated as a punishable criminal offence,” the Bill stated.

Keeping in mind the sizeable population of ST, the Bill proposes that the law would not apply to STs covered under Articles 342 and 366(25) of the Constitution (such as Bhil, Gond, Korku, Baiga, Sahariya and Bhamar).

The Bill also proposes to ban the word illegitimate and give every child equal legal status. Sons and daughters are given equal rights to inherit property, regardless of marital status. Widows and widowers will also be treated equally in the deceased’s property.

Yadav had formed a committee headed by retired Supreme Court judge Justice Ranjana Desai to prepare the draft.

‘Delimitation Bill the same ... we hope those who voted against it do so again’

THE OPPOSITION’S move to walk out of the all-party meeting on Sunday over the government inviting “rebel TMC” faction is being seen as a precursor to the Monsoon Session of Parliament, starting on Monday.

Despite ending the previous session on a high by defeating Bills related to delimitation and women’s reservation in the Lok Sabha, the Opposition sees itself grappling with diminished numbers after 37 MPs (Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha) from four anti-BJP parties switched to the ruling side.

Senior MP and Congress Whip in Lok Sabha **Manickam Tagore** speaks to **Asad Rehman** about the Monsoon Session, Delimitation Bill, Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) proposed march to Parliament on Monday, and altered numbers in the House, among other issues. Excerpts:

What are the key issues the Opposition will focus on during the Monsoon Session?

The issues will be discussed in a meeting of all Opposition parties on Monday morning. The Congress has identified the main issues. While we want Parliament to function, we do not want it to become all about



MANICKAM TAGORE
CONGRESS WHIP IN LOK SABHA

the government’s business. The Opposition must be heard. We want to discuss issues like paper leaks, *chanda chori* (alleged donation theft at Ram temple), Manipur turmoil, and the illegal breaking up of parties by the government to conjure a (two-thirds) majority.

How do you think the reduced tally of the Opposition will play out in Parliament?

It is unfortunate that horse trading is taking place in this way. People voted to prevent BJP from securing a majority. However, BJP is buying and threatening MPs, and splitting parties. (Union Home Minister) Amit Shah and (Prime Minister) Narendra Modi are misusing agencies.

The government may re-introduce Bills related delimitation in the upcoming session after they were defeated in the previous session...

We know people voted in a certain way. Before the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, the PM declared BJP will cross 400 (seats) but it didn’t happen. For the first time, the PM had to depend on allies to form the government. The new Delimitation Bill is a bid to snatch away voices of southern, eastern and western India. They (government) are not ready to back down despite the Bill being defeated less than 100 days ago. Nothing has changed. We hope those who voted against the Bill in April do so again.

Is the Congress reaching out to parties like the DMK and NCP (SP), who have yet to make their stand clear on the Delimitation Bill?

There is no reason for them to change their stand from April 17, when voting happened on the Bills. (Congress chief) Mallikarjun Kharge and other leaders are in touch with parties. We are communicating with all parties to defeat the Bill.

We saw the Opposition walk out of the all-party meeting

on Sunday. Will we see more such situations where the ruling side and Opposition are not on the same page?

We knew what horse trading was but now we are seeing elephant trading. The TMC MPs have merged with the NCPI, which suddenly has 20 MPs. This is against the Constitution and parliamentary democracy.

The CJP and activist Sonam Wangchuk have announced a march to Parliament on Monday. Will Congress MPs participate given that the party has extended support to the protesters?

(Leader of the Opposition) Rahul Gandhi has been raising the issue of the (deteriorating) education system for the past two years. He went with it to the people of Kota. He also raised it in Parliament and was told by (Union Education Minister) Dharmendra Pradhan that things will improve.

Still, some organisations are taking up these issues and we do not have any problems with those taking up people’s causes. We are clear. We want Pradhan to go. We will continue to raise these issues inside and outside Parliament. **FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

Hold all-party meet for FCRA, delimitation Bill, Derek urges PM

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 19

HIGHLIGHTING THE Opposition’s apprehensions over the government’s “dubious record” in handling important legislations, TMC Rajya Sabha leader Derek O’Brien Sunday urged PM Narendra Modi to hold an all-party meeting to discuss the Bills on delimitation and amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA).

In his letter to the PM, O’Brien said that no legislation on delimitation appears on the parliamentary bulletin listing government business for the Monsoon session. He referred to the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill and the Delimitation Bill, introduced in Lok Sabha on April 16 this year, which, he said, had failed to secure the required two-thirds majority and were negated the following day. O’Brien said the proposed amendments to FCRA Bill would hit educational institutions run by the Christian community and charitable organisations by establishing excessive executive control over their functioning.

Dissent in Pawar family: Rohit opposes delimitation Bill, says will result in manipulation of constituencies

Alok Deshpande
Mumbai, July 19

IN A clear sign of dissent within the Opposition NCP (SP) and within the family of party chief Sharad Pawar, party MLA Rohit Pawar on Sunday expressed clear opposition to the delimitation bill, distancing himself from the stand announced by NCP (SP) Lok Sabha MP Supriya Sule that the party would consider supporting the Bill if it comes with 50% increase of seats in all the states.

“The primary objective of the ruling party in the Monsoon



NCP-SP MLA Rohit Pawar. FILE

Session of Parliament is to ensure the passage of the delimitation Bill. To achieve this, they may entice states by promising a 50% increase in seats through

sweet talk. However, if we fall into this trap of numbers and support the Bill, the constituencies for the Lok Sabha and Assembly will be manipulated for political gains, much like the ward restructuring in municipal elections,” said Pawar.

Signalling another break in the Opposition ranks ahead of the House session, the Sharad Pawar-led party’s working president Supriya Sule had said that her party would consider supporting the Centre’s proposed delimitation Bill if it ensures a 50 per cent increase in the Lok Sabha seats in all states.

Sule’s remarks came amid reports that sections of the NCP(SP)’s MPs and MLAs were increasingly pushing for a tie-up with the ruling BJP-led NDA.

This is for the first time that a member of Pawar family has openly commented and countered the party’s position, hinting that he may not be willing to support the BJP or the NDA.

He added that this restructuring will be done solely to maintain power, without regard for geographical boundaries or constitutional frameworks, and the delimitation of constituencies in Assam is a

perfect example of this.

“Since 2016, the BJP has already devised a strategy with the help of experienced former officials on how to manipulate constituencies to align their power equations. They are now merely waiting for this Bill to be passed,” he said.

Pawar said that until it happens, BJP will put up the facade of harmony with the Opposition and talk about democracy. “Everyone needs to think carefully about whether to foil this plot or to let it succeed by directly or indirectly supporting the Bill.”

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the Monsoon session of Parliament, Leaders of the Opposition in both Houses — Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge — wrote to PM Narendra Modi on Saturday that his “silence” on the alleged Ram temple donation theft “is unacceptable” and that it was his “duty to ensure accountability and restitution”.

In a joint letter, Kharge and Gandhi wrote, “Lakhs of devotees who donated their hard-earned money with faith, devotion and trust are feeling betrayed by the theft.” They urged the PM to immediately order an “independent and comprehensive investigation into financial affairs of the Trust, including the handling of all offerings.” “The findings and the Trust’s accounts should be made public,” read the letter. **ENS**

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 19

CHIEF MINISTER V D Satheesan, who heads the barely two-month old Congress government in Kerala, appears to be facing discontent from within the party with several senior leaders slamming him for “over-looking organisation while taking key decisions and making political appointments”.

The criticism directed at Satheesan is emerging from those considered close to AICC general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal, who was seen

to be among the frontrunners for the CM’s post.

The latest flashpoint centres on Satheesan’s handling of Congress’s student wing, the Kerala Students Union (KSU). The controversy erupted after KSU state chief Aloshious Xavier objected to the appointment of an advocate with an alleged CPI(M) background as government counsel in HC.

Satheesan, who also holds the Law portfolio, rejected the objection and publicly asserted that the KSU had no role in deciding such appointments. On Friday, at an event in Kochi, he also drew criticism from sec-



Chief Minister V D Satheesan in Thiruvananthapuram. ANI FILE

tions of the party for allegedly failing to acknowledge the waiting KSU leader.

In what was widely seen as a rebuke to Satheesan’s approach towards party workers, senior

Congress leader V M Sudheeran backed Xavier. At a function in Thiruvananthapuram on Saturday, Sudheeran described the KSU leaders “a man of probity” with the courage to speak the truth and urged him to continue doing so without fear.

Venugopal also weighed in on the issue, saying nothing should be done that causes pain to party workers. “The party will examine the grievances raised by the KSU,” he said.

Saturday, which marked the third death anniversary of

former CM Oommen Chandy, also saw state Congress spokesperson V R Anoop take an indirect swipe at Satheesan. “He (Chandy) never turned power into arrogance. He never feared criticism. He never harboured hatred towards those who disagreed with him,” he wrote in a post on Facebook.

KPCC general secretary P M Niyas similarly stressed the importance of accepting criticism. “The strength of an organisation lies not in rejecting criticism but in accepting it and making corrections. The maturity and credibility of

leadership are demonstrated only when lapses are acknowledged and addressed. Those who insult the KSU are not merely disparaging an organisation; they are insulting the sacrifices and memories of its martyrs. The KSU is not just an organisation. It is an emotion and a conviction,” he said.

Niyas had earlier opposed the appointment of N Seshadri-nathan as State Election Commissioner, alleging that the nominee had links to Sangh Parivar. Satheesan did not act on those objections. A section of Congress leaders believes Satheesan has increasingly side-

lined the party organisation and become less receptive to criticism from within. They point to contrast with his own role as one of its most outspoken internal critics during previous Congress government headed by Chandy.

Most of the controversies that have confronted the government in its brief tenure have arisen from decisions taken either by the CMO or departments directly handled by Satheesan. Equally striking is the fact that senior Congress leaders and Cabinet colleagues have largely refrained from publicly defending the CM.



8 killed as rain triggers landslips in Nagaland

Express News Service
Guwahati, July 19

LANDSLIDES IN multiple locations in Nagaland's Mon district, triggered by heavy rainfall, killed at least eight persons on Sunday and injured several others.

According to the officials in Mon district, the landslides took place around 6.30 am. They said that while bodies of four persons were recovered on Sunday, four more continued to be buried under debris.

"Deeply distressing reports of heavy landslides in Mon. My heartfelt condolences to those

who've lost loved ones. The state government is closely monitoring the situation. NSDMA, District Administration, DDMA, SDRF, Police, AR & local community are working on ground for search & rescue operations," said Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio.

The state government announced ex gratia assistance of Rs 4 lakh for the next of kin of each of the deceased and Rs 74,000 for each of the injured.

District administrations also reported widespread waterlogging in Mon and Tizit towns that disrupted normal life because of incessant rainfall.

Himachal on high alert as MeT predicts heavy rainfall

Press Trust of India
Shimla, July 19

OFFICIALS IN Himachal are on high alert after the Shimla meteorological department on Sunday predicted very heavy rainfall at isolated places in four to five districts for the next two days. The MeT office has issued a red warning for Chamba, Kangra, Mandi and Sirmaur districts for Monday (July 20) and Chamba, Kangra, Kullu, Mandi and Sirmaur districts for Tuesday (July 21).

Chief Secretary Kamlesh Kumar Pant has directed all deputy commissioners (DCs) to activate district emergency operation centres on a 24x7 basis, identify vulnerable locations

and take preventive measures.

The commissioners have been instructed to keep Quick Response Teams (QRTs), SDRF, NDRF, Home Guards, fire services, police and ambulances ready. Officials are reviewing contingency plans and resource inventories to ensure availability of food, drinking water, medicines and essential items.

The public has been asked to avoid unnecessary travel, stay away from rivers, streams, nullahs and landslide-prone slopes, and desist from attempting to cross overflowing bridges or flooded roads.

People can contact the state emergency helpline, 1070, or the district emergency helpline, 1077.

J&K: 18 die as flash floods, landslides wreak havoc

Arun Sharma
Jammu, July 19

AT LEAST 18 PEOPLE, including several children, were killed, a large number of vehicles were swept away, and several residential and commercial buildings were damaged after overnight heavy rain led to flash floods and landslides in the early hours of Sunday in Jammu and Kashmir's border districts of Poonch and Rajouri.

Sixteen people died in Poonch district alone, and Rajouri town saw large-scale property damage.

In Poonch, 15 of the 16 deaths took place in the Surankote area — eight in Murrh, four in Sangla, and one each at Sanglani, Marhote and Dogrian Baffliar. Nazia Kousar (28) died in the Noon Bandi area near Poonch when her house collapsed. Her husband, Mohammad Hafiz, and three children, aged between two and six, were rescued from under the debris.

Around 50 private vehicles parked at the Bela Colony bus stand area of Rajouri were washed away in a flash flood. According to locals, the bus stand, made operational in November 2024, was built on a mound in a river that had been dry for a few decades.

However, the river was flooded on Sunday by water brought into it from the nullahs coming from the Darhal and Thanamandi sides. The bus stand subsequently got sub-



In Mendhar area of Poonch district on Sunday. PTI

merged under flood waters, and the vehicles parked there during the night were washed away.

The flood waters also entered nearby slums, and a woman named Pinki Devi was reported to have been swept away, officials said.

A local government official said the death toll was not high in the area because there was no one present at the bus stand area when the flooding occurred.

J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, who had gone to New Delhi to sit on dhama at Jantar Mantar on Monday demanding the restoration of statehood for Jammu and Kashmir, said he would return to Jammu in view of the disaster.

Expressing grief over the loss of lives in Poonch and Ra-

jouri, he said the SDRF, police and all other agencies concerned were engaged in relief and rescue operations, adding that the government will do everything possible to aid and assist affected people who have suffered property loss/damage due to the rains and flash floods.

Lt Governor Manoj Sinha said affected families have already been moved to safety, all departments are on high alert, and that they are prioritising immediate relief and repair work. He urged residents to stay calm and follow official updates. In view of the inclement weather conditions, while various link roads stand blocked due to landslides in the twin border districts, the pilgrimage to Shri Mata Vaishno Devi and Shiv Khori shrines in Reasi district was temporarily sus-

pending.

Meanwhile, authorities in the Jammu division have sounded the alert, following a sharp rise in the water level of the Chenab River and several other streams.

Officials said that all the gates of the Salal Hydroelectric Project in Reasi remained open for the second consecutive day as part of the reservoir flushing process, leading to a significant increase in the discharge and flow of the Chenab River.

In neighbouring Ramban district, police issued a public advisory after the opening of the gates of the Baglihar Hydroelectric Project also caused the river's water level to rise.

Police teams have also been deployed in villages along the Chenab River in Reasi, using public address systems to warn residents against venturing near the river and advising them to keep children and livestock away from its banks.

The district administration has cautioned that the water level in the Chenab may rise suddenly due to continued discharge from the dams and appealed to people to avoid unnecessary travel and stay away from rivers, streams and other water bodies.

According to IMD officials, Reasi received 106.5 mm of rain during the last 24 hours, followed by Rajouri (103 mm), Udhampur (101.6 mm), Katra (85 mm), Poonch (77 mm), Batote (57.2 mm) and Ramban (9 mm) in the Jammu region.

• BRIEFLY



Works on installing the underpass were completed in 8 hours.

GUJARAT

Surat's Udhna station gets India's first steel pedestrian underpass

IN A major boost to passenger safety, Udhna railway station in Surat got the country's first steel subway to connect platforms — built using the 'track cut-and-cover' method to save time for the construction of traditional infrastructure. As part of a pilot project of the Railways, a steel subway was on Friday installed underneath the tracks at the Udhna station. The Mumbai Division of Western Railway installed the 'subway' built by L&T under the tracks. The project employs a 'track cut-and-cover' method which involves installing a pre-fabricated, arch-shaped steel tunnel beneath the tracks, said Divisional Railway Manager, W R Pankaj Singh. The installation was completed within eight hours on Friday. ENS

Goa BJP MLA Jennifer Monserrate dies

FORMER CABINET Minister and BJP MLA from Taleigao constituency Jennifer Monserrate, wife of Atanasio 'Babush' Monserrate, died on Sunday at a private hospital in Goa after a prolonged illness. She was 56. She is survived by her husband, who is the incumbent Revenue Minister and BJP MLA from Panaji Assembly Constituency, and her son Rohit Monserrate, the incumbent Mayor of the Corporation of the City of Panaji (CCP). The government has declared a two-day state mourning, to be observed on Sunday and Monday. ENS

Telangana Cong worker set ablaze, dies

A LOCAL Congress leader died shortly after set ablaze in Warangal district of Telangana, said police said on Sunday. Unidentified persons poured petrol on G Mahesh (35) and set him on fire in on Saturday, police said based on preliminary investigation. He died on the way to the hospital. While the reason is not known, in a video, Ganesh said that he was called by some people to an isolated place. The police initially registered an attempt to murder case, which was later altered into a murder case. Further investigation is underway. PTI

50 spotted deer translocated from Sasan Gir to Mandvi forest

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, July 19

IN A BID TO mitigate incidents of human-wildlife conflict, the Gujarat Forest department has translocated 50 spotted deer from the Sasan Gir Wildlife Division to the Mandvi Forest Range in Surat district.

The initiative is intended to strengthen the natural prey base for carnivores, enhance biodiversity, and support long-term ecological balance in South Gujarat, an official release said on Sunday.

"The translocation was carried out in three phases between May and June this year. A total of 21 spotted deer were released on May 23, followed by 16 on June 18 and another 13 on June 24, taking the total number to 50," the release said.

Conservator of Forests (Surat Circle) Puneet Nayyar said forest officials had carried out habitat assessments to identify sites capable of sustaining the released animals.

"To ensure year-round water availability, the department has developed 10 permanent water points across the release area, providing reliable drinking water for the deer," Nayyar said.

Ayurveda doctor on bail in Gurugram cyber scam arrested again — in Rs 30-crore ponzi scheme

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, July 19

AN AYURVEDA doctor from Andhra Pradesh, who was arrested from Telangana and released on bail last year in the Rs 5.85-crore Gurugram digital arrest case, has been arrested again — this time over a ponzi investment scheme in Hyderabad, where he allegedly owes victims Rs 15-20 crore.

Case records show that the accused, Kitcha Veerbhadr Rao, was arrested on July 15 from Kadapa by the Andhra police for allegedly defrauding around 270 investors of over Rs 30 crore, about half of which has been returned.

This is Rao's second arrest in the ponzi scheme case, after the police first caught him on April 13 this year from Nagole in Hyderabad. The re-arrest came on fresh complaints in the ponzi scheme case after his mandatory release following 90 days in custody without a charge-sheet being filed, records show.

One of the victims, J Paul, a Hyderabad-based IT consultant, told *The Indian Express*: "I had invested Rs 2.14 crore in the scheme of which Rs 1.75 crore remains unreturned. We

are determined to file multiple complaints so that he does not escape the police."

Another victim, R Kolli, a business consultant, said the police in Nagole had allowed them to confront Rao at the police station. "We asked him to show the money trail in the mule accounts he had opened but he did not. He claimed he had no money left," Kolli said, adding that he lost Rs 1.2 crore by investing in Rao's ponzi scheme.

In the Gurugram case, *The Indian Express* had first reported last July that scamsters trapped an executive in a digital arrest scam, stole Rs 5.85 crore from her HDFC Bank account and routed it through three layers: the ICICI Bank account of a resident in Haryana's Jhajjar; 25 other accounts across 10 banks; and then 141 more accounts.

This newspaper had also reported that the second layer of 25 accounts included at least 11 in the Sreenivasa Padmavathi Co-operative Urban Bank in Hyderabad. Two of these "mule accounts" were allegedly opened by Rao, according to court records.

The Union Home Ministry's cyber fraud unit, Indian Cyber



The Indian Express report published on June 30

Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), had informed Gurugram police that there were 181 complaints of cyber crime involving these 11 accounts and that Rs 21 crore had passed through them in just three months. For the two accounts that Rao opened, I4C data shows, there were 30 complaints of cyber fraud.

The FIR lodged against Rao in the ponzi scheme case at the Nagole police station on March 10 cites the Gurugram case as his first criminal offence. It states that Rao was allegedly running a ponzi scheme in which he offered monthly returns of between 10% and 16% — and that he duped investors by placing a fake SEBI certificate in his office.

"They (K V Rao and his team) offered huge commis-

sions to mediators and agents who brought investors into the scheme. Based on these assurances, nearly 270 families invested their hard-earned money. Many victims are from poor and middle-class families who had borrowed money through loans and chit funds expecting safe returns," the FIR states, adding that Rao is out on bail in the Gurugram case.

The Gurugram scam was at the centre of a series of investigative reports published by *The Indian Express* last July on how digital scamsters move crores of stolen money in minutes through a maze of deposits in banks across states. It was just one of 1.23 lakh such crimes reported across the country in 2024, involving a total of

Rs 1,935 crore.

Last month, *The Indian Express* reported that a fish trader, Swamy Ayyappa Naravula, was arrested by the Gurugram police in the case for his alleged role in converting the stolen money into cryptocurrency. The police also recovered a phone from him, allegedly containing details of cryptocurrency worth Rs 40 lakh.

Rao's role surfaced on the Gurugram SIT's radar after Samudrala Venkateswarlu, a director of the bank holding the 11 mule accounts, allegedly told police that the "Hyderabad gang", including Rao, used to withdraw money from these accounts and convert it to cryptocurrency. Samudrala himself was arrested on April 29 by the Gurugram SIT.

Meanwhile, the Gurugram police have recovered Rs 1.06 crore of the money stolen from the executive — some from banks used in the scam, and some in cash from Samudrala (Rs 18.5 lakh) and Rao (Rs 10 lakh). The victim told *The Indian Express* that a sum of Rs 23 lakh, routed to the account of a company run by Rao and later frozen amid legal proceedings, has still not been returned.

'Sorry papa, I tried...': Kanpur graduate kills self over government job

Press Trust of India
Kanpur, July 19

A 23-YEAR-OLD B Tech gold medallist allegedly died by suicide at his home in Kanpur, leaving behind a note apologising to his father for failing to secure a government job despite repeated attempts, police said on Sunday.

The deceased, Anand, had topped the B Tech (Electrical Engineering) programme at a private engineering college, PSTI, in 2024 and secured the third rank in Uttar Pradesh. He was awarded a gold medal at a college function on August 13, 2024.

According to the police, the family's domestic help raised an alarm when repeated knocks on the door went unanswered. Anand's family had travelled to Bihar to fix his elder

brother's marriage alliance.

A hand-written note read, "Sorry, papa, I tried nearly 50 times to get a government job, but I couldn't succeed. Please forgive me," according to the police. The body was sent for post-mortem examination, and the last rites were performed on Saturday evening.

Anand's father, Rajkumar, a retired employee of Lohiya Private Limited and a native of Buxar in Bihar, said his son completed a one-year apprenticeship with Power Grid after graduation before devoting himself to preparing for competitive examinations.

"He appeared for recruitment exams conducted by the Railways, SSC, banks and the education department, but could not succeed. He had been under severe stress for the past several months," Rajkumar said.

Up late for football World Cup final? No classes in Kerala, Meghalaya, Manipur today

ENS & PTI
Thiruvananthapuram, July 19

AHEAD OF THE FIFA World Cup final, Kerala, Meghalaya and Manipur governments declared Monday a holiday for all educational institutions. The match between Spain and Argentina kicks off at 12.30 am IST Monday.

Announcing the decision, Kerala CM V D Sathesaran said in a Facebook post. "The football festival that takes place once every four years is drawing to a close. Our passion for football is a model for the entire world. If the match is being held as per the scheduled time, it would be around 2.30 am when the match ends. If it goes into extra time and penalties, it will continue even longer."

"Children have been asking how they will manage to go to school after staying up so late. The government has decided to



A cutout of Lionel Messi near the Vizhinjam International Seaport in Thiruvananthapuram, Sunday. PTI

declare a holiday for all educational institutions in the state, including professional colleges. Let everyone enjoy the Argentina-Spain final with all its excitement," he said. Education Minister N Samsudheen said the Education Department also wanted to encourage students'

interest in sports.

Meghalaya CM Conrad K Sangma announced a holiday for all educational institutions on Monday. Describing football as "a passion and a way of life" in Meghalaya, the CM said the decision was taken to allow youngsters to enjoy the much-

awaited final.

In Manipur, an order issued by the education department said that the Governor has directed that all educational institutions will remain closed on Monday "with a view to enable students across the state to enjoy FIFA World Cup 2026 final".



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India once dominated textile trade. It needs institutions to make a mark again



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH
BY ASHOK GULATI
AND SULAKSHANA RAO

FEW INDUSTRIES have shaped India's civilisation as profoundly as textiles. Long before modern concepts of global value chains emerged, textiles were already woven into India's economic, cultural and commercial fabric. Archaeological excavations at Harappa and Mohenjodaro (dating back 4,500 years) have uncovered spindle whorls, needles and dyeing artefacts, among the earliest evidence of textiles. What began in the Indus valley was sustained through centuries of trade, innovation and craftsmanship.

For nearly two millennia, Indian fabrics clothed consumers across Asia and Europe. During the Mughal period, Bengal became the world's premier centre for cotton textiles. Dhaka produced the legendary muslin prized by royalty across continents, while Murshidabad, famous for its silk and muslin, emerged as one of the 18th century's wealthiest commercial centres. The economic significance of all this was immense. India accounted for one-fourth of global economic output in 1700, according to Angus Maddison. Then the Industrial Revolution happened, powered by James Hargreaves' spinning jenny and other mechanised weaving technologies. These disruptive technologies changed the rules of the game, in this case competitiveness. Competitive advantage stopped being about artisanal skill and became about technology, productivity and economies of scale. India increasingly became a supplier of cotton to Lancashire mills and a market for manufactured textiles.

Independent India's textile journey has been an effort to reverse this. India today possesses a fully integrated textile value chain, from cotton to spinning, weaving, process-

ing, garment manufacturing and exports. The key catch is the employment intensity of the sector. Apparel alone generates 153 jobs for every Rs 1 crore invested, against 27 in automobiles and 14 in steel. Yet its share of global apparel exports has stagnated at around 3 per cent for over two decades even as Bangladesh's rose from 2.2 per cent to 9 per cent, Vietnam's from 1 per cent to 6 per cent. How does a civilisation that once clothed the world end up with 3 per cent of a \$521 billion global apparel market?

This is the question our new book, *Stitching India's Apparel Export Strategy: From Farm to Foreign*, released last week, sets out to answer. The book presents a comparative policy analysis of China, Bangladesh and Vietnam through five pillars of competitiveness: Scale and ecosystem, capital, labour and skilling, clusters and institutions, and market access and trade facilitation.

The lesson from China is one of an ecosystem approach: Vertically integrated clusters, concessional finance and the Sino-sure model of export credit insurance and institutional governance that transformed China into the largest apparel exporter. Bangladesh leveraged Least Developed Country (LDC) preferences through readymade garment (RMG)-specific finance, back-to-back letters of credit, and export processing zones offering plug-and-play infrastructure and one-stop regulatory services. Vietnam aligned foreign investment, industrial parks and free trade agreements (FTAs) into one integrated strategy and industry-academia

partnerships to attract global manufacturers. Each country followed a different path, but all created integrated ecosystems that enabled firms to compete at scale. Besides all these aspects, one that is very important but much less talked about is the issue of undervalued Chinese currency. Estimates by the IMF, the US Treasury (2026) and Goldman Sachs suggest the yuan has been undervalued by 16 to 30 per cent against the US dollar, acting as an implicit export subsidy.

To realise the government's ambition of \$100 billion in Textile and Apparel (T&A) exports by 2030, India must strengthen these fundamentals of competitiveness across the entire value chain. The first is scale and ecosystem development. The "missing middle" of mid-sized, export-ready firms capable of handling large, fast turnaround orders remains a constraint. Equally relevant is fibre mix. Global apparel trade is dominated by man-made fibre (MMF). India's textile industry remains skewed towards cotton, with a 60:40 cotton-to-non-cotton fibre consumption ratio, in contrast to the global average of 25:75. This mismatch locks India out of the fastest-growing segments such as activewear, technical textiles and athleisure. The recent rationalisation of the inverted duty structure in the MMF segment must now be complemented by investment in MMF spinning and weaving. Second is capital. India's real interest rates of 6.2 to 8.2 per cent remain significantly higher than those of China (3.1 per cent), Vietnam (around 1 per cent) and Bangladesh (negative real rates). Delays in Goods and Services

Tax (GST) refunds and export incentive disbursements also constrain liquidity. Next is labour and skilling. India's apparel sector is highly dependent on migrant labour, moving from Bihar, Odisha and Jharkhand into production clusters such as Bengaluru, Tiruppur, Surat etc. There is high attrition and absenteeism during the festival season, when assembly lines fall short. In our opinion, a more sustainable model is to move factories to where the cheap labour is. Pearl Global's Muzaffarpur unit in Bihar is a step in that direction. The gains are multiple: Higher female labour participation, lower migration costs and a pathway for labour-surplus states like Bihar to accelerate manufacturing-led growth.

Finally, with the UK-CETA (Comprehensive Economic And Trade Agreement) and EU-FTA, India has achieved tariff parity with competitors such as Bangladesh and Vietnam. But competitiveness extends far beyond tariffs. India needs seamless end-to-end integration of trade processes so exporters can move goods, documents and approvals with minimal compliance costs, speed and predictability.

The reform agenda for India is clear: Build an ecosystem approach to competitiveness. PM-MITRA (PM Mega Integrated Textile Region and Apparel) parks, announced in 2021, embody this approach by integrating the five pillars of competitiveness — scale, infrastructure, finance, skills and market access — within a single institutional framework. Their timely implementation is critical if India is to seize the current window of opportunity in global apparel trade. Complemented by the export promotion mission and the integrated programme for the textiles, these reforms can reposition India as a scale-driven, digitally-enabled, sustainable and women-inclusive global sourcing hub. History tells us that India once clothed the world through craftsmanship. The future will depend on whether it can stitch together an ecosystem where firms, finance, institutions and supply chains move with the speed, scale and predictability that global value chains demand.

Gulati and Rao are distinguished professor and senior fellow, respectively, at ICRIER. Views are personal

Some hard questions to RBI over its growth optimism



IN ITS last meeting, the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee voted unanimously to keep interest rates unchanged and maintain a neutral stance. While the accompanying statements did lay out the rationale for the committee's decision, several issues, beginning with inflation, need to be clarified.

Directionally, inflation is expected to trend upwards through the year. The central bank's own forecasts have pegged inflation at 5.65 per cent in the second half of the year, up from 4.65 per cent in the first half. There is also the possibility of prices surprising on the upside, considering the situation in West Asia and uncertainty over the monsoon season.

The MPC, however, voted to keep the repo rate at 5.25 per cent. This implies that, on a forward-looking basis, real interest rates are mildly negative. As negative rates are meant to stimulate economic activity, this would suggest that policy is accommodative. This sits uneasily with the neutral stance the committee currently maintains. A neutral stance, as the RBI governor had earlier noted, calls for neither stimulating economic activity nor controlling inflation. So, is the MPC implicitly pursuing an accommodative policy while formally maintaining a neutral stance?

Currently, headline inflation is being driven more by food and fuel prices. While there is considerable uncertainty over energy prices, the rainfall this season and the impact of El Niño going ahead, the RBI may well believe that price pressures will moderate towards the end of the year. It may thus view negative real interest rates as transitory, justifying its approach. But as forecasts beyond the second half of this year haven't been released, it is difficult to know for sure. Price pressures may not dissipate. High WPI also does suggest inflation in the pipeline — inflation in manufactured products was 7.18 per cent in the first quarter. The extent of the pass-through of higher input prices depends on the pricing power of firms and domestic demand. Will growing market concentration tilt the balance? And what about the knock-on effects on inflation expectations and wages?



Then there is the issue of how the central bank views the underlying economic growth momentum. In its commentary at least, the RBI continues to be optimistic about the country's growth prospects. Like last year, it continues to underline the "resilience" of the economy, even though it expects growth to slow down from 7.7 per cent in 2025-26 to 6.6 per cent in 2026-27. Behind this rhetoric lie uncomfortable questions.

The RBI believes that private consumption has displayed "resilience". However, this is at odds with subdued core inflation, which points towards weak demand. "Sustained low level of core inflation indicates that there are no immediate broad-based demand pressures in the economy," an MPC member had noted in the most recent meeting.

The central bank has also argued that fixed investment has maintained its momentum. Yet, its most recent financial stability report has also noted that "private corporate investment remains subdued as reflected in the moderation in the investment to GDP ratio". So, is it the RBI's view that investment activity is still driven by public capex? Do both private consumption and investment need continued support? With inflation edging upwards and growth slowing down, what is the central bank more worried about — growth or inflation?

The calculus, however, does not end there. There is the issue of the rupee and the US Fed.

There have been times when the RBI's interest rate decisions appear to have been guided not by inflation considerations, but more by the desire to defend the rupee. The pressure on the currency, which had eased, now appears to be reigniting following the renewed conflict in West Asia. Will the RBI raise rates if it believes that the measures announced so far are unlikely to ease the pressure on the currency? And what happens if the US Fed also raises interest rates? While inflation in the US has come in below expectations in June, there is a possibility of the Fed raising rates over the next few meetings. If that is indeed the case, will US monetary policy, as it has seemed in the past, influence the RBI's interest rate decisions?

The central bank should clearly spell out its views on these issues.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Regional failure

VANDITA MISHRA'S piece ("The problem is, the regional party does not hold", *IE*, July 14) rightly blames organisational hollowing for the collapse of regional parties, but it understates a deeper failure: The SP's shift from M-Y to PDA is not just optics; it is testable. Regional parties have learned to perform inclusion through caste categories while leaving the prosecutorial machinery untouched. Mishra's organisational critique is correct, but the deeper failure is substantive: There is no alternative model of justice, only alternative coalition arithmetic.

Atharv Bhand, Pune

State apathy

THE ENTIRE nation witnessed how the Modi government handled the farmers' protests in a heartless manner, allowing protesters to suffer under extreme weather conditions for more than a year ("We're no longer hungry. Is that why Sonam Wangchuk's fast doesn't move us?", *IE* Web, July 18). The government's apathy towards the protesters' demands, including the removal of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education Minister, is not only shocking but also undemocratic.

Tharcius Fernando, Chennai

Taking sleep seriously

WE OFTEN treat sleep as a personal lifestyle choice, but when environmental conditions, unreliable power supply and rising temperatures make rest nearly impossible, it clearly becomes a public health crisis ("Sleepless nights, a public health challenge", *IE*, July 18). Dietary habits and screen addiction are part of the problem, but we cannot fix a systemic issue through individual discipline alone. While a digital detox and yoga can help, policymakers need to treat sleep as a public-health priority in urban planning. If they do not, we are looking at a cascading health crisis that will undermine our productivity and well-being for years to come.

Ananya Mishra, Kanpur



SAROJINI NADIMPALLY

ON JULY 8, the World Health Organisation (WHO) released its Global Status Report on Cancer. The figures are staggering: An estimated 20.6 million new cancer cases and nearly 10 million deaths worldwide each year; that is, more than 26,000 lives lost each day. At current rates, the WHO predicts 35 million annual cases by 2050.

In addition to the scale of the disease, the report highlights an inherent inequity. A woman with breast cancer in a high-income country has an 87 per cent chance of surviving five years, compared to about 42 per cent in a low-income country, a gap that is less due to biology and more due to where she happens to live. While 68 to 94 per cent of wealthier countries have access to the top 20 priority cancer medicines, only 9 to 54 per cent of low- and lower-middle-income countries do.

India's own numbers fit into this picture, albeit not comfortably. With an estimated 15.33 lakh new cases expected in 2024, a Rajya Sabha standing committee noted that roughly one in nine Indians faces a lifetime risk of cancer. The committee has also sought expert recommendations to improve the affordability of cancer care and expand access to diagnostics. According to GLOBOCAN 2022 data, breast cancer accounted for over 1.92 lakh new cases and over 98,000 deaths in India in 2022. More than half of these cases are detected at an advanced stage,

Patents should not put cancer care out of reach

making treatment more expensive and less effective. I'm writing this while undergoing cancer treatment myself. What has struck me is not the disease itself but the ordeal of surviving it: Waiting for an appointment, the anxiety, and the arithmetic every patient does, working out which drug she can afford, which treatment package is feasible, and how much her insurance might cover.

A breast cancer patient who cannot afford targeted therapy, immunotherapy, or hormonal therapy is not just facing a market or health-system failure. She is witnessing the slow erosion of a right that the Constitution is meant to guarantee. The same applies to access to essential medicines.

The right to health has long been recognised as integral to the right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution. The Supreme Court has held that a healthy body is the foundation of all human activity; that the right to life includes access to medical care and a decent standard of living; that the state has a duty to make essential medicines affordable.

Litigation over access to medicines, compulsory licensing, or drug pricing should not languish in courts for years, as it often does. In 2022, a retired bank employee with HER2-negative metastatic breast cancer approached the Kerala High Court seeking compulsory licensing of the patented drug Ribociclib under Sections 92 and 100 of the Patents Act, 1970, be-

cause its prohibitive cost made treatment unaffordable. The court directed the Centre to consider compulsory licensing, but the petitioner died before the matter was decided. The High Court converted the proceedings into a *suo motu* case, *In Re Exorbitant Pricing of Life Saving Patented Medicines*, which remains pending despite having been listed for hearing more than 57 times. If delayed treatment is already a rights violation, prohibitively expensive treatment cannot be any less so.

In the 20 years since India aligned its patent regime with TRIPS, it has issued only one compulsory licence: For Bayer's Nexavar in 2012, a drug for kidney and liver cancer, which reduced its monthly supply cost from Rs 2.8 lakh to under Rs 9,000. The 2001 Doha Declaration on the TRIPS Agreement and Public Health, which India helped shape, holds that intellectual property protection should never come at the cost of public health. The tools already exist. What is missing is the willingness to use them.

The WHO has declared this a global emergency. For India, it is a pressing policy issue and a constitutional question. The Rajya Sabha's inquiry into affordable cancer care is a welcome opening. What remains uncertain is the political will to act before it is too late, even for a patient like me who can afford treatment.

The writer is a public-health specialist working on reproductive health and biotechnologies

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Indian English is not a colonial relic

decolonise education, treating English as permanently foreign is a strange way to start. More fundamentally, the term "native language" is problematic. As the SC observed, it is not a constitutional category. The Constitution speaks of the "mother tongue", "regional language," and "Indian language". The idea that every nation has one authentic language rooted in its territory emerged from 19th-century European nationalism. Applying that framework to India ignores its history of multilingualism, migration, and cultural exchange. Ironically, a policy presented in the language of decolonisation relies on a European idea of linguistic authenticity.

From a postcolonial perspective, the problem runs deeper. Frantz Fanon reminded us that language is tied to power, identity, and social mobility. Homi Bhabha argued that colonial inheritances are not

simply preserved after empire but appropriated and transformed in new cultural contexts. That is what happened to English in India, adapted into an Indian language with its own vocabulary, idioms, literature, legal discourse, and administrative practice. It no longer belongs to its colonial past, a point the linguist Braj Kachru made through his theory of World Englishes. He argued that countries such as India had developed institution-

The idea that every nation has one authentic language rooted in its territory emerged from 19th-century European nationalism. Applying that framework to India ignores its history

alised indigenised varieties that could no longer be treated as mere copies of British or American English.

At the same time, the strongest critique of English in postcolonial thought cannot be dismissed. Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o argued that colonial languages displaced indigenous ones and alienated people from their cultures. That critique holds force in many societies, but India's experience differed. After Independence, English took on a new political role: For non-Hindi-speaking states, it became a constitutional safeguard against the dominance of any single Indian language. The present controversy must be viewed in this context. Statements by leaders portraying English as a colonial legacy that India should move past suggest an ideological preference for reducing its significance. None of this is an argument against

strengthening Indian languages. They deserve greater institutional support. But promoting them does not require treating English as a foreign language. Language is a form of social capital. In India, English shapes access to higher education, the civil services, the higher judiciary, and the knowledge economy. Reclassifying it changes none of these realities. The real question is whether a postcolonial society should define belonging by a language's ancestry rather than its place in contemporary life. English has become one of the languages through which India governs, learns, litigates, and debates. Calling it "non-native" does not decolonise education; it simply misunderstands what postcolonial India has made of the language.

The writer is former professor, Christ University, Bengaluru

Move to bring Bihar colleges under govt dept: DU teachers raise concerns

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 19

A DAY after six NDA,MLCs wrote to Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary to drop a proposed Bill seeking to delink undergraduate colleges from state universities, members of the Delhi University Teachers Association (DUTA) and the Federation of Central Universities Teachers Associations (FEDCUTA) wrote to Bihar Governor Syed Ata Hasnain, who is the chancellor of the state universities, requesting him to continue with the existing system.

The Indian Express had previously reported that the proposed Bill, under which over 500 constituent colleges offering undergraduate degrees would come directly under the control of a newly created higher education department, is likely to be introduced in the monsoon session of the Assembly beginning Monday.

In a joint letter addressed to the Bihar Governor, six DU teachers, who are serving or ex-functionaries of DUTA and FEDCUTA, wrote: “The universities are not merely administrative structures. They are autonomous academic institutions, where teaching, research, curriculum, examinations, recruitment and academic standards are integrated within a single institutional framework,” they wrote.

The letter that the proposed legislation could fundamentally alter the character of the affiliating university system.

“UG education forms the foundation of the academic ecosystem. Universities develop curricula, conduct exams, supervise academic standards, undertake faculty development and create pathways for students to pursue PG education and research. Fragmenting this structure may weaken this interwoven structure and the continuity between undergraduate and postgraduate education. Secondly, the proposed arrangement would substantially reduce academic authority of universities over their constituent colleges,” read the letter.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Gagandeep Singh Lambha S/O Shri Harmeeet Singh R/O G-28/34-35 Third Floor, Sector-3, Rohini, Delhi-110085, have changed my name to Gagandeep Singh. 0040866842-5

I, Parveen Kaur Saini W/o Mohinder Singh, R/o WZ-24, G/F, S.P. Mukherjee Park, Tilak Nagar, West delhi-110018 , have changed my name to Parveen Kaur. 0071048549-1

I, Sunetra Atmaj Rane, D/o. Mr. Shreenivas Wadke, holder of Indian Passport, hereby declare that I shall henceforth be known as Sunetra Shreenivas Wadke. Both names refer to one and the same person. Henceforth the new name shall be used for all legal and official purposes as per my account. 0071048621-1

I, Harmeet Singh Lambha S/O Shri Devi Dass R/O 9858, Gali Zameer Wali Nawab Ganj, Azad Market, Delhi-110006, have changed my name to Harmeet Singh. 0040866842-4

I, Mohinder Singh Saini S/o Kartar Singh, R/o WZ-24, S.P. Mukherjee Park, Tilak Nagar, West delhi-110018 , have changed my name to Mohinder Singh. 0071048553-1

I, Pankaj Malik S/o. Om Pal Singh R/o.3198 3rd Floor, Lal Darwaja Sita Ram Bazar, Delhi-06 In my passport record's my father's name is written as Om Pal Singh Malik but my father's correct name is Om Pal Singh

0040866766-1

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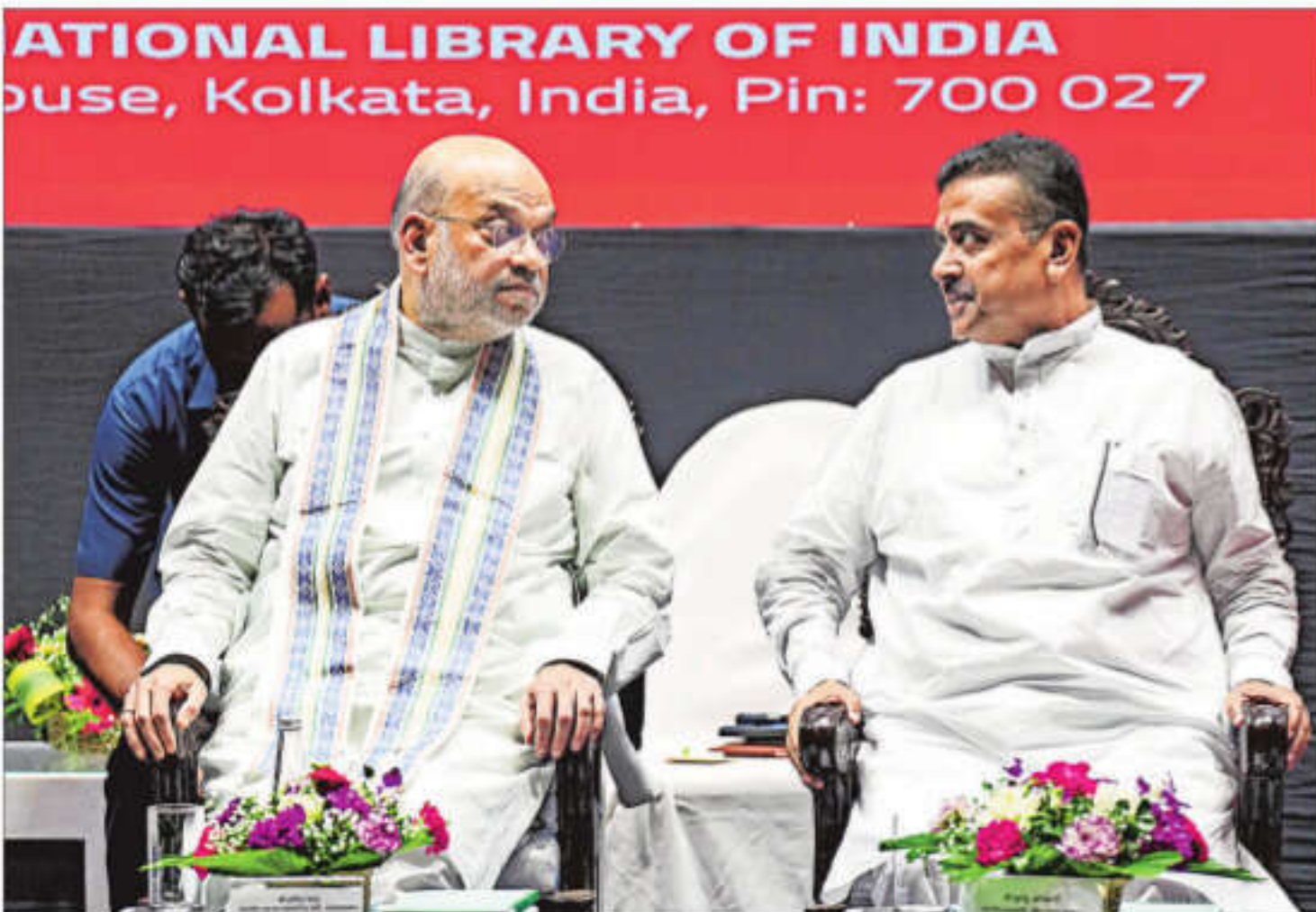
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UNION HOME MINISTER'S 3-DAY BENGAL VISIT CONCLUDES



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari during the foundation stone laying of the Amul Bengal Dairy Project, in Kolkata on Sunday. PTI

Shah lays foundation stone of world's largest curd production plant

Slams previous TMC govt for stalling entry of Amul into state

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 19

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah on Sunday laid the foundation stone virtually for the world's largest curd production plant while slamming the previous TMC government for stalling the entry of Gujarat-based dairy cooperative Amul into the state.

Part of the Rs 700-crore Amul Bengal Dairy Project, the plant – coming up at Howrah Food Park in Howrah's Sankrail – will have a daily capacity to process up to 30 lakh litre milk and 10 lakh litre curd.

Addressing the gathering at the event at the Biswa Bangla Convention Centre here in the presence of CM Suwendu Adhikari, Shah said, “I am here to tell the people of Bengal that all the election promises the BJP had made would be fulfilled. Today is a very important day for the farmers of Bengal. Amul has performed the ‘bhumi puja’ for what will become the world's largest curd production plant. Around 1.2 lakh small dairy farmers and cattle rearers will benefit from this initiative.”

Shah said the political change in the state was unlike any witnessed in the country since Independence, asserting that the new BJP government led by Adhikari has revived the quest for “Sonar Bangla” after decades of “misrule” of the Left and the TMC.

“We used to write to the then chief minister [Matamata Banerjee] to provide two plots of 15 acres each so that eastern India's dairy production could be developed from Bengal. At

that time, I was told Gujarat would not be allowed to enter the state... But this [project] is not for Gujarat; it is for the livestock farmers of West Bengal,” he said.

Praising the present BJP government, he said the project became possible because of the political change in the state. “On my way here, I asked CM Adhikari for land, and he immediately agreed to provide it free of cost to the Amul Federation,” he said.

Shah said he had come to Bengal on behalf of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to sweeten the mouths of the people with ‘mishti doi’ after the BJP's victory in the recent Assembly elections.

Shah said the state, which was once “a beacon of light” for the entire country in education, culture, spirituality, the freedom movement and nationalism, suffered decades of “political decline”.

“Bengal remained under a Communist government influenced by foreign ideology for three decades. After breaking free from that, it fell into the clutches of the TMC... Before our eyes, the dream of ‘Sonar Bangla’ envisioned by Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore was destroyed,” he said.

He also laid the foundation stones of 14 storage warehouses with an estimated cost of Rs 6 crore, with a total storage capacity of 1,400 metric tonnes across nine districts.

Earlier in the day, Shah held a high-level review meeting regarding the law-and-order situation in the state. The meeting was attended by CM Adhikari

and the state's police and administration brass.

According to sources, Shah asked all border police stations of West Bengal Police to work in coordination with the BSF. He emphasised the need to establish an anti-narcotics task force, an anti-terrorist squad and a special investigation agency modelled after the NIA to strengthen West Bengal's internal security, given its 2,217-km border with Bangladesh, officials told PTI.

Inaugurates ‘Museum of Word’

Later in the day, Shah visited the National Library campus in Alipore where he inaugurated the Museum of Word (Shabdalo), said to be India's first immersive language museum.

The Shabdalo is designed to showcase the vast diversity of India's languages, scripts and storytelling traditions.

Developed by the National Library under the aegis of the Union Culture Ministry, Shabdalo celebrates India's 22 official languages and traces their journey from oral traditions and ancient manuscripts to printed works and modern electronic texts, highlighting the country's enduring linguistic diversity.

“This is a momentous day for the nation's culture... I am fully confident that this Museum of Word will address a fundamental need in this process of cultural resurgence and will succeed in its mission.”

“Every youth must learn one Indian language along with the mother tongue. Through this, we can give long life to our languages,” he said.

9 in 10 Indian adults have abnormal lipid level; low HDL most common

Found to peak among those aged 30-39 yrs: Study

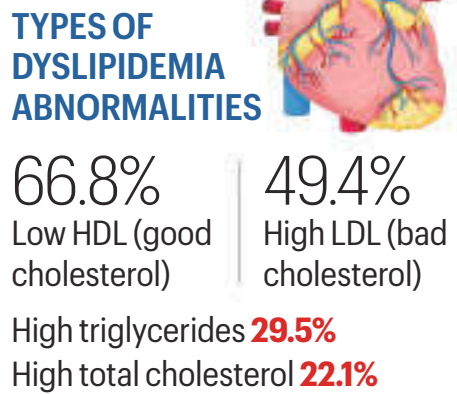
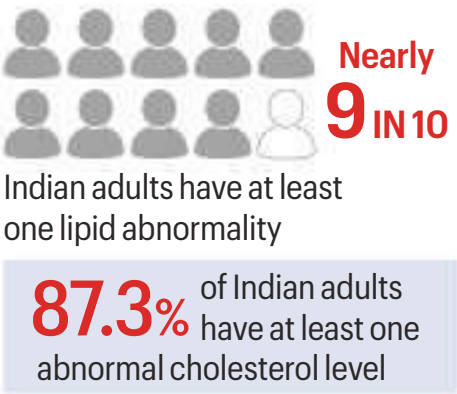
Express News Service
New Delhi, July 19

MOST PEOPLE associate high cholesterol with middle age, obesity or diabetes but according to data from a national study by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR)-INDIAB, nine in 10 (87.3%) Indian adults have at least one abnormal lipid level, making dyslipidemia — an unhealthy balance of fats in the blood — one of country's most widespread health problems.

The study analysed lipid profiles from 23,665 adults selected from the larger ICMR-INDIAB survey covering all states and UTs. People with dyslipidemia often feel healthy while unhealthy fats accumulate inside blood vessels over the years, narrowing arteries, increasing the risk of heart attack, stroke and other cardiovascular diseases.

Overall, women had a higher prevalence of dyslipidemia than men. Urban residents were more affected than those in rural areas, but the relatively small urban-rural gap indicates lifestyle changes from sedentary occupations, changing diets, which include processed food, and decline in physical activities have transcended metropolitan centres. “These findings reinforce decades of evidence that cardiovascular health depends

India's dyslipidemia profile



SEDENTARY LIFESTYLE, UNHEALTHY DIET INCREASES RISK

UNEXPECTED FACE OF RISK
Around 355 million Indians have abnormal lipid levels despite normal blood sugar, normal blood pressure and no obesity.

WOMEN SHOW A HIGHER BURDEN
Women have a higher prevalence of dyslipidemia than men. Urban areas are more affected, though rural India isn't far behind.

LINKED TO MODERN LIFESTYLES
Sedentary lifestyle, unhealthy diet, obesity, diabetes and hypertension significantly increase the risk of abnormal cholesterol levels.

HEART RISK BEGINS EARLY
Dyslipidemia peaks between the ages of 30 and 39 years

SOURCE: ICMR-INDIAB NATIONAL STUDY

not only on genetics but also on daily habits — healthy eating, regular exercise, maintaining appropriate body weight and avoiding tobacco. They point to an early screening of cholesterol,” says Dr V Mohan, one of the authors of the study and chairman, Dr Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre, Chennai. “A lot of dyslipidemia is driven by low high-density lipoprotein (HDL), which we call good cholesterol. Of course, Indians are genetically predisposed but lifestyle is equally to blame. Our diet continues to be

carbohydrate-heavy. Excess carbs push up triglycerides, which push down HDL. We have found this factor alone drives up dyslipidemia in Indians by 90%,” he says.

The study revealed that two out of every three adults had low HDL cholesterol — the most common abnormality, followed by elevated LDL or “bad” cholesterol, high triglycerides and high total cholesterol.

South Asians have long been recognised as having a unique metabolic profile. Many Indians develop low HDL and elevated

Geo-tagging, scientific monitoring, revival plans: Chhattisgarh draws roadmap to curb river pollution

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, July 19

GEO-TAGGING of river origin points, district-wise River Revival Plans, scientific monitoring of river discharge, groundwater levels and water quality, and technical scrutiny by expert institutions — these are among the measures the Chhattisgarh government says it has taken to prevent river pollution.

In an affidavit to the Chhattisgarh High Court, the state government informed the court of the steps taken to tackle river pollution. This comes nearly two months after court came down heavily on the government, citing media reports on untreated industrial discharge, blackened water and fish deaths in the Shivanth and Kharun rivers.

In a major step towards river protection, the state informed the court geo-tagging of river origin points has been completed and they are being digitally mapped on the PM Gati Shakti platform as part of a statewide river restoration programme.

It also said district-wise River Revival Plans have been prepared or are being finalised, and expert institutions including IIT Roorkee, NIT Raipur and Chhattisgarh Swami Vivekanand Technical University (CSVTU), Bilhail, have been engaged to prepare technically sustainable restoration plans.

Further, a “State Level Source Festival (Rajya Stariya Shrot Mahotsav)” and a “State Level Workshop” will be organised and deliberations and recommendations emerging from the said programme shall be suitably incorporated into the ongoing River Rejuvenation



Institutions including IIT Roorkee and NIT Raipur have been engaged to prepare technically sustainable river restoration plans

Plans to further strengthen implementation of the directions issued by this Hon'ble Court and the State Level Committee.

It will be organised during last week of July and attended by members of the state-level committee, district committees and river origin site committees constituted in various districts, representatives of concerned government departments, technical experts, academic institutions, local bodies, public representatives and environmental groups and other stakeholders.

The chief secretary said a meeting was held on June 15 and directions issued to all district collectors, including undertaking only scientifically suitable river conservation works in consultation with expert institutions, submitting geotagged photographs of river origin points before the court and implementing “desiltation policy, river bank protection and flood control works through SDRF and other available schemes”.

It also included ensuring scientific monitoring of river dis-

charge, water quality and groundwater levels.

The affidavit gave river-wise updates on 11 rivers, including the Hasdeo in Koriya/MCB districts. “The Hasdeo River's origin has been identified and geo-tagged, and a comprehensive River Revival Plan is being prepared. The plan includes catchment treatment, riverbank protection, desiltation, plantation, groundwater and water-quality monitoring, while source — considered a religious site — is proposed to be developed through environmentally sustainable facilities such as homestays”.

The two-judge Bench of Chief Justice Ramesh Sinha and Justice Ravindra Kumar Agrawal said the government had prima facie demonstrated substantial compliance with its directions but found the affidavit silent on its 2020 order directing the removal of encroachments around the Arpa river's origin, asking the chief secretary to file a separate affidavit on the issue. The court will hear the case on August 11.

triglycerides while their body weight remains normal. This combination is closely linked to insulin resistance which contributes to the disproportionately high rates of premature heart disease in South Asian populations.

Researchers estimate that around 355 million Indians have abnormal lipid levels despite normal blood sugar and blood pressure and no obesity. In other words, those generally considered “healthy” are significantly at risk of heart disease.

Instead of rising only in old age, dyslipidemia was found to peak among those aged between 30 and 39 years. For a country with one of the world's youngest populations, the implications are profound — early onset of abnormal lipid levels means longer lifetime exposure to cholesterol-related damage, increasing the likelihood of premature cardiovascular disease.

Individuals with higher Body Mass Index (BMI) and worsening blood glucose status showed substantially higher rates of dyslipidemia. Sedentary lifestyle pushed the likelihood of unhealthy lipid profiles.

The study's authors argue that if India hopes to curb the rising tide of heart disease, screening must begin earlier and not wait until people develop diabetes, hypertension or obesity before recommending cholesterol tests. Most importantly, people should not assume they are protected simply because they are young, slim or not diabetic, they said.

On the run for 27 yrs after killing 2 cops, Agra man held in Bhopal

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 19

HE EVADED arrest for 27 years by assuming a new identity in Madhya Pradesh, cutting off all contact with his Agra-based family who eventually presumed him to be dead.

The decades-long hunt for Bhura, now 48, wanted for killing two police constables in 1999, ended on Saturday with his arrest from Bhopal district, police said.

Acting on a tip-off, a police team travelled to Bhopal last week and placed the suspect, who had assumed the name Jamil, under surveillance for several days, officials said. He lived along with his wife and son, they added.

“After an extensive search to track him down, we established his real identity. During interrogation, he admitted he is Bhura,” said Aditya, DCP Agra.

The DCP said police would seek his remand for further questioning, as they are still trying to recover one of the three rifles allegedly looted during an attack on police personnel in 1999. Bhura never contacted his family nor visited them during this period, police added.

Though Bhura initially denied that he was the fugitive the police were searching for, he caved in after prolonged interrogation, the officials said.

According to police, Bhura told during questioning that he had been a member of the Ramesh Kushwaha gang. In 1999, he and four other gang members, including Ramesh Kushwaha and Dhadhu, travelled to Agra in a jeep to carry out robberies and dacoities.

Woman loses way in forest after escaping rape bid, Odisha Police rescues her using drones

Press Trust of India
Bhubaneswar, July 19

ODISHA POLICE on Sunday rescued a woman from a reserve forest on the outskirts of Bhubaneswar using drones, flare guns and rocket fireworks after she allegedly fled there while escaping an attempt to rape, officials said.

According to police, the woman had taken a lift on a motorcycle from Khurda bus stand. The rider allegedly took her towards the Ratanpur Reserve Forest with the intention of sexually assaulting her.

“The accused attempted to rape the woman. However, she resisted, fought back and escaped into the reserve forest. While fleeing, she lost her way

inside the forest,” a police officer said. The woman then contacted the police for help using her phone, following which around 50 personnel from the Infol valley, Jatani and Khandagiri police stations, led by the ACP (Zone III), launched a search operation.

“As the GPS location on her mobile phone was disabled by default, drones, flare guns and rocket fireworks were used to help her identify our location. She was rescued safely,” the officer said. Police said the woman was initially reluctant to lodge a complaint but later agreed after counselling.

A case of attempt to rape has been registered at the Infol valley police station, and the accused has been arrested.

150 OTHERS REMOVED FROM PROTEST SITE

Ken-Betwa project: Police detain protest leader fasting for 14 days

Anand Mohan J
Chhatarpur, July 19

THE MADHYA Pradesh Police on Sunday morning detained Ken-Betwa protest leader Amit Bhatnagar and several demonstrators from the protest site at Chhatarpur district's Kupi village, ending a two-week agitation against the Rs 44,605-crore Ken-Betwa Link Project.

This comes after Bhatnagar spent 14 days on an indefinite fast, emerging as the face of protests over alleged irregularities in land acquisition, rehabilitation and compensation for families affected by the project.

The Ken-Betwa Link Project, India's first river-linking project, will transfer water from the Ken River to the Betwa basin through the Daudhan Dam and a network of canals, with the stated aim being to provide irrigation, drinking water and hydropower across MP and UP. The project requires the displacement of nearly 2,000 families from villages falling within the reservoir's submergence, leading to protests.

Several platoons of local police in riot gear landed up at the protest site as Bhatnagar and the protesters kept their distance from the police force by wading into the river, while the police tried to convince them to call off the protests.

Additional SP (Chhatarpur) Aditya Patle told *The Indian Express*, "Bhatnagar has not been arrested. He was on a fast for two weeks, and taking his

health into account, we detained him and took him to the local hospital for treatment."

Patle said around 150 protesters were detained, packed into buses and sent to Panna district. "Our investigation showed these are not people from the locality but from Panna who had issues with other dam projects. So we detained them and sent them to Panna."

Police further said the action against the protesters was taken because they were present near a local river tributary, which had risen to dangerous levels due to heavy rainfall. They were also protesting under an under-construction bridge, which police claimed was a hazard.

An activist who has worked on displacement and rehabilitation issues in Bundelkhand, Bhatnagar has been involved in campaigns related to land acquisition, environmental compliance and the rights of project-affected families. Since July 3, he led the Kupi protest, which has drawn displaced villagers from Daudhan, Palkhua, Sukwaha and neighbouring settlements demanding fresh surveys, correction of compensation records and action on alleged irregularities.

Hours earlier, Bhatnagar points out 'irregularities'

Hours before his detention, Bhatnagar, visibly frail after two weeks without food, spoke to *The Indian Express* from a cot under a tarpaulin at the protest site. Too weak to walk on his own, he was often carried by



Protesters waded into Barana river as security personnel move in to detain them in Madhya Pradesh's Chhatarpur district on Sunday. PTI

fellow protesters between demonstrations. He paused every few minutes to sip water before resuming conversations with villagers, coordinating the agitation and addressing visitors.

Over the past fortnight, he joined women protesters lying on symbolic funeral cots and helped organise mock funeral pyres to dramatise what demonstrators called the "death" of villages facing submergence under the Daudhan reservoir.

"The government has not been fair and transparent in its land acquisition process. There are many irregularities in the disbursement of compensation," Bhatnagar said before his detention.

He alleged that the proceedings registers of the Gram Pan-

chayats of Ratiya, Kari, Khatwani, Palkhua, Naiyapur, Khajuri and Sukwaha contained identical word-for-word entries, while several Gram Sabha meetings were shown as having taken place at 11.30 am on February 17 and 18, 2022, raising questions over the authenticity of the proceedings.

Bhatnagar further alleged that around Rs 11 crore had been sanctioned as compensation for houses in Kharihani village, while documents available with him suggested nearly Rs 8 crore was paid to people who either had no connection with the village or had migrated away decades ago.

Chhatarpur Collector Parth Jaiswal rejected the protesters' allegations, saying most of those

participating in the agitation were not directly affected by the Ken-Betwa Link Project. "We have identified 176 names of those participating in the protest. About 10% of them are affected by the Ken-Betwa project. The remaining 90% are not project-affected," he said.

Rejecting allegations that Gram Sabha proceedings had been fabricated, Jaiswal said "there were no irregularities in the Gram Sabha records". On claims that compensation had been sanctioned to a Muslim family despite "no such family residing in Kharihani village, he said the family owned fertile agricultural land there and had been compensated for the acquired land, not for residential status in the village".

EXPRESS special

Blues at Himachal's famed police orchestra as its lead accused of false notes

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, July 19

THE FIRST orchestra in India to perform nationally under the police banner and in uniform, and get international invites. A finalist on TV talent show *Hunarbaaz — Desh Ki Shaan* in 2022. The main act at the closing ceremony of the International Film Festival of India in 2023. A long list of fans including Bollywood names such as Karan Johar and Twinkle Khanna.

Harmony of the Pines, as the orchestra of the Himachal Pradesh Police is called, has come a long way since it started 30 years ago as a small group of seven members, to "alleviate stress faced by the police force". Now, in one of the rare discordant notes to strike the band, its in-

charge and virtually its face, Inspector Vijay Kumar, has gone to court over his suspension on July 13, on charges of making money by monetizing his personal social media account, reportedly without disclosing the same to the police department.

Vijay, who belongs to Kanagra and has been with the orchestra almost from the start, says the money at stake is just over Rs 6,000. The next hearing in the case is on July 31, with the High Court seeking the state government and DGP's reply.

The development has come as a surprise in the state, where the last big performance by the orchestra was less than a month ago at the government-sponsored Narkanda Summer Festival in Shimla, and where it is a regular in the ongoing anti-drugs campaign. In the first week of June, the orchestra per-



A file photo of Harmony of the Pines. Inspector Vijay Kumar is third from left in the seated row.

formed at Thyagaraj Stadium in Delhi. In the last week of May, it received an award at the hands of Governor Kavinder Gupta.

The orchestra was a brainchild of former ADGP Bhupinder Singh Thind and was started in 1996, but got more professional 2019 onwards when a dedicated sub-cadre was formed for hiring people for it, says a DIG-rank officer. Now it has 17 members, including two women.

SP Bhupinder Singh Negi, Commandant, 1st Himachal Pradesh Armed Police Battalion (HPAP), Junga, said a committee of music experts and senior officials picks up the recruits, on the basis of their practical and theoretical knowledge of music.

Harmony of the Pines comes under the administrative jurisdiction of the Battalion, and is allocated a dedicated space at Bharari Police Lines in Shimla.

"Basic police training, weapon training etc is necessary for the personnel hired for the orchestra too. Their ranks, salaries are equivalent to the ranks of police officials on general duty," Negi said. The orchestra's personnel can be called in for duty in case of an emergency or for VVIP visits

and to maintain law and order.

Its charges range from roughly Rs 30,000 for government and Rs 1 lakh for private functions in Himachal, to Rs 1.50 lakh and more outside the state. For police functions, the rates are lower. Revenue generated through official performances of the orchestra is to be deposited into the Police Welfare Fund.

The orchestra has around 329,000 followers on Instagram and nearly 18,000 subscribers on YouTube. Officials said the department spends lakhs of rupees on the upkeep and replacement of instruments.

The DIG quoted above said that while Vijay is not from the special cadre, having joined the police force as a Constable in 1998, "he was sent on deputation to the orchestra in the early 2000s due to his melodious voice and knowledge of musical instruments".

Vijay faced action for failure to disclose the complete earnings through his social media accounts while publicising private musical activities. Allegedly, he could not show any permission showing he was allowed to make private music albums while being a member

of the police force.

Vijay has submitted that he earned approximately Rs 6,794 for his monetized social media accounts and that he had deposited the same into the Police Welfare Fund. But the department found his reply unsatisfactory, and the probe found him "in violation of statutory and departmental provisions governing the conduct and discipline of police personnel".

An officer said: "Orchestra members can perform in plain clothes also, but all performances are bound by strict regulations. No orchestra member is allowed to perform individually and commercially without the permission of the DGP."

Incidentally, in June last year, the department turned down Kumar's VRS application, saying it would hit both the orchestra and the police force. IGP, Armed Police & Training, Prem Kumar Thakur wrote: "Inspector Vijay Kumar possesses extensive experience, musical expertise, and exceptional leadership qualities that are pivotal for the training, coordination, and disciplined performance of the orchestra team. His continued presence is vital to ensure the operational readiness and professional standards of the orchestra. Any premature release of Inspector Vijay Kumar from service would result in a vacuum and may adversely impact the image and functioning of the department at official platforms."

Vijay as well as the other orchestra members refused to comment on his suspension.

'Likelihood of something positive happening greater under this dispensation than any other... onus on Pak'

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 19

AJAY BISARIA was private secretary to Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee and later became India's High Commissioner to Pakistan. He was there during the July 2001 Agra summit when he famously handed over a note to Vajpayee in the midst of talks with Pakistan's President Pervez Musharraf about the latter's hawkish views on Kashmir and terrorism during the breakfast roundtable with Indian editors.

Bisaria was India's envoy to Pakistan during the Feb 2019 Pulwama terror attack and the Balakot aerial strikes, the capture and release of Indian Air Force fighter pilot Abhinandan Varthaman, and the abrogation of Art 370 in Kashmir.

25 years after the Agra summit, Bisaria — who authored the best-selling book — "Anger Management: The troubled diplomatic relationship between India and Pakistan" — spoke to *The Indian Express* and shared his thoughts on lessons from the failed Agra summit and engaging with Pakistan in the current state of affairs. Edited excerpts:

Twenty-five years after the Agra summit, what do you think are the lessons learnt?

For Vajpayee, Agra was a necessary step towards closure on Kargil... a near war, particularly in a nuclear environment, needs closure of some kind. The hope at Agra was to reach that closure. The summit was also necessary for Vajpayee and his team to understand the Pakistani general and his proclivities, an understanding that eventually led to the real closure of Kargil at the Islamabad SAARC Summit of January 2004.

So the trial by fire of going to Agra, watching it fail, and persisting was critical to Vajpayee reaching that closure in January 2004 — which bought us a few years of peace: certainly the next three years, arguably till 2008. In that sense, the peace he hoped to achieve at Agra did eventually materialise; Agra itself was simply too soon. In hindsight, the error at Agra was clearly insufficient preparation. They should have prepped the summit properly — sent teams back and forth. Instead, the approach was "let's see what the general does", and the failure was implicit in that. Had they invested a few months of diplomacy before getting there, they could have secured a better outcome at Agra itself.

Now, 25 years later, do you think a similar move is possible in the current environment?

The Indian political leadership now sees the political cost of a peace initiative as too high. The examples cited are Vajpayee in 1999, repaid with Kargil; Vajpayee again engaging Musharraf at Agra in 2001 and still not succeeding; Manmohan Singh seeing the cost in the 2008



AJAY BISARIA
INDIA'S FORMER HIGH COMMISSIONER TO PAKISTAN

Mumbai terror attack and never risking a Pakistan visit; and Modi paying the price for the 2015 Lahore visit with the Pathankot attack.

So, politically, it appears too risky — the fear of being caught in a ruse yet again. If it happens now, it will happen only with a sufficient guarantee — direct or indirect, overt or covert — that this time it is for real: that Pakistan wants a genuine conversation and no one will sabotage it with an attack. The chances are stronger under a "same-page" government in Pakistan, with the army standing as a guarantee — reassuring India that if a peace deal is done now, the army and the civilians are aligned. That would improve the odds. But the problem is that the army itself seems to have gone rogue in Pakistan, and so the appetite for an Agra-type move is very low.

These moves seem to succeed only when there is a strong government in India and a military leader on the other side. Is there a pattern?

That used to be the understanding, and to some extent it holds. It rests on the same broader global framing that it took Nixon to go to China — a Democrat could not have done it. By the same logic, it took Vajpayee, a BJP leader, to go to Pakistan; it took Modi to go to Pakistan; Manmohan Singh could not go in all his 10 years. Because this is such a strong government — a BJP, right-of-centre government — the likelihood of something positive happening is greater under this dispensation than any other.

But I would say the onus is on Pakistan. If they can persuade the Indian political system that this is a prime minister who has genuinely been trying for two years — that they want to pivot to geoeconomics, get past this problem, and talk — then the chances improve, provided there is some guarantee that it won't be back to square one.

What do you make of the chatter about the RSS also talking of engaging with Pakistan? Should we read anything into it?

It is not insignificant, but I don't think it is an orchestrated move — the government signalling through the RSS in close consultation. It reads as a fairly innocent, first-principles instinct: let's solve this problem.

SIT to probe Ahmedabad blast & fire that killed 9, cracker unit owners held

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, July 19

A DAY after nine persons were killed and six others injured in a blast and fire at a firecracker factory in Ramol area, the Ahmedabad city police on Sunday arrested three persons who were running the illegal unit.

Police Commissioner Anupam Singh Gahlaut said that the licence of the firecracker unit had expired in March and that the accused were illegally operating it for the past 20-25 days, taking advantage of police's preoccupation in the bandobast for Rathayatra (held on July 16).

The three arrested accused have been identified as Ramila Dodiya, her son Mehul and their partner Sadiq Saiyyed. They are expected to be produced before a court in Ahmedabad on Monday.

Addressing a press conference, Gahlaut said Mehul was operating the firecracker unit and his mother Ramila was handling its administration. "This (unit) was ordered to shut on March 4, 2026. And it was completely shut. It was



The site in Ramol area of Ahmedabad where a blast at an illegal firecracker unit killed nine and injured six, on Sunday. EXPRESS

being checked from time to time. However, for the past 20-25 days, taking advantage of police's preoccupation in Rathayatra, they had brought labourers from different parts of Dahod district and were making (firecrackers). ...they got orders of firecrackers from some places in connection with the upcoming immersion ritual of Lord Ganesha (Ganesh Visarjan). And these people were making the firecrackers from there. And the blast happened," Gahlaut said.

"It has also come to notice

That has been the instinct with the others, too.

In my assessment, the longer we go without spectacular terrorism of the Pulwama-Pahalgam level, the greater the chances of some reconciliation... if we go sufficiently long without a spectacular attack, there is a chance we would attempt again what we have tried at least four times since going nuclear. The current political calculation is that any attempt is too risky, because terrorism could sabotage it. But I would certainly advocate a line of communication with the Pakistan Army — covert or overt — to test whether there is a reasonable guarantee, and a reasonable appetite on the other side, for rapprochement.

What was the defining moment at Agra, and your assessment of how it played out?

My assessment is that Agra failed because of Musharraf's overreach on Kashmir — not, as is often claimed, because there was a hawk in the room called Advani, without whom Jaswant Singh almost had a deal. I don't think that is correct. Advani and Jaswant had a bit of a squabble, but they were finally on the same page, and Vajpayee backed them. The problem was the overreach on Kashmir. The earlier Musharraf was not as flexible as the later Musharraf, who was willing to do the four-point formula — essentially giving up the claim on Kashmir by making it irrelevant. Even for Musharraf, Agra was part of a learning curve.

The other thing to note about Agra is that Vajpayee was acutely conscious of the history of Indian leaders being conned by Pakistani ones; he had been a strong critic of Shimla in particular. He knew that at Shimla, on the last day, Bhutto had come to Mrs Indira Gandhi, folded his hands in a one-on-one meeting — "mujhe time de do" — and persuaded her that, given time, he would convert the LoC into the international border. That last meeting saved the 1972 summit from being the failure it would otherwise have been.

Musharraf attempted the same play — whether or not he had read that history — seeking one last, desperate meeting with Vajpayee in the hope of retrieving the summit. Vajpayee just smiled at him and said, "*General sahab, ab toh bohot late ho gaya*" — it is too late now. Had I been in Musharraf's shoes, I would have settled for a plain and simple agreement: we came, we met, we had a constructive round of talks, and we will continue the conversation. But he had overreached, and Vajpayee said a clear no. Learning from history, Vajpayee refused to be persuaded at the last moment of a summit that a Pakistani leader was sincere — because he felt Musharraf was not sincere enough, and more work needed to be done. My feeling, in retrospect, is that he was determined not to be conned.

Bihar Model Schools to be painted saffron, JD(U) objects

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 19

THE BIHAR government's decision to paint all 551 Model Schools in the state saffron is facing questions not just from the Opposition, but also from the BJP's primary ruling alliance partner, the JD(U).

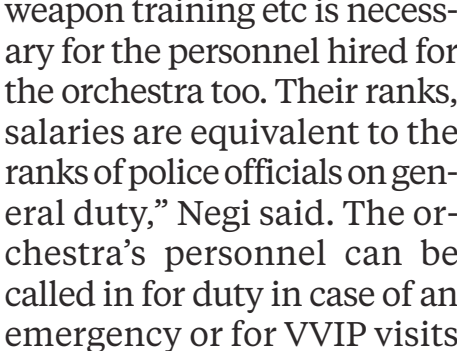
The Model Schools, renamed Saraswati Vidya Niketan (classes 9 to 12), were formally launched by CM Samrat Choudhary on Sunday at an event in Begusarai. The CM posted on X: "We have heralded a new age in education by inaugurating 551 Saraswati Vidya Niketan from Begusarai, the land of poet Ramdhari Singh Dinkar."

The state government said these schools were equipped

with modern digital infrastructure, e-libraries, and smart classrooms. They will also provide free JEE and NEET coaching alongside live interactive classes.

However, the decision to paint all these schools saffron, replacing the existing pink, sky blue, or yellow, has drawn criticism. The Bihar education department, in an order issued to these schools, directed them to adopt the saffron palette immediately.

Expressing concern, JD(U) chief spokesperson Neeraj Kumar said, "Education has no colour. It must align only with the spirit enshrined in the Preamble of the Constitution, not with any specific colour on school walls. Our other concern is that the names of the land do-



A Model School building

nors for several schools are being placed below the 'Saraswati Vidya Niketan' signage. Ideally, the donors' names should precede the new name."

The JD(U) is part of the BJP-led NDA government in Bihar.

A headmaster of a Model School, speaking on the condition of anonymity, said school authorities were asked to paint

the buildings saffron at the earliest. "Earlier, there were no specific directives on colour. It used to be yellow, pink, or even sky blue from time to time. Of late, the schools have mostly been painted pink. However, those choices were left to the headmaster's discretion. The new education department letter specifies that there must be uniformity across all model schools. While the exterior walls must be saffron, the interior classroom walls have to be white, and the main gate must be painted golden," the headmaster said.

RJD national spokesperson Subodh Kumar Mehta told *The Indian Express*: "We saw it coming. It is nothing but the beginning of the saffronisation of education. This is the RSS model

of education. The day the BJP-led NDA government decided to rename Model Schools as Saraswati Vidya Niketan, we could sniff the RSS agenda."

Bihar Congress spokesperson Asit Nath Tiwari said: "The BJP is adept at changing colours. They are trying to give education a fixed colour, which is detrimental to democracy. It also signals that Bihar has entered the post-Nitish Kumar era. The BJP is slowly walking into the RSS trap." Defending the move, BJP state vice president Santosh Patk said the choice of colour represents "energy and positivity".

"The Opposition is unnecessarily politicising a progressive infrastructure upgrade that will benefit thousands of students," he said.

‘PENETRATION INTO TIER-2, TIER-3, RURAL MARKETS IS CRUCIAL FROM AN INCREMENTAL GROWTH VIEW’

Consumer firms eye rural growth as q-comm reshapes urban mkts

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 19

AS CONSUMER companies look beyond crowded urban markets for growth, “micro-markets” have emerged as a key strategy. Tata Group-backed Trent, which operates the Zudio brand, highlighted this approach in its annual report for 2025-26, pointing to its focus on expanding across micro markets rather than focusing only on comparative store performance.

These micro-markets, which vary across companies, refer to highly segmented, untapped regions that make it easier for companies to focus their efforts. Tier-1 and tier-2 cities, which have a population with increasing wage growth and aspirational demand, form a large part of the micro-markets for most consumer companies.

Like Trent, many other consumer brands have started shifting their focus towards the hinterlands for growth, as rural demand continues to outpace urban demand, while digitalisation has led to the rapid growth of new-age platforms in bigger cities, saturating the

space for traditional players.

Rural demand growth has continued to outpace urban demand, led by higher agricultural wages, favourable monsoons over the past couple of years that boosted crops, and growth in the rural non-farm economy. This has shifted consumption patterns in these regions, with rural consumers becoming increasingly aspirational. While the El Niño forecast later in the year could affect rainfall and temporarily hamper the momentum, analysts expect rural demand to remain strong going forward.

Many consumer brands have acknowledged this shift and made efforts to expand into tier-2 and tier-3 cities, a trend also reflected in their earnings.

In their earnings announcement on July 11, Avenue Supermarts, which operates the retail chain D-Mart, noted that its stores in non-metro cities performed much better than the older stores in bigger cities in the April-June quarter.

“In large metros, growth in older stores, which have significantly higher revenue per square foot, was flat this quarter. While stores in non-metros continue to grow well,”

• CONSUMPTION PATTERNS BEYOND METROS

RURAL DEMAND growth has continued to outpace urban demand, led by higher agricultural wages, favourable monsoons, growth in rural non-farm economy

WHILE THE El Niño forecast could affect rainfall and temporarily hamper the momentum, analysts expect rural demand to remain strong

MICRO-MARKETS, which are in focus, are highly segmented, untapped regions that make it



easier for firms to focus their efforts. Tier-1 and tier-2 cities form a large part of micro-markets

said Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer Anshul Asawa. These stores played a major part in the company’s 15% revenue growth during the quarter, the management said.

Other retail conglomerates such as Tata Group’s Titan and Reliance Group’s retail ventures have also expanded to the hinterlands, with a large chunk of the new stores added every quarter placed in regional hubs and smaller locations.

The same is true for quick-

service restaurant companies like Jubilant Foodworks and Devyani International, which run the Indian outlets for international brands like Domino’s, KFC, and Pizza Hut. These companies had earlier focused on increasing their store density across urban hubs so that a Domino’s or a Pizza Hut is present in every locality in a big city.

Traditional FMCG players, which earlier focused on specific rural hubs with dense populations, have expanded further

into the hinterlands on the back of digitalisation and improving trade channels. After the Covid-19 pandemic, companies such as Hindustan Unilever (HUL) and Nestle India have launched and optimised specialised programmes to aid this.

“If we look at any FMCG company pre-Covid, a large part of the focus was on the urban markets. A lot of the big names such as HUL and Nestle already have almost 100% coverage in the urban market. Thus, penetration into tier-2, tier-3, and rural markets becomes important from an incremental growth perspective,” said Ronak Shah, an analyst tracking the consumer sector at Equirius Securities.

The shift in focus to smaller and untapped markets has been gradual and was driven by several factors. A major reason behind this shift is firms chasing incremental growth. Another key reason is the high competition provided by new-age quick commerce platforms such as Zepto, Swiggy’s Instamart, and Zomato’s Blinkit, with most of their sales coming from metropolitan cities. **FULL REPORT ON**

[WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](#)

Healthcare crisis in US, regulatory curbs weigh on Indian IT companies

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 19

EARNINGS FOR most Indian IT companies so far have shown resilience on several fronts, even as the demand outlook remains clouded by factors such as geopolitical uncertainty, client budget cuts and rising AI spends.

While each IT major has its own set of clients spread across various verticals, all these players have singled out one segment that has underperformed across the board — the healthcare and lifesciences vertical in the Americas.

For example, revenue from Wipro’s Health vertical, which accounts for 14% of its overall revenue, fell 2.6% sequentially in Q1. In its post-earnings conference call on Thursday, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Srinu Pallia said budgets of US-based healthcare providers and insurers have remained flat due to pressures in the US healthcare ecosystem, with these companies also looking to increasingly spend towards AI.

“Their budgets have been flatish for us, and in some places we have seen negative growth. Also, most of the budgets right now are being reallocated to some kind of discretionary spending, but towards AI,” Pallia said.

Other IT majors have also seen revenue from the segment decline sequentially in Q1 — by 1% for TCS and 0.5% for HCL Technologies. Tech Mahindra was the only exception, with the segment registering positive growth of 2.6%.

Why healthcare underperformed

A large chunk of the healthcare and lifesciences verticals

• Healthcare revenue drags IT majors in Q1

Company	Revenue change from health	Rev share (QoQ change)
TCS	-1.0%	10.3% (-10 bps)
Wipro	-2.6%	14.0% (-20 bps)
HCL Tech	-0.5%	14.0% (-20 bps)
Tech Mahindra	2.60%	7.3% (unchanged)

Note: Health refers to Healthcare and Life sciences. All changes are QoQ, in constant currency terms
Source: Exchange filings

of Indian IT majors comprises US-based healthcare providers, insurers, life sciences companies and medical device manufacturers. The US healthcare system has faced an affordability crisis since the Covid-19 pandemic, prompting the government to tighten scrutiny and introduce measures that have pressured companies in the sector over the past few years.

Some of the measures include capping prices of critical drugs and aggressively squeezing medicare-related costs, which is positive for citizens but have sharply hit the margins of companies in the sector.

“The government crackdown has reduced the discretionary spending power of US health companies and payers. What has made it worse for Indian IT companies is that these US clients have now focused their limited spending ability towards AI and automation to reduce costs in that way as margins remain squeezed,” an analyst tracking the IT sector at a domestic brokerage said.

Traditionally, healthcare companies in the US approached Indian IT firms for jobs such as server maintenance, back office operations, and compliance. However, they are now spending heavily on AI, in which the Indian ma-

jors face much more competition from global AI companies.

‘Spending shifts towards AI’

“It is very difficult to say from here what the issue is. It might be a sector-specific issue, or maybe a client-specific one. But discretionary spending, where you experiment on new stuff, is definitely declining in favour of AI spending,” said Sunny Agrawal, head of research at SBI-CAPS Securities.

These factors have led to the healthcare and life sciences vertical being on a declining trend over the past year across many Indian IT majors. For instance, Wipro has seen their revenue from the segment falling sequentially in three of the last four quarters. HCL Tech saw its revenue from the segment fall 1.8% in FY26.

However, some of these companies expect performance from the segment to improve in the upcoming quarters. TCS Managing Director and CEO K Kirishivasan said he expects the vertical to pick up in the Q2 earnings. Wipro’s Pallia said while companies in the American healthcare sector focus on AI, he expects new opportunities such as AI implementation and compliance to also arrive.

FY27 growth seen 6.5-6.8%: Deloitte

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, July 19

DELOITTE INDIA on Sunday projected India’s economy to grow at 6.5-6.8% in the current fiscal, with growth expected to strengthen in the second half of the year supported by festive demand, monetary easing, and a gradual stabilisation in global conditions.

In its latest edition of Economic Outlook report, Deloitte said India entered 2026 in a Goldilocks phase, with macroeconomic fundamentals appearing unusually well balanced, but geopolitical developments altered the global landscape with tensions in the West Asia disrupting critical shipping routes, triggering volatility in commodity prices and weakening investor sentiment.

This resulted in a wider trade deficit, sustained capital outflows, and a sharp depreciation of the rupee against the US dollar within a matter of weeks.

Against this backdrop, the RBI had last month lowered India’s GDP growth estimates for current fiscal to 6.6%, from 6.9% estimated earlier. GDP grew 7.7% in the previous (2025-26) fiscal.

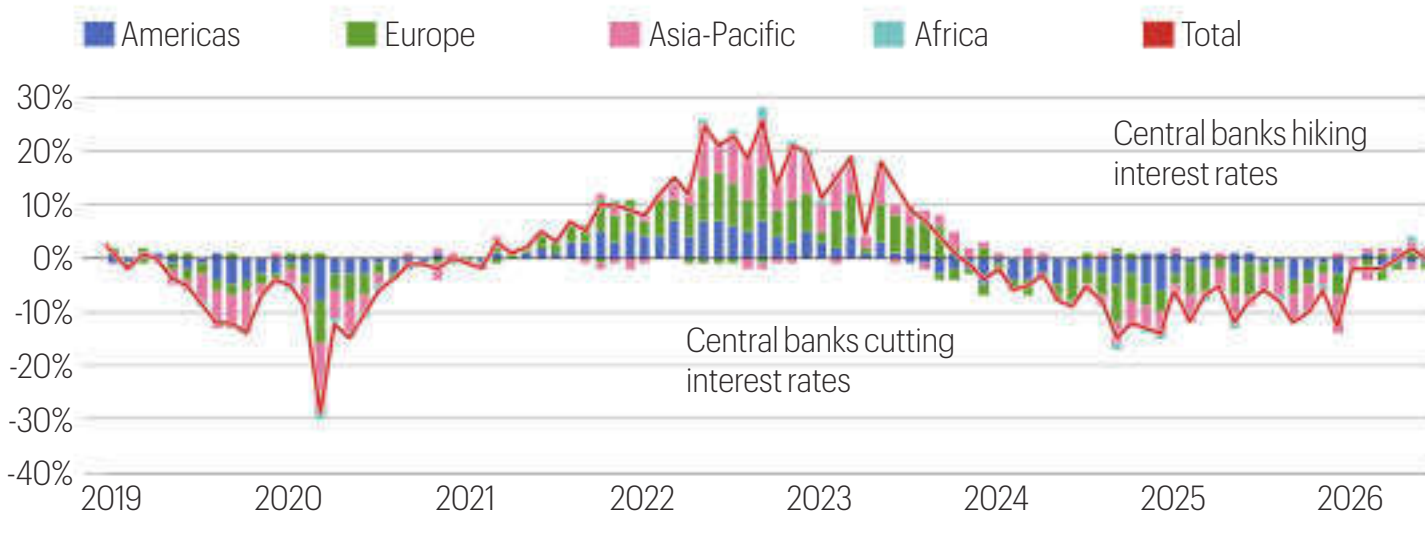
Deloitte India Economist, Rumki Majumdar said the global environment has become considerably more uncertain.

“While recent geopolitical developments and the RBI’s policy measures may help cushion some of these risks, weather-related uncertainties, particularly the impact of El Niño on agricultural output and food prices, remain an important downside risk,” she said.

“Deloitte expects India’s economy to grow between 6.5% and 6.8% in FY27. Growth is likely to remain moderate in the first half before strengthening in the second half, supported by festive demand, monetary easing, and a gradual stabilisation in global conditions,” Majumdar said.

• ‘RATE HIKES WILL NOT REOPEN THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ’

Central banks are having to be more careful than usual given the growth, inflation uncertainty caused by the geopolitical and trade shocks, according to a report by Moody’s Analytics.



SOURCES: BANK FOR INTL. SETTLEMENTS, MOODY’S ANALYTICS

Higher inflation, even if temporary in nature, strengthens the case for tighter monetary policy, especially at a time when the AI boom has kept growth strong and asset prices elevated. But raising interest rates to curb inflation is less effective

now than say, in 2022, as demand is already weak across much of the world, contended Moody’s Analytics. “...most central banks have not eased much since the 2022 tightening cycle, and rates in many countries sat in contrac-

tionary territory before the West Asia flared up. Much of the easing was meant to happen this year. Instead, the conflict and the murky outlook have forced many policymakers to hold steady or nudge rates higher.”

SOURCE: MOODY’S ANALYTICS

Samsung cuts jobs in US, offers relocations ahead of HQ move

Reuters
Seoul, July 19

SAMSUNG ELECTRONICS has cut jobs at its US display, phone and other consumer electronics operations — affecting workers mainly in New Jersey and Texas, according to documents and two people familiar with the matter.

The South Korean tech giant said on Sunday in a statement to Reuters that 739 roles in Englewood Cliffs, New Jersey, have been affected by plans by Samsung Electronics America (SEA) — which is focused on consumer electronics and does not include chips — to move its headquarters to Texas.

A majority of people affected have received relocation offers, but others were let go, it added without elaborating.

At SEA’s Plano, Texas office, some 100 workers including staff in its mobile division, have been let go, according to one person who said they were among the employees laid off. Sources declined to be identified because of the sensitivity of the issue.

The cuts — though related to the shift in headquarters — underscore diverging fortunes within the South Korean tech giant with its chip division skyrocketing to record profit but its consumer electronics units languishing as chip costs surge.

Samsung’s decision to shift SEA’s headquarters is striking because SEA employees in New Jersey only moved to new offices with much fanfare less than a year ago. SEA employs about 1,200 workers in New Jersey, according to a press release by US Representative Josh Gottheimer, who attended an event to mark the opening of the new offices in September.

While the precise extent of the layoffs at SEA could not be learned, documents seen by Reuters show that the unit notified some employees on June 30 of an “enterprise-wide reduction-in-force”.

‘Semicon 2.0 to drive investment for chips’

New Delhi: Provisions under Semicon 2.0 to provide incentives to Indian chip-making firms against equity are expected to drive largescale investment required for the development of advanced chips for technology such as artificial intelligence, a senior government official has said.

Under Semicon 2.0, which has a budget of Rs 1.27 lakh crore, the central government

has prioritised chip design by Indian companies.

In an interview to PTI on Saturday, Ministry of Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said advance chip design may need thousands of crores of investments.

“Under design-linked incentive scheme, you get only about Rs 15 crore. Now, to design high-end chips you need Rs 1,000 crore or more,” he said. PTI

• INDIA-AUSTRALIA URANIUM DEAL: THE COUNTRY IS SECURING URANIUM AS IT AIMS TO EXPAND NUCLEAR POWER CAPACITY TO 100 GWE BY 2047

Why domestic reserves are not enough to fuel India’s nuclear ambitions

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 19

EARLIER THIS month, India secured a long-term uranium supply deal with Australia, marking the first major outcome of the India-Australia Civil Nuclear Cooperation Agreement signed nearly 12 years ago.

While the volume of uranium oxide, or yellowcake, to be supplied and the duration of the agreement have not been disclosed, the deal follows similar long-term uranium supply agreements signed with Canada and Kazakhstan earlier this year, underscoring New Delhi’s efforts to diversify and secure fuel supplies for its planned expansion of nuclear power generation.

The agreement comes as India pursues an ambitious tar-

get of expanding its civil nuclear power capacity to 100 gigawatt-electric (GWe) by 2047 and, last year, opened the tightly regulated civil nuclear sector to greater private participation.

Uranium, a common element found worldwide, must undergo several processing stages before it can be used as nuclear fuel. These include mining and milling, conversion, enrichment (where required), and fuel fabrication.

But where does India currently source the uranium that fuel its nuclear reactors? And what role do the domestic uranium reserves play in meeting the country’s growing demand?

India needs more uranium supply

For the country’s indigenous pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWRs), which run

on natural uranium, fuel requirements are met through a combination of production from state-owned Uranium Corporation of India Ltd (UCIL) mines and imports. Enriched uranium used in the two light water reactor (LWR) variants — Tarapur Nuclear Power Plant and Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant — is entirely imported.

The domestic uranium oxide reserves currently stand at around 4.3 lakh tonnes, spread across 47 uranium deposits located in Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Jharkhand, Meghalaya, Rajasthan, Karnataka, Chhattisgarh, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Maharashtra. UCIL has the mandate to mine and process uranium ore in the country and operates major mines in Jaduguda and Tur-



Uranium must undergo several processing stages before it can be used as nuclear fuel. REUTERS

amdih in Jharkhand and Tummalapalle in Andhra Pradesh.

However, the uranium requirement for only 2.4 GWe out of the country’s total 8.7 GWe capacity is currently met

• URANIUM DEFICIT

DOMESTIC URANIUM oxide reserves stand at around 4.3 lakh tonnes, spread across 47 uranium deposits located in Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Jharkhand, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh among others

BUT URANIUM requirement for only 2.4 gigawatt-electric out of the country’s total 8.7 gigawatt-electric capacity is currently met from domestic sources while the rest is met through imports

from domestic sources while the rest is met through imports, a committee constituted by the Ministry of Power to prepare a roadmap for 100 GW nuclear capacity by 2047

noted in June 2025.

“Thus, to meet the target of 100 GW of nuclear capacity in 2047, India would need to augment uranium supplies and also have commensurate processing and fabrication capabilities,” it added.

The committee estimated that in 2047, the country will need an additional 8,029 tonnes of natural uranium and 1,045 tonnes of enriched uranium annually.

NSG waiver, global uranium partnerships

The country’s ability to import uranium for its civil nuclear reactors was unlocked in 2008, when the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) granted it a ‘clean’ waiver, making it the only non-signatory to the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) to

enjoy such trading privileges.

Government data shows that between 2008-09 and 2024-25, India imported a total of 18,842.60 metric tonnes (mt) of uranium in the form of uranium ore concentrate, natural uranium dioxide pellets and enriched uranium dioxide pellets for reactors operating under International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) safeguards.

In 2024-25, nuclear power plants generated 56,631.48 million units (mu) of electricity, of which 39,180 mu was produced using imported uranium, according to government data. The estimated requirement of imported natural uranium for operating and proposed safeguarded PHWRs is around 9,000 metric tonnes of uranium during 2025-2033.

India currently imports uranium from Russia and Uzbekistan. Shipments from Canadian mining company Cameco Corp., under the \$2.6-billion supply agreement signed in March, are expected to begin next year. Kazakhstan is also expected to emerge as one of India’s most significant uranium suppliers after Kazatomprom, the world’s largest uranium producer, agreed in February to sell a substantial volume of uranium to India. Both Cameco and Kazatomprom were among India’s major uranium suppliers until 2020-21.

Apart from these countries, France supplied uranium ores and concentrates to India in 2025-26, while similar imports were received from the US in 2024-25, according to trade data.

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• GLOBAL

US, Iran trade lethal strikes again: Their motives, lessons

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 19

THE US and Iran have attacked each other viciously in the last one week, blowing multiple holes into the already tattered Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) they signed on June 17. On Saturday, two US military personnel were killed in Jordan. The US has retaliated, raising the spectre of an all-out war once again.

The MoU had hinged on the capability Iran had demonstrated to control the Strait of Hormuz. The recent tensions hinge on the US attempting to demonstrate that it can loosen Tehran's chokehold on the strategic international waterway, through which 20 per cent of the world's energy supply flows.

Takeaways of war for both

Iran has said that US strikes have killed at least 50 people and wounded more than 500 in the post-MoU round of hostilities. The MoU had promised major economic relief to a country crippled by sanctions. Yet, Iran's unwillingness to back down is because of two factors — the conviction that the US cannot be trusted, and the imperative to maintain control over the Strait of Hormuz, its biggest leverage.

Thus, Iran has continued to escalate wherever it sees the need, attacking US military bases in its neighbouring countries.



A bridge destroyed after a strike in southern Iran. AP

• INDIA'S CONCERN

● A return to war will bring serious challenges at a time the Indian economy is already facing headwinds.

● New Delhi is urging both parties to return to dialogue and diplomacy, and to not put the global economy on a slowdown.

high-speed, manoeuvrable missiles at US bases in the region, highlighting the threat that the advancement of Iran's ballistic missile programme poses to US security interests, according to ISW.

The ISW said Iranian leaders focused on missile accuracy after the 12-day war in June 2025. Iran had struggled with relatively poor missile accuracy in its strikes against Israeli military targets in March and April 2026 too, which likely pushed it to deploy cluster munitions at a greater scale in order to maximise damage.

For the US, the experience has been a re-hammering of the lessons it learnt after the wars in Afghanistan and Iraq — that too much firepower, poorly applied, only produces more enemies. A major goal for the US now is to ensure Hormuz remains free for movement, like it was before it, along with Israel, attacked Iran on February 28.

Stakes for India

For Delhi, a return to open war means more lives at risk, as many Indians live and work in West Asia, apart from the large population of Indians that make up ship crews. Fourteen Indians have died since the war began on February 28, while two more are missing. New Delhi has protested with both Iranians and Americans over the loss of lives — mostly of seafarers and some Indians living and working in the Gulf.

War will also bring serious economic challenges. The Indian economic situation is facing headwinds with the rise in energy prices, which has had a debilitating impact on its markets. The inflationary impact of West Asian developments is already visible.

• ECONOMICS

Poor monsoon's impact on India's agri import bill



HARISH DAMODARAN

IN 2025-26 (April-March), India imported a record 16.9 million tonnes (mt) of vegetable oils and 1.1 mt of raw cotton, valued at \$19.5 billion and \$1.9 billion respectively. Further, it imported nearly 6 mt of pulses — the highest after 2024-25 and 2016-17 — worth \$3.6 billion (*table 1*).

The current fiscal could see even these records broken, thanks to El Niño. The impact of this climate phenomenon — an abnormal warming of the central and eastern Pacific Ocean waters off the coasts of Peru and Ecuador, associated with dry weather across India, Southeast Asia and Australia — is already being felt.

Rainfall for the country in June was 38% below the normal long-period average for the month. While July so far has registered a lower 9.9% shortfall, the cumulative deficiency for the four-month southwest monsoon season (June-September) as on July 19 is still at 23.8%.

Kharif sowing lag

The lack of rain has affected plantings of most *kharif* (monsoon-cultivated) crops. While overall sown area till July 10 was 16% below that for the same period of 2025, the decline was even more in pulses (23.3%) and oilseeds (21%).

Within pulses, the year-on-year acreage drop was 30.3% for *arhar* (pigeon pea) and 29.7% for *urad* (black gram). In oilseeds, it has ranged from 16% for soyabean to 34% for groundnut and 46% for sesamum. The progressive area sown under cotton, too, has fallen 15.3% from last year's corresponding coverage (*table 2*).

"Rainfall has been weak and also scattered. There are areas within 20-25 km of the same *taluka* (sub-district) that have received showers and those that haven't," said Nitin Kalantri, a leading dal miller from Latur in Maharashtra.

The monsoon's revival seen during the first week of July should help somewhat close the above gaps and may be reflected in the Agriculture Ministry's *kharif* sowing

• How India's imports of these three have soared

Year (Apr-Mar)	Vegetable Oils		Pulses		Raw Cotton*	
	Quantity	Value	Quantity	Value	Quantity	Value
2016-17	140.07	10892.75	66.09	4244.13	5	946.88
2017-18	153.61	11637.48	56.08	2908.33	4.69	979.32
2018-19	150.19	9890.32	25.28	1140.76	2.99	633.05
2019-20	147.22	9672.88	28.98	1440.09	7.44	1328.42
2020-21	135.4	11089.12	24.66	1611.72	2.31	385.89
2021-22	142.78	18991.62	27	2228.95	2.24	559.55
2022-23	157.45	20837.7	24.96	1943.89	4.52	1438.69
2023-24	155.2	14871.66	47.39	3746.78	2.52	598.66
2024-25	164.13	17366.26	72.56	5477.28	6.01	1219.32
2025-26	169.4	19488.41	59.64	3572.89	10.73	1888.79

QUANTITY IS IN LAKH TONNES AND VALUE IS IN \$ MILLION; *INCLUDES WASTE.
SOURCE: DEPARTMENT OF COMMERCE

data update on Monday.

"Sowing of pulses, including *arhar* (a 5-6 months crop), can take place till July-end. What we need is good rain over the next two weeks," added Kalantri.

The same goes for cotton, where the sowing window in the main growing belts of central and southern India usually shuts by mid-July. This can be extended till the month-end, if the monsoon is delayed or erratic.

"Cotton doesn't need too much rain. Also, the price sentiment for cotton is good this time, with many farmers keen to shift from rice and maize," M Prabhakar Rao, chairman and managing director of the Medchal (Telangana)-based Nuziveedu Seeds Ltd, pointed out.

According to him, less rainfall would be a problem more from the standpoint of pink bollworm (PBW) infestation, which can bring down crop yields: "PBW is a monophagous pest that feeds exclusively on cotton. Frequent rains help in disrupting the mating cycle of the adult moths, besides drowning the pupae in the soil. Prolonged dry weather is conducive for uninterrupted mating, egg-laying and the growth of larvae that bore into the developing bolls".

El Niño worries

While the monsoon rainfall deficit is

• Kharif acreage growth

Pulses	-23.32	Oilseeds	-21.01
Arhar /Tur	-30.29	Soyabean	-15.98
Moong	-10.63	Groundnut	-33.99
Urad	-29.72	Sesamum	-46.03
Moth Bean	-28.1	Sunflower	62.26
Cotton	-15.34	Coarse Grains	-22.47
Rice	-8.64	Maize	-19.54
Sugarcane	1.52	Bajra	-26.58
Jute & Mesta	1.95	Jowar	-23.64
All Kharif Crops	-16.03	Ragi	-16.22
		Small Millets	-29.27

(%, YEAR-ON-YEAR), AS ON JULY 10
SOURCE: DEPT. OF AGRICULTURE & FARMERS' WELFARE

quite significant now, the worry is more from a strengthening El Niño in the months ahead.

The US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) has forecast an 81% probability of the present El Niño intensifying into a "very strong" event during October-December, with a 97% chance of it persisting through the spring months till March-April.

Given that El Niño is known to not only suppress rainfall, but also raise temperatures, it could translate into a relatively short and warm upcoming winter. That can potentially hurt the ensuing *rabi* (winter-spring) season crops such as wheat, rapeseed-mustard, *chana* (chickpea), *masoor* (red lentil) and potato as well.

The brunt of all this would be borne by oilseeds, pulses, millets and cotton, which are predominantly rainfed crops, unlike rice, wheat or sugarcane. The current developing El Niño — which, NOAA believes, may turn out to be "among the largest...events in the historical record going back to 1950" — can result in India's vegetable oil, pulses and cotton imports also scaling a new peak.

The comfort factors

On the positive side, stocks of rice and wheat in government godowns, at 68.3 mt and 53.4 mt respectively on June 1, were way above the corresponding minimum

required levels of 13.5 mt and 27.6 mt for July 1.

Government agencies are also reportedly holding over 4 mt stock of pulses, which includes 2 mt of chana and 0.6-0.7 mt of *arhar*.

"They can offload these in a worst-case scenario. There is also scope to import, especially with fresh shipments of arhar from East Africa (Mozambique, Tanzania, Malawi and Sudan) expected in August-September. Likewise, *masoor* from Canada and Australia would be ready for shipping after September and November respectively. The voyage time for these would be 20-30 days," noted Kalantri.

Also, unlike in 2022, post Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the world is awash with ample stocks from the record global harvests of wheat, rice, corn (maize), sugar and even soyabean, rapeseed and palm oil in 2025-26.

The Food and Agriculture Organisation's benchmark food price index was up just 1.7% year-on-year in June. The only commodity of worry is vegetable oils, where the index in June was 23.3% higher than a year ago. The landed prices of imported crude palm, soyabean and sunflower oil in Mumbai, at \$1,235, \$1,292 and \$1,455 per tonne on Friday, was higher than their corresponding July 2025 average of \$1,095, \$1,191 and \$1,216 respectively.

A key reason for vegetable oil prices firming up is their alternate use as biofuel. When crude petroleum prices harden — as they are with the resumption of the conflict in West Asia — there is added incentive to divert palm, rapeseed and soyabean oil for the production of fatty acid methyl esters, which can substitute regular diesel.

In the coming days, if the monsoon continues to play truant, one can expect two actions from the government.

The first is a slashing of import duties — currently 16.5% on crude palm, soyabean and sunflower oil, 30% on yellow peas and 10% on *masoor* and *chana*. This will be alongside continuation of nil duty on imports of *arhar*, *urad* and raw cotton.

Secondly, one shouldn't rule out the government even going slow on the ethanol-blended petrol programme. That could involve bringing back restrictions on diversion of sugarcane juice/syrup and even intermediate-stage 'B-heavy' molasses for making ethanol.

• SPACE

Race for Low Earth orbit: What Vikram-1 launch means for India

Arav Shah

New Delhi, July 19

INDIA'S FIRST privately developed launch vehicle, Vikram-1, placed several technology demonstration satellites in Low Earth orbit (LEO) on Saturday morning.

The launch from Sriharikota by Hyderabad-based Skyroot Aerospace — India's first space unicorn — makes India only the third country globally to have private launch capability after the US and China. This comes after the government opened up the space sector to private companies in 2020 and formalised the framework under the Indian Space Policy of 2023.

Low Earth orbit

LEO is the zone immediately surrounding Earth and is typically defined as the region between 160 km and 2,000 km above our planet's surface. Satellites in LEO generally take 90-120 minutes to circle Earth. This proximity makes this orbit preferable for satellites meant for communications as well as Earth observation and imaging because it helps reduce signal latency.

"Today, orbital slots in the LEO work on a first-come-first-served declaration. The only obligation a new entrant has is to not interfere with the previous occupants. This



Vikram-1 lifts off from Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh, on Saturday. PTI

essentially makes it a literal gold rush," Ashwin Prasad Rao, staff research analyst at the Takshashila Institution's Outer Space programme, told *The Indian Express*.

Under the 1967 Outer Space Treaty, no nation or corporation can legally claim ownership over an orbit.

"What states are actually competing for is access to preferred orbital shells and advantageous radio-frequency slots managed by the ITU," Khyati Singh, research analyst at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses, told *The In-*

Partially reusable

● Although India doesn't have a reusable launch vehicle yet, ISRO's partially reusable Next Generation Launch Vehicle is projected to be operational in the mid-2030s.

dian Express. The International Telecommunication Union (ITU) is the United Nations agency managing radio frequencies and preventing harmful interference between two or more satellites.

An "orbital shell" is a layer of satellites at the same altitude (how high the satellite orbits above Earth's surface) and orbital inclination (angle of the satellite's orbit relative to the equator). Once a specific orbital shell is occupied, subsequent parties are expected to coordinate around the incumbents or migrate to clearer pastures.

So, this framework incentivises speculative "squatting", leading to countries designing and deploying satellite "megaconstellations" to encircle as much space as possible — like China's Guowang and Qianfan satellites.

A promising start

Vikram-1's success represents a massive leap for Indian private aerospace capability. It ensures New Delhi has assured access for launching small satellites, which are currently the most "underserved segment of the market," Singh said.

But its true strategic value lies in creating sovereign "surge capacity." "This grants India the ability to rapidly rebuild or increase the number of intelligence, surveil-

lance, and reconnaissance satellites on demand, without relying on ISRO, which is vital in an increasingly contested Indo-Pacific region," she said.

Securing this orbital access directly feeds into national security. "It is a huge information warfare tool," Rao said, pointing to the Starlink satellite system's role during the Iran war. He, however, cautioned against the "current model of overreliance on a few external providers", citing the increasing risk of security concerns.

Still some way to go

India is still far behind in the LEO race. To counter this vulnerability, India needs to ramp up its launch frequency. But this faces major structural bottlenecks.

"Two of the biggest roadblocks right now are the lack of scale that the sector is going through. The other is ISRO's elongated timelines for India's own reusable rocket which is one of the most critical components in ensuring frequent launches into the LEO," Rao said.

Building this ecosystem requires immense capital. While the government recently introduced a Rs1,000-crore venture capital fund to support early-stage space startups, an increase in direct procurement volume is the need of the hour.

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

In China's creation of new global AI body, a push for lead role in governance

Amitabh Sinha

New Delhi, July 19

SINCE 2018, the World AI Conference (WAIC) has been held annually in Shanghai to showcase Chinese advancements in artificial intelligence (AI). What has largely been an industry event has attracted global attention this year, thanks to the participation of Chinese President Xi Jinping. Several heads of state and UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres were also present upon his invitation.

Xi's presence led to the event doubling as a platform for presenting an alternative thought process and framework for global AI governance — an evolving subject that will be central to how the technology grows and who benefits from it.

What China is offering

At the core of this alternative perspective is the creation of a new international institution called World AI Cooperation Organisation, or WAICO. It is meant to ensure that

developments in (and benefits of) AI are accessible to everyone, even developing countries that lack the resources or capability to build their own AI systems from scratch. It also commits to "extensive consultation and joint contribution for shared benefit".

WAICO was proposed at last year's conference and has now been made operational. Along with China, 29 countries (including Pakistan and Russia) signed an agreement for its creation. It is being projected as a more "inclusive" alternative to the AI governance frameworks proposed by Western countries, which heavily emphasise ethics, values, safety and responsibility.

In this context, Xi's keynote speech on the opening day of the conference about the need to guard against "overstretching" of national security concerns is being widely quoted.

"AI development should not be a solo performance by a single country, but a symphony of international cooperation... we should jointly oppose overstretching the national security concept in the field of

AI and placing one country's security over that of others," he said.

Cornering technology

It is undeniable that AI, like other powerful technologies with wide-ranging impacts, has a very high risk of potential misuse. Nuclear technology, for instance, produces clean electricity, has applications in healthcare, agriculture and research, and is also behind the most devastating weapons known to the world.

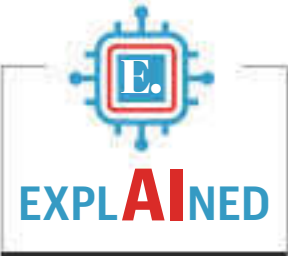
The misuse of AI is seen to have even more profound consequences for humanity. It is no surprise, therefore, that in conversations on governance or regulatory frameworks, issues of safety, ethics and responsibility are often emphasised.

But there is also a growing concern that these legitimate issues might become a cloak for technology denial or exclusion of

countries. Such concerns are not unfounded. Historically, issues concerning environmental standards, child labour, or intellectual property protection have been used to deny certain technologies, or impose trade restrictions and other sanctions.

Case in point, the sudden shutdown of the US-based Anthropic's new Mythos 5 and Fable 5 AI models last month, following a US government directive to suspend its access to all non-US nationals.

Since a bulk of AI development is happening in the United States, it is also spearheading public debates on governance and regulation, alongside like-minded countries in Europe and elsewhere. Globally, a disparate set of conversations on governance frameworks is ongoing. There is the UN-initiated Global Dialogue, and the recent AI Summit in New Delhi, which saw a group of countries facilitating these discussions.



A weekly column decoding AI's new frontiers, how they shape the world and our place in it

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, JULY 20, 2026

NEWMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY PHILIPP ACKERMANN

Year 2026 marks the 75th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between India and Germany. Given its key role in the EU and the strength of bilateral relations, Germany is one of India's most significant partners in Europe. German ambassador Philipp Ackermann, who has served in India from 2022 to 2026, and was posted in Delhi from 2007 to 2010, has witnessed the changing arc of the relationship. He has witnessed strengthening of bilateral ties and navigated the challenges — wars in Ukraine, Gaza and Iran and the volatility in geopolitics. As he heads to China, he is best placed to reflect on Indo-German ties in an increasingly uncertain world



ON RUSSIA'S INTERFERENCE

Russia wants to invade other countries in order to enlarge its territory. It is interfering heavily in every European country through cyber warfare. We have to be in a better position to defend ourselves



ON INDIA-EU FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

For us, the most important thing is perhaps India's Free Trade Agreement with the EU, which will change our approach to doing business with and in India. That it happened, is a milestone

Shubhajit Roy: One of Germany's success stories has been skill development. Why has it not taken off in India? Is it about dignity of labour?

One difference between India and Germany is that craftsmanship is given dignity in Germany. I come from a very small town in Bavaria where the dignitaries were, basically, the craftsmen — not the notaries, the teachers or the doctors. The baker whose family has been there for 400 years, the butcher, the roofer: generations of good craftsmen selling good bread, sausage and beer. They were the ones running the town. They sat on the city council. That is not so much the case in India. Not yet.

Aakash Joshi: Remigration, which was once a fringe idea, is very real now. Once such ideas start gaining currency, the engagement is not always rational.

Remigration is a word Germans do not like to use; it is linked to the extreme Right. But what the current government has done is reduce illegal immigration. That shows the government has understood that people have this feeling of being overwhelmed by migration, and it has said: We will organise migration in such a way that those who are useful to our society come to Germany.

Aakash Joshi: Post Cold War, there was one model for emerging countries. Increasingly, there is a deeper engagement with the Chinese model and a questioning of the once championed liberal values.

The post-Cold War conviction that there is only one solution for the world — an open-minded liberal democracy in which everybody is free to find their own way — was not entirely correct. Besides China, there are other examples of countries that are performing well without being set up as Western liberal democracies, including Singapore and Vietnam. Rwanda is one of Africa's big success stories. So we have to accept that there are different ways of structuring societies — as long as they do not threaten the territorial integrity of their neighbours.

Jatin Anand: How do you evaluate India's diplomatic footprint, especially under PM Modi?

India is becoming more and more a factor that you cannot ignore. All of us — not only India but also Europe — find ourselves in an environment that is far more difficult than it used to be. The war in the Gulf has made things difficult and it has had an impact on all our countries. Foreign policy, therefore, is much more complicated than it used to be.

Jatin Anand: On the raising of your defence budget, largely because of Trump's demands: do you think there is actually space, and a need, for investment in conventional warfare amid AI and drone technology?

Yes. And it is not just because of Trump. The rearming of European nations is because of Russia. When you look at our investments, they are not only in conventional warfare but also in cyber warfare and other domains. We need a new generation of aircrafts. We have to invest heavily in modern war technology — drones and the like. And Ukraine will be one of the most interesting countries in the world from which to purchase non-conventional war material. Zelenskyy is travelling to Saudi Arabia and the UAE, and they are all interested in what Ukraine has to offer.

Kaushik Das Gupta: On the heat crisis in Europe: the cities were not built for such heat. What does that mean for green politics in Germany?

At the end of June, it was hotter in Berlin than here. The heatwave was linked to some 10,000 deaths in Europe. Air-conditioning is the first idea that comes to mind. But in southern European cities — in Spain, southern France and Italy — there are ways to make cities cooler without spending too much energy. Greenery is important, as are huge parasol-like structures for shade. We have to think about how to make our cities cooler and that architectural thinking is now reaching central and northern Europe too.

Raj Kamal Jha: In your public diplomacy you engaged with art, literature, culture. Now that you are leaving India, is there something that still puzzles you about the country? And as you head to Beijing, what is the big question on your mind about China?

India is a place that never stops surprising you. I will never say that I understand India. I understand parts of India, and I am emotional about them. But there are always situations where you think: how is that possible? I like that because India is always in flux. What is very striking is that in Europe there is a clear line between the rational and the irrational. In India, this line is blurred in a surprising and convincing way. As for China, everything one reads is about modern China — post-1945, Communist China, Mao Zedong. Unlike in India, where history, tradition and culture always play a big role, with China it is all about recent politics. But Chinese civilisation is thousands of years of art, culture and great inventions. I am very curious to discover the roots of China — roots that shaped today's China, some of which, like Buddhism, came from India.

‘Indian migration is a success in Germany... I am impressed how Indians have integrated into the German labour market’

As he prepares to leave Delhi for Beijing after four years as Germany's Ambassador to India, Philipp Ackermann on 75 years of diplomatic ties, migration, Europe's security after Russia's invasion of Ukraine, and what still surprises him about India. The session was moderated by Shubhajit Roy, Diplomatic Editor, *The Indian Express*



German ambassador Philipp Ackermann (right) in conversation with Shubhajit Roy, Diplomatic Editor, *The Indian Express* GAJENDRA YADAV

How has the war complicated Germany's relationship with Israel?

This goes to the very foundations of modern post-war Germany. Support for Israel among the population is really shrinking. When you talk to young people now, an increasing number of people are critical of the Israeli government. This includes major political parties — the Social Democrats, the Greens — who were very critical of the current government. Chancellor Friedrich Merz stopped delivering arms to Israel when he felt that the Gaza war got out of hand. So there is an incremental change underway. There will never be a moment when Germany is not defending the right of existence of Israel. But in Germany, you now have a movement that is very strongly pro-Palestinian. That also has to do with migration: we have a lot of Syrian, Palestinian and Arab migrants in Germany, and that leads to conflicts and frictions. But when you read the government's policy statements on Israel, the main thing we now hear is harsh criticism of the settlements in the West Bank, which we consider illegal. I sense a certain cautious movement away from absolute support.

Shubhajit Roy: After Russia invaded Ukraine, you were forced to rearm. But Russia has not collapsed and is still fighting Ukraine. It has even got a fresh lease of life with the Strait of Hormuz closed.

Nobody wants the collapse of Russia. We had a long-standing relationship with Russia — there was a NATO-Russia Council, and Germans were explicitly reaching out to Russians, not only for business reasons but also for historical ones. We felt a responsibility towards a country that had suffered enormously during the Second World War. But what we woke up to one day was that Russia is an imperialist country that wants to invade other countries in order to enlarge its territory. That we cannot accept in Europe because we are built on the clear understand-

ing that territorial integrity is one of the most sacred conditions under which states work with each other. It is the basis of our cooperation and cannot be touched. And we have seen that the Russians don't care; they have no scruples about invading and they are willing to engage massively in the invasion of a country that is much smaller and weaker than them. It was a wake-up call, especially for my country, because after the war we believed we would live together in peace for eternity. That, unfortunately, did not turn out to be true. What we see now is Russia interfering heavily in every European country through cyber warfare. Just this morning we learned that there was a cyber attack on the electricity grid in Poland. It lasted only a couple of seconds and it would have succeeded if somebody had not intervened. Drones fly over airports all the time. So we

are, in a way, under attack: not direct attack, but cyber attack, and we therefore have to put ourselves in a new position to counter it. This war has now lasted longer than World War I. It shows that we have to be in a better position to defend ourselves — because who is to say the Russians will not attack Estonia, or some other country they feel should not exist?

Shubhajit Roy: You have come out in strong defence of NATO. But you have also seen the US commitment to the transatlantic partnership weaken, especially under President Trump. Last week, when he came for the NATO summit, he said he wouldn't have come if it were not Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan hosting it.

But the alliance stands, and what Trump

ON GERMANY'S STANCE ON ISRAEL

There will never be a moment when Germany is not defending the right of existence of Israel. But in Germany, you now have a movement that is very strongly pro-Palestinian. Israeli government is heavily criticised in Germany



{ W E E K L Y C A P S U L E }

The geography of dementia

A NEW STUDY, led by the University of Southern California, of more than 214,000 older adults from 14 countries and regions suggests that preventing dementia may require different strategies in different parts of the world. Researchers found that many of the most important modifiable dementia risk factors, including low education, high blood pressure, and smoking, vary dramatically between countries. For example, low education affected 85.6 per cent of older adults in China but only 12 per cent of those in the US. High BMI (body mass index) was found in 44.9 per cent of Americans compared with just 13.3 per cent Indians.



Exercise rewires the heart

REGULAR EXERCISE may benefit the heart in a way scientists are only beginning to understand. Beyond improving cardiovascular fitness, new research from the University of Bristol (UK) suggests that moderate aerobic exercise reshapes the nerves that regulate the heart. Researchers found, for the first time, that regular aerobic training changes the heart's controlling nerves differently on the left and right sides of the body. The study uncovered a striking left-right difference that may one day improve treatment strategies for irregular heartbeats, chest pain, angina and stress-induced 'broken-heart' syndrome.



How Ozempic slows ageing

RESEARCHERS AT University of California, San Diego, have found that semaglutide, the active ingredient in Ozempic and Wegovy, slowed biological aging markers in adults with HIV, marking the first clinical evidence that the drug may influence human aging. Although the findings are encouraging, scientists say larger studies are needed before concluding that the medication can help people age more slowly. GLP-1 medications reduce inflammation and improve metabolic health, which can decrease chronic immune activation, one of the major drivers of accelerated ageing.



Movie-watching slows down ageing

GOING TO the cinema, visiting museums, or attending concerts may do more than entertain. Researchers at the Institute of Science, Tokyo, found that older adults, who regularly participated in cultural activities, tended to have bodies that functioned like those of people about three years younger. They believe stronger social ties, better mental health and healthier habits could help explain the link. People taking part in cultural activities at least every few months had an average physiological age of 66.9 years. Those with lower levels of participation had an average physiological age of 69.9 years.



Chewing gum for BP control

A NEW study by King's College, London, found that chewing sugary gum after eating nitrate-rich vegetables or drinking beetroot juice helped the body produce more beneficial nitrite, leading to a temporary drop in blood pressure. Researchers hope the discovery will lead to healthier ways to enhance the cardiovascular and performance benefits of dietary nitrate without relying on sugar. Nitrate naturally accumulates in vegetables from the soil but it does not benefit the body until bacteria in the mouth convert it into nitrite. This helps relax and widen blood vessels, lowering blood pressure.





THE HEALING TOUCH

DR ROMMEL TICKOO
SENIOR DIRECTOR, INTERNAL MEDICINE,
MAX HEALTHCARE



They simply have a much narrower role than marketing suggests

Why your Omega-3 supps may not be helping your heart

Research has found little benefit for most healthy adults

PICTURE THIS: You're standing in the supplement aisle, staring at a bottle of fish oil that promises to "support heart health." It seems like a sensible investment. You don't eat much fish, so popping a capsule every morning feels like an easy way to protect your heart. It's a belief shared by millions of people. In fact, about one in five adults over 60 takes fish oil supplements. The problem? The science behind those claims doesn't hold up nearly as well. For years, the idea that fish oil supplements prevent heart disease was largely built on observational studies showing that populations eating more fatty fish had lower rates of cardiovascular disease. But observational studies can only identify associations — they cannot prove cause and effect. People who regularly eat fish also tend to have healthier overall diets, exercise more and consume less processed meat, all of which independently reduce cardiovascular risk. When researchers finally put fish oil supplements to the test in large, randomised controlled trials — the gold standard of medical evidence — the results were disappointing. A landmark meta-analysis published in *JAMA Cardiology* found that Omega-3 supplements were not associated with reductions in heart attacks, strokes, coronary heart disease or major vascular events. In other words, the cardiovascular benefits seen in people who eat fish did not translate into swallowing an over-the-counter fish oil capsule.

One reason is that eating fish delivers far more than just Omega-3 fats. Fish provides high-quality protein, vitamins, minerals and replaces less healthy foods in the diet. Simply isolating Omega-3 into a capsule doesn't recreate those dietary benefits. Unlike prescription medications, dietary supplements are regulated as foods rather than drugs. Manufacturers are not required to demonstrate that their products actually prevent disease before selling them. An analysis of more than 2,800 fish oil supplement labels found that roughly 2,000 carried heart health claims, despite the lack of convincing evidence. Researchers have also found substantial variability in the actual Omega-3 content of commercially available supplements. Some products contain far less of these Omega-3 fats than consumers expect. Omega-3 fatty acids are chemically fragile and easily damaged by heat, oxygen and light during manufacturing and storage. Oxidised fish oil loses biological activity and may even promote inflammation rather than reduce it. Laboratory testing has shown that many commercially available fish oil products contain significant levels of oxidation.

So are Omega-3 supplements useless? Not at all. They simply have a much narrower role than marketing suggests. Evidence supports Omega-3 supplementation — of prescription strength and not OTCs — in certain situations. Prescription-strength EPA (icosapent ethyl) has been shown to reduce cardiovascular events in selected high-risk patients who have elevated triglycerides despite taking statins. Fish oil at doses above 2 grams per day can significantly lower triglyceride levels. Omega-3s are important for foetal brain and eye development during pregnancy. Regular dietary Omega-3 intake may support overall brain and eye health. These benefits, however, should not be confused with preventing heart disease in otherwise healthy people using low-dose, over-the-counter supplements. They aren't completely harmless either. Fish oil supplements can cause fishy burps, bloating, nausea and diarrhoea. Higher doses (typically above 4 grams per day) have also been associated with an increased risk of atrial fibrillation in some studies. Most over-the-counter capsules contain around 300–500 mg of Omega 3, well below prescription doses used to lower triglycerides.

Supplementation may be reasonable for people who eat less than one or two servings of fatty fish each week, those with elevated triglycerides (under medical supervision) and specific medical conditions. For everyone else, especially those with normal triglyceride levels, there is little evidence that routine OTC fish oil supplementation prevents cardiovascular disease.



GETTY IMAGES

Reva Thakkar

AT 16, when Anushka Gaikwad stopped getting her periods, she did what most teenagers wouldn't — she visited the nearest clinic in her village of Cundaim in Goa. Instead of looking for an underlying hormonal problem, the doctor asked her to take a pregnancy test. Alarmed, Anushka persuaded her mother to seek another opinion in Panaji. A sonography finally revealed the real cause: Polycystic Ovarian Syndrome (PCOS), now referred to as Polyendocrine Metabolic Ovarian Syndrome (PMOS) to better reflect what doctors now understand about the condition.

Now 22, she says, "I realised later how little people, even healthcare providers, understood women's problems." Her experience is far from unique. PMOS is the most common endocrine disorder affecting women of reproductive age worldwide. But despite the name change, many still think of it as a disease of the ovaries. In reality, it is a metabolic disorder that affects nearly every system in the body — from insulin regulation and fertility to cardiovascular health, sleep, mood and mental wellbeing.

According to *The Lancet*, PMOS affects around one in eight women globally. In India, however, the burden is higher, with recent studies suggesting that one in five women may have the condition. "Almost one in five women below the age of 25 has some impact of PMOS, compared to the global average of around 8-13 per cent," says Dr Anshumala Shukla, head, Minimally Invasive Gynaecology, at Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital, Mumbai, who specialises in endometriosis, PMOS and is part of WHO efforts to draw up guidelines for the former. "Part of this is because India already has very high rates of diabetes and insulin resistance. Added to that are rapid urbanisation, easy access to processed food, sedentary lifestyles and rising stress levels," she says.

Why India is seeing early PMOS

The increase in diagnoses is partly because more women are seeking help for menstrual problems. "It's no longer taboo to see a gynaecologist," says Dr Meenakshi Ahuja, principal director, Obstetrics and Gynaecology, Fortis La Femme, Delhi. But awareness has not spread evenly. Women in rural areas often remain undiagnosed for years, while mothers — who are usually the first point of support for adolescent girls — have little understanding of the condition. India's underlying metabolic profile also makes women more vulnerable. A family history of diabetes and insulin resistance in-

One in five women now lives with PMOS

Why is it rising?

Once dismissed as an ovarian disorder, it is now understood to be a metabolic condition linked to insulin resistance, lifestyle and genetics

creases susceptibility to PMOS. While Dr Ahuja estimates India's overall prevalence at around 10 per cent, she says rates in cities — where sedentary routines and poor sleep are more common — may range between 25 and 40 per cent.

Dr Shukla believes the younger age at diagnosis is no coincidence. "Teenagers have higher screen times, eat unhealthy food and don't exercise regularly. Those with a genetic tendency start showing symptoms soon after they begin menstruating," she says. Then there is smoking, common among women in their 20s. This raises levels of free testosterone in the blood that manifests as acne, excess facial hair and hair loss. Smoking increases fasting insulin levels, worsening insulin resistance. This can lead to rapid weight gain and a higher risk of developing Type 2 diabetes. Smoking further triggers body inflammation and reduces your ovarian reserve (the number and quality of your eggs) by almost 20 per cent.

What are its symptoms?

Irregular periods remain the symptom that prompts most women to seek medical help but doctors say they are only one part of the picture. They look for irregular or delayed menstrual cycles caused by lack of ovulation, signs of excess male hormones such as facial hair or male-pattern hair loss, ultrasound evidence of enlarged ovaries with multiple follicles, and hormonal abnormalities in blood tests, including elevated Anti-Müllerian Hormone (AMH) levels, the last measuring the number of small, early-stage egg follicles in the ovaries. In women with PCOS, this follicle count is often very high.

The syndrome can also trigger weight gain, infertility, insulin resistance, sleep disturbances, anxiety and depression. For Nak-



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shatra Borgaonkar, the diagnosis came at 14. When her periods finally began, they came only once before disappearing for another five months. Ascan confirmed PMOS. A decade later, she says the diagnosis itself was not the hardest part. "Nobody really explained what was happening to my body. I was simply told to stop eating junk food and eat small meals, an advice that pushed me towards years of unhealthy eating habits," she says. She describes herself as having spent years on the eating disorder spectrum, fuelled by emotional eating linked to hormonal changes she barely understood.

For Tahera, 23, it was only after beginning treatment that she realised excessive body hair and persistent acne were symptoms of PMOS. Once prescribed oral contraceptive pills, she noticed her skin clearing and body hair reducing. Dr Shukla says these emotional consequences are common. "High testosterone levels can lead to weight gain, which causes anxiety and depression," she says. Irregular periods themselves also contribute to anxiety. Stress worsens the condition by increasing cortisol, which increases insulin resistance, which in turn worsens PMOS. Poor sleep compounds the problem. "You can't sleep at 3 or 4 in the morning and wake up at 11. That disrupts the body's circadian rhythm," says Dr Shukla.

Not just about losing weight

For years, PMOS treatment has been reduced to a familiar refrain: lose weight. "But it has more to do with hormonal imbalance and insulin resistance," says Ritika Samadhar, regional head, Clinical Nutrition and Dietetics, Max Healthcare. "If you don't address hormonal imbalance, any weight loss is likely to be temporary." That means focusing less on eating less and more on eating better. "The quality of food becomes more



• DECODING A STUDY

Air pollution may be quietly damaging your kidneys

A study of over 12,000 Indians found that long-term exposure to PM2.5 was linked to poor kidney function

Anonna Dutt

NOT JUST your lungs, high levels of air pollution may be damaging your kidneys too. Researchers found that increase in exposure to PM2.5 was linked to reduced filtration efficiency of the kidneys, according to a study that followed over 12,000 people for six to ten years. The findings were recently published in the journal *Kidney International Reports*. This decline was evident even when the researchers controlled other risk factors like diabetes and hypertension.

"This is part of an ongoing series of studies on the impact of air pollution on different diseases. So far, we have shown an association with higher air pollution levels and increased risk of hypertension, diabetes and dyslipidemia (high levels of blood fats like

cholesterol and triglycerides). Now, we have shown that pollutants impact kidney function as well. The association remained consistent even after controlling other factors, meaning the impact of air pollution on kidneys is not through the increases in diabetes and hypertension, but independently as well," says Dr V Mohan, one of the authors of the study and chairperson of Dr Mohan's Diabetes Specialties Centre, Chennai.

The participants were from Delhi and Chennai — two cities with very different levels of ambient air pollution. "The findings show that long-term exposure to fine air pollution may gradually reduce kidney function even in younger adults who do not already have chronic kidney disease (CKD)," adds Dr Mohan.

The PM2.5 levels in Delhi were much



GETTY IMAGES

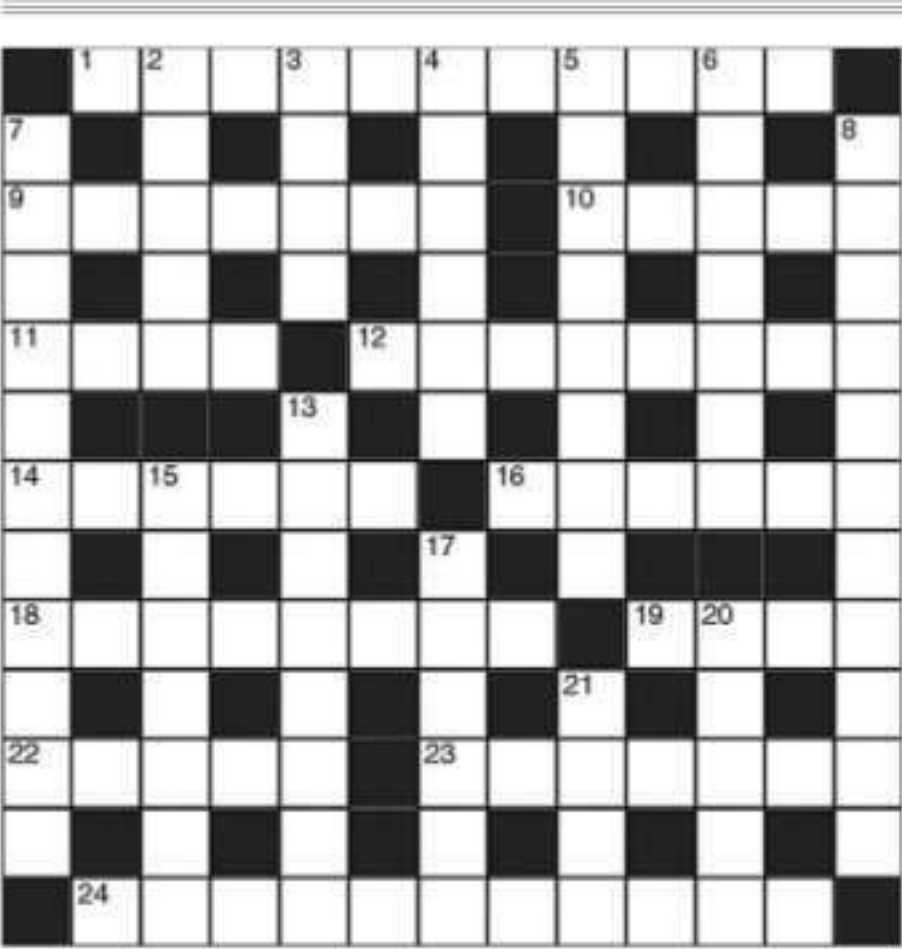
PM2.5 triggers systemic inflammation which damages cells and blood vessels

higher than Chennai during all three hospital visits by the participants during the study. The baseline PM2.5 level in Chennai stood at 33 mg/m3 and in Delhi 118 mg/m3. The levels stood at 37mg/m3 and 30 mg/m3 for Chennai during the subsequent visits

and 123 mg/m3 and 130 mg/m3 for Delhi. The doctors measured the estimated glomerular filtration rates (eGFR) — used to check the health of the kidney — and found it to be 112 mL/min/1.73 m2 for Chennai residents and 106.4 for Delhi residents. While both values are considered to be normal, people in Delhi were already starting with lower reserves. The decline was also sharper. The study found that every 5 mg/m3 increase in annual average PM2.5 levels led to a decline of kidney function by 0.42 in Delhi residents and 0.32 in Chennai residents.

"There could be as much as four per cent decline in a year. Kidney function goes down with age but if you start with lower reserves, the damage would be quicker," says Dr Doraiaj Prabhakaran, one of the authors and executive director of Centre for Chronic Disease Control. PM2.5 triggers systemic inflammation, oxidative stress that damages cells and blood vessels. The small particles directly enter the blood and then travel to the kidneys.

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Clubs maybe where admirals may be seen? (11)
9 Offer - or wait for a better offer (4,3)
10 A little hooter (5)
11 How much, say, is a unit of power? (4)
12 For Wagnerian hero standard fails unexpectedly (8)
14 In a wood there's a female angler (6)
16 Educational measure? (6)
18 Scholarly in theory (8)
19 High spot of getting married in a church (4)
22 Doctor, I have reduced energy (5)
23 Pitch of the roof? (7)
24 History teachers who are real experts? (4,7)

DOWN
2 Left out until rewritten (5)
3 African goes up into space (4)
4 Right sort of taxes without added charges (6)
5 It's close to home or posted a little way out (8)
6 Necessitate having to collect? (4,3)
7 A decisive manual exhibition (4,2,5)
8 Didn't miss any of the athletics meeting, anyway (2,3,6)
13 Submissive; always coming up with regular payment (8)
15 It's a man in distress. This may keep him going (7)
17 Not a bird; it chirps and flies (6)
20 A rich sort of job for a professor (5)
21 Catch sight of a pimple (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6044 ACROSS: 1 Friend, 4 Landlord, 9 Oracle, 10 Accuracy, 12 Peer, 13 Plumb, 14 Cute, 17 Miscalculate, 20 Out of service, 23 Okay, 24 Sweet, 25 Face, 28 Overpaid, 29 Strict, 30 Reporter, 31 Frayed
DOWN: 1 Foot pump, 2 In a sense, 3 Nile, 5 Accomplished, 6 Drum, 7 Opaque, 8 Dryden, 11 Black on white, 15 Nahum, 16 Start, 18 Vitality, 19 Dejected, 21 Colour, 22 Make up, 26 Spar, 27 Stir

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

It is not from reason that justice springs, but ____ is born of wisdom. - Maurice Maeterlinck (8)

IPSEO

GOETHS

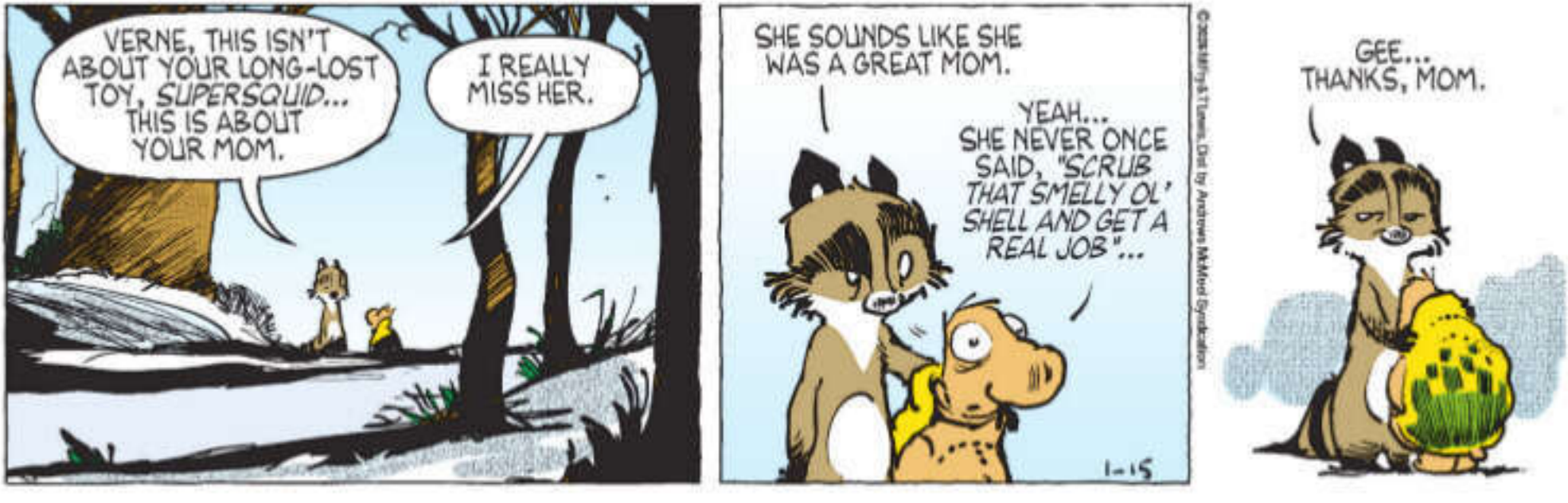
AERTNS

FIDGET

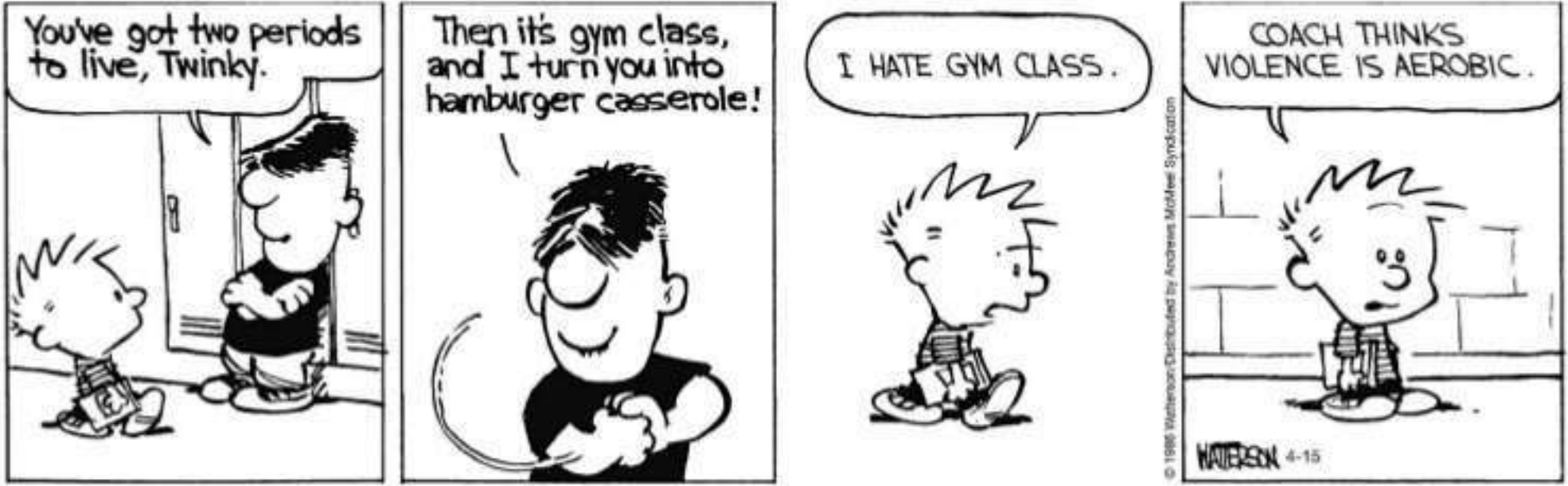
WISDOM

ANSWER: It is not from reason that justice springs, but **wisdom** is born of wisdom. - Maurice Maeterlinck (8)

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s
INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6385

2	7		5	4		8		
				8				
	3			7			4	
		6			5	7	8	
1	2	7				9		
5				6			9	
						2		
1		9	8		6	3		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6384

1	2	9	6	3	7	4	5	8
6	8	5	1	9	4	2	3	7
3	7	4	2	8	5	6	9	1
9	4	3	8	7	2	1	6	5
5	1	2	9	4	6	8	7	3
8	6	7	3	5	1	9	4	2
7	9	6	5	1	8	3	2	4
4	3	1	7	2	9	5	8	6
2	5	8	4	6	3	7	1	9

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

GORKHA RIFLES

Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave heart IC-53987 late Lt Puneet Nath Dutt, Ashok Chakra (P) of 1/11 GR, who made supreme sacrifice during Naushera Operation (J&K) on 20 Jul 1997. His raw courage valour and martyrdom will remain a source inspiration for all of us.

Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.

CONSTABLE DINESH KUMAR SINGH 93 BN BSF 10.07.1967 – 20.07.2001

CONSTABLE HARISH CHANDER 195 BN BSF 11.05.1970 – 20.07.1998

CONSTABLE HARI PAD KAR, PMG 50 BN BSF 23.01.1969 – 20.07.1995

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)

CONSTABLE SHIV NARAYAN MEENA

ITBP salutes its braveheart Constable Shiv Narayan Meena of 45th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Chhattisgarh in 2021.

CENTRAL INDUSTRIAL SECURITY FORCE

INSP/EXE KABUL SINGH HMT SRINAGAR

CISF proudly remembers the supreme sacrifice of the brave-heart. On this day, he laid down his life at the altar of duty. His courage and bravery would remain an abiding source of inspiration for the force. The force will remain eternally indebted to him for this noblest deed.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

Veer Balidani Head Constable Ajit Singh 124 Bn 2-1-1960 To 20-7-2001

Veer Balidani Constable Madhav Malakar 124 Bn 1-3-1968 To 20-7-2001

Veer Balidani Constable Pramod Kumar Behera 124 Bn 25-2-1966 To 20-7-2001

Veer Balidani Constable Ramesh Jadhav 124 Bn 9-7-1970 To 20-7-2001

Veer Balidani Constable D.Chakrayiah 124 Bn 12-4-1968 To 20-7-2001

Veer Balidani Constable/Driver Beant Singh 124 Bn 26-4-1968 To 20-7-2001

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to six valiant troopers of 124 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while countering an ambush by insurgents in Tirap district, Arunachal Pradesh on 20 July 2001. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Krishna Kumar 72 Bn 24-12-1959 To 20-7-1989

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Krishna Kumar of 72 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while countering an ambush by militants in Tarn Taran district of Punjab on 20 July 1989. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

कार्यालय मुख्य चिकित्सा एवं स्वास्थ्य अधिकारी, जिला बलरामपुर-रामानुजगंज (छ.ग.)

क्र. / लेखा/खनिज एवं न्यास मद / 2026 - 27 बलरामपुर, दिनांक / 07/2026

रुचि की अभिव्यक्ति के प्रकाशन की सूचना

उपरोक्त विषयान्तर्गत लेख है कि जिला बलरामपुर-रामानुजगंज (छ.ग.) के खनन प्रभावित क्षेत्रों में अल्ट्रासाउण्ड मशीनयुक्त मोबाइल मेडिकल यूनिट (USG MMU) का संचालन किया जाना है जिस हेतु रुचि की अभिव्यक्ति (एडक) के माध्यम से इच्छुक फर्मों से आवेदन आमंत्रित किया जाता है।

- रुचि की अभिव्यक्ति (EOI) के प्रकाशन की तिथि: 16.07.2026 से 01.09.2026 तक सायं 02 बजे तक।
- रुचि की अभिव्यक्ति (EOI) जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि: 01.09.2026 को दोपहर 02 बजे तक।
- इच्छुक फर्मों से प्राप्त रुचि की अभिव्यक्ति (EOI) खोले जाने की तिथि: 01.09.2026 दोपहर 03 बजे तक।

जिसकी विस्तृत जानकारी बलरामपुर जिले के वेबसाइट www.balrampur.gov पर अवलोकन किया जा सकता है।

नोट :- निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय में परिवर्तन किया जा सकता है।

मुख्य चिकित्सा एवं स्वास्थ्य अधिकारी जिला चिकित्सालय बलरामपुर-राजंज (छ.ग.)

No 262702183-4

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

D.R.M./C/AGRA/ATVM/Facilitator/2025 Date : 16.07.2026

NOTIFICATION

Calling for application for engagement of facilitators for Automatic Ticket Vending Machines. The Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, Agra Division, Agra- 282001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites applications from Divyanjan (Only locomotive disability) & General Public, for engagement of facilitators for issue of unreserved tickets through Automatic Ticket Vending Machines (ATVMs) installed at stations over Agra Division. The stations and the number of facilitators to be engaged against each are given below.

S. N.	Name of Station	Category of Station	ATVM 70% (Other)			ATVM 30% (Divyanjan)		
			No of ATVM	Facilitator To be engaged	Duration of Work	No of ATVM	Facilitator To be engaged	Duration of Work
1	Agra Cantt.	NSG-2	05	00	Contract valid for 31.03.2027	02	02	Contract valid for 06 Months
2	Mathura Jn.	NSG-2	07	01		02	04	
3	Agra Fort	NSG-3	04	04		02	06	
4	Raja ki Mandi	NSG-3	03	08		01	03	
5	Dholpur Jn.	NSG-4	01	01		01	03	
6	Idgah	NSG-4	01	02		01	03	
7	Kosikaian	NSG-4	01	03		01	03	
8	Bhuleshwar	NSG-5	01	02		01	03	
9	Kherli	NSG-5	01	03		01	03	
Total			24	24		12	30	

The advertisement notice and application form are available in North Central Railway website <https://ncr.indianrailways.gov.in>.

Date of issue of application form at the website 17.07.2026 (Friday)

Date of availability of application form at website 17.07.2026 (Friday)

Last date for submission of completely filled application form: Upto 13:00 Hrs. 11.08.2026 (Tuesday)

(1) Applications, along with all relevant terms and conditions, can be obtained from the office of the DRM (Commercial), Agra, on any working day (Monday to Friday) between 10:00 AM and 5:00 PM, from the date of notification until 10.08.2026 at 17:00 PM. (2) The prescribed form for depositing the application fee shall be obtained from the office of the Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, Agra. The application fee must be deposited at the Agra Cantt. Booking Office on or before 10.08.2026 by 17:00, and it shall be mandatory to obtain the Money Receipt (MR) as proof of payment. (3) Application forms can also be downloaded from the North Central Railway website, <https://ncr.indianrailways.gov.in>. The application fee is Rs 1180/- including GST (nonrefundable). This amount must be deposited at the Agra Cantt. Booking Office, and the original copy of the MR received must be attached to the application form and deposited in the designated box at the Divisional Office. (4) The completed application forms along with all desired documents must be submitted in a sealed cover to the office of the Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, North Central Railway, Agra by 13:00 hrs on 11.08.2026. The applications will be opened on 11.08.2026 at 15:30 in front of the assembled people. If the said date is declared a holiday for any reason, the applications will be opened on the next working day at the same place and time. (5) Applications received late/incomplete/wrongly filled/desired document not attached will not consider and will summarily rejected. (6) Railway administration reserves the right to postpone/modify or to cancel any one or all the application without assigning any reason. 1642/26 (MG)

KMML The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd (A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking), Sankaramangalam, Kollam 691583 Phone: 0476-2651215 to 217, E-Mail: md@kmml.com

TENDER NOTICE

For more details please visit E-Tendering Portal, <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> or www.kmml.com

Sl No	Tender Id	Items
1	2026_KMML_861027_1	Sundry transportation of Goods from various parts of the country to Kollam

Chavara 18.07.2026 Sd/- Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-HQ-2026-170

Description of work: Virangana Laxmibai-JHS East: Repairs and maintenance work of Railway Quarters and Service Building in Jhansi East Colony under the jurisdiction of ADEN/HQ/II/JHS in East Colony for Two Year.

Approx Cost: 32307643.32	Earnest Money: 646200.00
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Date of closing Tender: 10.08.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 24 Months

- Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 10.08.2026
- For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. 1647/26 (PH)

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.15/2026/RS/JHS Date: 16.07.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

For and on behalf of President of India, the Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (Rolling Stock) North Central Railway, Jhansi invites open tenders through online (E-Tendering) for the following work:-

Tender No.: JHS-RS-WC-T3-2026-27-RT1 Tender value: Rs. 17,07,08,88.00

Description: Yearly calibration of Electrical/Mechanical measuring & test equipment of Electric Loco shed, Jhansi for a period of 03 years.

Earnest Money: Rs. 35400.00

Completion period from the date of issue of LOA: 36 Months

Tender No.: JHS-RS-WC-T1-2025-26-RT5 Tender value: Rs. 37878000.00

Description: Electrical repair of Hitachi TM HS 15250.

Earnest Money: Rs. 757600.00

Completion period from the date of issue of LOA: 24 Months

Closing date of tender: 14.08.2026 for each tender. Tenderer will submit the tender online upto 14.08.2026 (15:00 Hrs.). Complete details & for submission of tenders can be seen in Indian Railway website <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. 1640/26(K)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @CPRONCR

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice No. 26/33 Dt. 17.07.2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

On behalf of the President of India, The Principal Chief Materials Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj, (An ISO 9001:2015 certified unit) invites the following E-Procurement Tenders:

S. N.	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Tender Opening Date
1	38261306	Brake Beam	2110 Nos.	17.08.2026
2	38261221	Side Frame Key	42075 Nos.	25.08.2026
3	30262821	Dump Valve for LHB Coaches	54 Nos.	18.08.2026
4	30262040	Primary Vertical Damper	4720 Nos.	11.08.2026
5	38264283	Automatic Pressure Modification Device	419 Nos.	20.08.2026
6	30252877A	Flex Ball Cable Short	108 Nos.	31.08.2026
7	30261692	Cut Off Angle Cock with Vent	8437 Nos.	03.09.2026
8	38262717	Side Bearer Assembly	1168 Set	10.09.2026
9	38261435	Pin with Washer and Bulb Cotter	83779 Nos.	15.09.2026
10	38261926	Centre Pivot Top	962 Nos.	22.09.2026

Note: The complete information of above tenders can be seen and downloaded from IREPS website i.e. <https://www.ireps.gov.in>. For any change / corrigendum in tender, please visit this website regularly. No separate corrigendum/change will be published in newspaper. 1655/26 (PH)

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Be patient with others today, because the Moon is opposite your sign, which means you will attract strong people to you. Discussions with partners, spouses and close friends will be lively. Express your creative talents. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Financial discussions will go well today. In fact, you will feel generous to family members and, likewise, they might be generous to you. Nevertheless, avoid confrontation with parents and authority figures. Tonight: Get better organised.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Interactions with kids will be lively. You might be attracted to competitive sports. You also might find yourself in a power struggle with a sibling or in a discussion about politics or religion that is a tad confrontational. Tonight: Socialise.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Family discussions about money might be aggressive, especially because someone behind the scenes seems to be steering the show. If you suspect this, walk away. Tonight: Relax at home.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Issues with those who are closest to you might be challenging today. Things might come down to a power struggle or a challenge of egos. Tonight: A lively discussion.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You're willing to work hard for your money today, which is why you might spend it just as fast. In part, this is because travel and exciting adventures are appealing right now. You also might be involved with a charitable society today. Tonight: Check your money.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You have lots of mental energy today, which is why you might get into an argument. Ask yourself if it's a worth it. Your charitable involvement with friends or groups will be appreciated. Even a small kindness makes a difference. Tonight: You win.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Avoid power struggles with parents, bosses and people in authority (including the police). Meanwhile, behind the scenes research will pay off in discussions about shared property, inheritances, taxes and debt. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): A discussion with a friend or a member of a group will be lively today. It could relate to your desire to help children in need. Or it might be related to the arts. Tonight: Be friendly.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Power struggles about money and possessions might take place today. If so, you won't hesitate to speak up to authority figures to defend your own best interests. Tonight: You're noticed by others.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Be careful of a ruthless desire to get ahead today, which might tempt you to coerce others into doing what you want. In fact, proceed with caution. Instead, use your energy to make travel plans or pursue avenues in higher education, medicine, publishing or the law. Tonight: Explore and learn.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Don't be too pushy at work today, especially if you're trying to introduce improvements. Meanwhile, you might make improvements at home or within your family. Co-workers might be generous to each other today. Tonight: Check your finances.

Tamil Nadu Power Generation Corporation Ltd

Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)

Specification No.	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of the Work
216	CE/Coal	TIME CHARTERING OF ONE NUMBER SELF TRIMMING PANAMAX OR KAMSARMAX GEARLESS BULK CARRIER VESSEL
217	CE/Coal	TIME CHARTERING OF ONE NUMBER SELF TRIMMING PANAMAX OR KAMSARMAX GEARLESS BULK CARRIER VESSEL

For details of works / Procurement / Due date of submission/Opening,viewing and downloading of a tenders, please visit websites: www.tnpsccl.org, www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in

DIPR/2313/Tender/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Gem Bid Notice 11/2026 E-Tender Notice Dated: 17.07.2026

Divisional Material Manager/Agra, North Central Railway, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-Tender for the following work.

Gem Bid No: GEM/2026/B/7709849 dt. 16.07.2026 EMD (Rs): 196180/-

Description: XLPE Cable for Working Voltage.

Qty: 16450 MTR Gem Bid Opening Date: 17.08.2026

Note: (1) The complete information of above Gem Bid are available on GEM website i.e. <https://www.gem.gov.in>. (2) Bids other than in the form of e-Bids shall not be accepted against above Bid. For this purpose, Vendors are required to get themselves registered with GEM website. (3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall only be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head attached by vendor shall be straight away ignored and shall not be considered. (4) Documents being attached should be signed on their body. (5) Allocation for "Cost of Drawing" is Z-650 and for "Earnest Money deposit (EMD)" is Deposit Misc. stores-00844517. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the GEM website may be approached. 1656/26(K)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @CPRONCR

हसदेव बरॉज जल प्रबंध संभाग

रामपुर/कोरबा जिला कोरबा (छ.ग.)

-: निविदा निरस्तीकरण सूचना:-

इस संभाग का निविदा सूचना क्र. 01/व.ले.लि. 2026-27 दिनांक 08.06.2026 निविदा सिस्टम क्रमांक 192555 (प्रथम आमंत्रण) द्वारा आमंत्रित निविदा का बिड केन्द्रीय निविदा प्रकोष्ठ के निविदा पूर्व अर्हता निर्धारण समिति द्वारा दिनांक 01.07.2026 को ऑनलाइन खोला गया। उक्त निविदा के प्रथम आमंत्रण में प्रतिभागी निविदाकारों की संख्या निरंक है। अतः उक्त निविदा तत्काल प्रभाव से निरस्त किया जाता है।

हस्ता/-
कार्यापालन अभियंता
हसदेव बरॉज जल प्रबंध संभाग
No 262702184-3 राममपुर कोरबा

"IMPORTANT"

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America did not just host the World Cup, it fell in love with it

Sandip G
New Jersey, July 19

OUTSIDE THE Atlanta Stadium after the England-Argentina thriller, James Brown is tiredly unfolding his makeshift stall that sold World Cup memorabilia. He is throwing the remaining items, stacks of caps and t-shirts, at throwaway prices before the locality empties fully. "I might open the store tomorrow, some fans might be lingering, but I will miss the World Cup," he says. A mechanic in a tyre shop on the highway, he says he has never been a football fan. His only motive was to make a quick buck. "I am more of a footie guy, that's what I have been watching and playing since my childhood. Soccer, well, no one watches games on TV at home. But here I had to learn and watch because I was dealing with soccer fans, and I wanted to appear knowledgeable," he says. "But the more I watched the more I started enjoying it, and USMNT was doing well. I wish they were in the final," he says. The football mania peaked

when the national team was putting on exciting performances until Belgium knocked them out in the round of 16. All stadiums were packed, even those disinclined to watch filled in the stands to cheer for their country. The tournament has averaged 64,511 fans for an occupancy rate of 99.7%, as per the Sports Business Journal. Roughly 6.5 million people watched from the stands. The dynamic pricing that made tickets unaffordable deterred numerous fans, but many still tuned into streaming platforms. American Outlaws member John Davis remembers a middle-aged real estate agent in his next seat in Seattle. "He kept on asking me about this rule and that, he was slightly irritating, but I was happy because even those who didn't know the game were passionately cheering for the game. The followers cut across age groups, but most of them were young, like 20-25. So I believe it's a good sign for the game's popularity in the US," he details. He says he even came across Americans passionately sup-



Norway fans' Viking Row (left) became a signature part of the World Cup; Scotland's Tartan Army marched to Boston's Fenway Park. AP



porting other teams too. "I came across a dozen of the locals, non-immigrants, supporting Egypt, in the game against Argentina. I never bumped into such people during the COPA (held in 2024)," he says. **Youth following** A Statista Insights Survey showed that 46 percent of the youth in the country watched the tournament. It slumped to 30 percent in the 50-65 age-

band. "Practically it's a young sport in the country, and naturally, most of its followers are youngsters. I remember it was the same in 1994, but things are different in this generation, when there is access to watching leagues abroad, and the social media platforms would sustain their interest. I wouldn't say it's still mainstream, but it's getting there," he observed. The broader impact of the tournament would be felt in a

decade or so, says Vincent Coroba, of Uruguay FC, an amateur football club. "The real thing is whether the sport has captivated the youngsters, whether America becomes a force. I think this World Cup will drive more youngsters into the sport," he says. Every host city was soaked in the World Cup frenzy. The pubs in Boston ran out of beer, thanks to the high-scoring Scots. Atlanta's famous south-

ern cuisine joints had queues as long as a furlong; the nights in Philadelphia's Chinatown never ended, and Times Square was a planet unto itself, the favourite rendezvous of visiting fans, a haunt of impromptu watch parties and assimilation of cultures, and some even played football in the streets. Micky Den, who runs a Thai restaurant on 41st Street, says he never expected the atmosphere to be this electrifying.

"Times Square is always buzzing, but not at this scale, and not for these many days. I made friends from Turkey, Senegal, and Argentina," he says. The quality of the game mobilised the fan-base. Matches ran close, all the superstars, barring Cristiano Ronaldo, dazzled; new stars were born; the perceived minnows shocked and scared the established order. There was never a dull day in the tournament. The scepticism that preceded the tournament vanished. The Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) barely pulled up immigrants from stadiums. The controversy surrounding the rejected visa and the treatment of the Iran team was quickly forgotten. Even President Donald Trump, the protagonist in the build-up to the tournament, performed only two cameo acts. The scandalous one involved him persuading the FIFA boss and friend Gianni Infantino to rescind forward Folarin Balogun's red-card-induced suspension. "It will stick out like a sore thumb, and will hit the image of American soccer," says Davis.

The other was a closed-door, private event with Infantino and football celebrities. "The American dream, Mr. President, came to reality," Infantino told Trump in New York on Friday. "We united the world." Trump called it "one of the all-time greatest sporting events in history." However, according to Forbes, the US economy didn't scale the heights it was predicted to. FIFA analysis had predicted that the World Cup would ship in \$30.5 billion into the US economy, an estimate based on the huge influx of international spend. But according to projections from the National Travel and Tourism Office, the country witnessed only a 0.2 percent surge in travellers. But beyond cut-throat finances, the stocks and checks, it was a World Cup where America fell in love with football (even Trump calls it football and has suggested changing American football's name) and football fell in love with America. And when the tournament ends, and the stalls and scaffolding are packed, America will miss the sport they call soccer.

SLUGFEST FOR THIRD PLACE

Spectacle without stakes

England beat France 6-4 in a wild and erratic game that went down to the wire



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 19

THE MINDS stalked the past, treading the grey lines between what could have or what should have been. But the eyes wandered into the future, what could, what abounded for the two teams that lost the semifinals in distinctive ways. France lost in tactics; England lost in the weight of emotions. Both combined to produce a wild thriller, a tennis set score of 6-4 in England's favour, which could have made a sure-shot case to enter the thriller hall of fame, had it not been for the peculiarly intrinsic nature of third-place games, struck between a formality and a ghost match. The spectators were absurdly entertained, there was a goal every tenth minute if the stoppage allowances were taken into account. Bukayo Saka, confined to cameos in the

England's celebrations were restrained. Handshakes and hugs were cold; they laboured to the fans' enclosure and applauded them

knockouts, as he was not optimally fit, pummeled the lapses in French defence, seemingly disinterested, the 90 minutes on the field a punishment for the collective shutdown against Spain. In the second half, it was England's turn to be sloppy, which France punished by blasting four goals. Two came from the flashing boots of Kylian Mbappe, who pulled two goals away from Lionel Messi to lead the golden boot race. He joined him in the table of most goals scored (21) in the history of the tournament as well. But no plaque or statistical feat would soothe his pain of not lifting the World Cup, after France had looked flawless till they bumped into Spain. He shook his head dejectedly when the final whistle blew, not because France lost the game and a place on the podium, but because he wouldn't be playing the final on Sunday. England's celebrations, too, were restrained. Handshakes and hugs were cold; they la-



Saka (top right) scored a hat-trick for England; Mbappe netted a brace for France. AP

boured to the fans' enclosure and applauded them. They put on forced smiles when on the podium. The eyes were hollow. The bronze medal hung uncomfortably in their necks, the mind longed for one of different shade. It was their best finish since winning the World Cup, the it could have been all too different but for the last six minutes of the Argentina game. The bronze would remind them of a scar.

Ghosts of the past

The past kept dragging back irreversibly. During the presentation ceremony, Saka was probed on his perceived criticism of manager Thomas Tuchel. He dead-batted: "I think it's just part of the game. You know when you lose there's always gonna be noise. When you win. There's gonna be noise ... there is always noise." In a different world, the hat-trick would have been a redemption for his penalty miss in Euro2020. Tuchel, whose England future remains uncertain, cribbed on the taxing schedule. "They (France) had one more day in-between the semi-final to digest, and they had way less travel distances than us. We played in the heat, at altitude. I was worried physically. You could see it in the second half, the cramps and all the tiredness, but I was never worried about the mentality." His parting line seemed a self-appraisal of a soon-to-be-fired employee. "I have said it before, this team has created something very special, and they showed it again," he said. The critics in England and the fans back home would passionately differ. His French counterpart Didier Deschamps, whom he



hugged tightly in a moment of heightened emotion, would invariably leave, as he had announced before the tournament. He leaves France with a rich legacy and enviable array of attacking riches, which in the hands of a foresightful successor could be a dynastic force. Mbappe's tribute to Deschamps before the game summed up his shaping influence on Mbappe and the group. "Today is your last dance. You, who have given us so much. We should have given you a better ending, but we failed," he wrote. Barring Ousmane Dembele, 29, all of his attackers are not yet in their peak years, yet magnificent. If only they possessed similar defensive resources. They require a backline overhaul. The crew of fullbacks are ageing. The once effervescent Theo Hernandez has lost his pace, Lucas Digne is not mobile enough to deal with a high pressing team like Spain. Jules Kounde, whether fully fit or not, could be ponderous. William Saliba needs a quicker centre-back ally than Dayot Upamecano. Whether England persist

with Tuchel or not, England have a vibrant nucleus to build on for their next tournament. Saka, perhaps smarting from the angst of being overlooked for the semifinal, showed the influence he could be, weaving and bobbing through the French defence like a knife slicing a pudding. Both his goals were supreme exhibitions of his minimalism and clarity of thought. He is only 24, Morgan Rogers is a year younger, as is Jude Bellingham, who had an exceptional campaign but for the hyper-emotional semifinal. Declan Rice is 27. At some juncture, the ageing sinews of Harry Kane, John Stones and Jordan Pickford would be phased away. But England has disturbing depth in talent to be title chasers in the next Euro and beyond. Thus, once the disappointment abates, ruing and rumination sink, emotions concede to realistic stock-checking, France and England would realise that the heartbreaks they suffered could only embolden them in the future, packaging them into a more durable product.

Records broken in 10-goal bronze final

THE THIRD-PLACE playoff is normally a game that no side wants to play, and head coaches of both England and France had said the same in the run-up to the match. It was also evident from the way the sides played, with scant attention given to defending, all of which led to it becoming a goalfest. Here's a look at some of the records broken or equalled:

64 This was the first time in 64 years that both teams scored four or more goals in a World Cup match. The last time this happened was a 4-4 draw between the Soviet Union and Colombia at the 1962 World Cup

10 This is the most number of goals ever scored in a third-place playoff match at the World Cup. The previous highest was the nine scored in 1958 by France and West Germany

22 Kylian Mbappe scored twice in the match, thus taking his tally in World Cups to 22 goals. It makes him the highest goal-scorer of all time in the history of the tournament, ahead of the Argentina vs Spain final

10 Mbappe is the first player since German great Gerd Muller in 1970 to score 10 goals at a single World Cup

7 Michael Olise finished with seven assists in this World Cup, which is the most in the last six decades

7 Jude Bellingham finished with seven goals. It is the most by an England player in a single edition of the World Cup

4 Bukayo Saka is the fourth England player to have netted a World Cup hat-trick, joining his captain Harry Kane, Gary Lineker and Geoff Hurst

How Spain has grown into coaching's premier school

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, July 19

"THE COACH," Johan Cruyff liked to say, "is the most important player in the team." Nearly three decades after he transformed Spanish football, the 2026 World Cup felt like the vindication of that philosophy. Spain reached the final under Luis de la Fuente. Standing opposite him was Argentina's Lionel Scaloni - an Argentine who earned his UEFA Pro Licence through the Spanish coaching system. De la Fuente, quite fittingly, had even been one of Scaloni's instructors. The subplot of the final was teacher versus student. Yet, that was only the latest exhibit in Spanish football's extraordinary coaching revolution. Weeks before the World Cup kicked off, the Champions League final had featured two Spanish coaches - Mikel Arteta and Luis Enrique. Unai Emery had won the Europa League. In England, Arteta's Arsenal finished ahead of Pep Guardiola's Manchester City. Luis Enrique had already guided Paris Saint-Germain to another Ligue 1 title.

Look around the world's biggest competitions, and Spanish coaches are everywhere. Nearly 20 percent of coaches in Europe's 'Big Five' leagues - England, Spain, Germany, Italy and France - are Spanish, according to research by Roberto Lopez del Campo of the La Liga Business School. At this World Cup, three teams besides Spain were led by Spanish managers.

Impact in India

The influence stretches beyond Europe. In India, the 'S' in the Indian Super League might as well stand for 'Spanish'. Spanish coaches have won more than half of the league's titles, while clubs have increasingly adopted Spanish methodologies. Even where Spanish coaches haven't reached, Spanish ideas often have. Not since Italy dominated the tactical imagination of the 1980s, or Germany reshaped pressing after Euro 2000, has one country exerted such authority over football's dugouts. The obvious question is: why Spain? The answer begins with failure.

For much of the 20th century, Spain were football's great underachievers. They produced gifted players but rarely converted promise into trophies. Quarterfinal exits became a curse. The group-stage elimination at the 1998 World Cup, followed by the controversial loss to South Korea four years later, reinforced a belief that Spanish football possessed talent but lacked a coherent identity.

The roots of the answer lay with Cruyff. At Barcelona, he changed the questions coaches asked. Instead of, 'Can he run?', they began asking, 'Can he think?' Instead of teaching players where to stand, they taught them why to stand there. Every academy side was expected to speak the same football language so that ideas



(Clockwise from top) Luis de la Fuente, Mikel Arteta and Luis Enrique have covered themselves in glory in recent times. AP/REUTERS

Spain's best since '23

LUIS DE LA FUENTE: 2024 European Championship, 2022-23 UEFA Nations League

MIKEL ARTETA: 2025-26 Premier League, 2023 FA Community Shield, 2025-26 UEFA Champions League runners-up, 2023-24 & 2024-25 Premier League runners up

LUIS ENRIQUE: 2023-24, 2024-25 & 2025-26 Ligue 1; 2023-24 & 2024-25 Coupe de France, 2023, 2024 & 2025 Trophée des Champions, 2024-25 & 2025-26 UEFA Champions League, 2025 UEFA Super Cup, 2025 FIFA Intercontinental Cup

flowed to the first team. The rest of Spain soon followed.

At around the same time, the Spanish Football Federation reimagined coaching. Becoming a coach was no longer viewed as the natural next step for an ex-player with a famous name. It became a profession. Licence courses resembled university degrees, with aspiring coaches studying pedagogy, psychology, physiology, sports science and tactical methodology alongside practical work on the pitch.

The same rigour filtered through the country's academies. Barcelona's La Masia became the world's most famous football school. But Villarreal, Athletic Bilbao, Sevilla and Real Sociedad built similar pathways, in which coaches progressed through the age groups just as players did. An Under-12 coach wasn't merely chasing victories; he was laying the foundations for the first team.

The proof was in the proverbial pudding, and it arrived

over the next two decades. Xavi, Andres Iniesta, Sergio Busquets and David Silva gave Spain its greatest national team, winning the 2008 European Championship, the 2010 World Cup and the 2012 Euros. At almost the same time, Guardiola's Barcelona redefined club football. Most assumed Spain's gift to football was tiki-taka. It wasn't. Spain's greatest export turned out not to be a formation but a way of thinking.

That is why Guardiola's football looks different from Luis Enrique's, why Arteta has adapted Spanish principles to the Premier League, why Xabi Alonso blends positional play with German organisation, and why Scaloni's Argentina became world champions without trying to imitate Spain.

Scaloni is perhaps the perfect embodiment of that legacy. Born in Argentina, developed as a player in Spain and educated through the Spanish coaching system, he carried those ideas back home without becoming a copy of anyone.

De la Fuente still remembers the young Argentine sitting in the front row of his coaching classes. "Leo was always debating," he recalled in an interview with *The Guardian*. "He had that restlessness, that way of challenging you. I don't see it that way." He was always arguing."

It is an anecdote that captures the essence of Spain's football culture. Coaches are encouraged not merely to absorb ideas but to question them, refine them and make them their own. That is how Spain became football's great coaching university.

The World Cup final is over. Spain's coaching revolution isn't.

Antonelli wins Belgian GP; title rival Russell crashes out



Kimi Antonelli won his first Belgian Grand Prix title. REUTERS
Spa-Francorchamps, July 19

KIMI ANTONELLI won the Belgian Grand Prix for Mercedes on Sunday to stretch his Formula One lead to 45 points over Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton on a bleak day for teammate George Russell, his closest title rival heading into the race. Russell spun off into the gravel at Les Combes on the opening lap at the Spa-Francorchamps circuit, after a collision with Hamilton while trying to make up places lost after the start, and dropped to third overall and 50 points behind. "I am numb to the disappointment. When it happens so often you just get used to it," a stunned Russell said of the latest blow to his championship hopes. Ferrari's Charles Leclerc was runner-up in the 44-lap race, 1.952 seconds behind after leading thanks to a pitstop while a virtual safety car was deployed, and Max Verstappen finished third to give Red Bull their 300th Formula One podium.

Hamilton finished fourth, despite serving a five-second penalty for the collision with Russell, and was investigated by stewards for an unsafe release from a pitstop that left one of his mechanics on the ground, but unhurt.

The mechanic, who had been trying to adjust the front wing, was helped back up after being hit by the front wheel as Hamilton was given the sign to leave. Ferrari were fined €30,000 (\$34,317.00) with €10,000 suspended for a year provided there was no similar infringement in that time. It was Antonelli's sixth win in 10 rounds this season, and his fifth from pole position, leaving him sure to go into the August break after Hungary next weekend with a solid lead.

The battle in the constructors championship tightened, with Mercedes now 73 points ahead of Ferrari after going into the weekend 78 clear.

"It's great to be back on the top step after a few difficult rounds," said Antonelli, who had drawn a blank in two of the past three rounds and seen his lead slashed from a hefty 66 points over Hamilton in June.

"It was a hard-fought race. We lost first place with the VSC but then we managed to make our way back.

"The momentum was always there. It was just about getting the results," he added. "Today we were a bit lucky with what happened in terms of the championship but you have to take every opportunity because we saw how much it can swing."

At 31, Sindhu downs Yamaguchi, lands her first Super 750 title

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 19

PV SINDHU tends to play Akane Yamaguchi almost with refueling rage these days. Despite leading her 15-14 in head-to-heads, she can look back in anger at the many titles the Japanese has denied her - including an Asian Championship. On Sunday, at age 31, Sindhu finally put an end to a 5-year streak of losses to Yamaguchi since May 2022. It was a scorching fiery 21-17, 21-17 victory, as she put every ounce and particle of strength and aggression into winning her first Super 750 title.

It was mindful menacing from the 5-ft-11 against an opponent who's barely 5-ft-1, but has used tall tosses and relentlessness to bother Sindhu. But with a rejuvenated attack, Sindhu tore apart the sturdy resolve that has upended her so often to register a truly dominant win that's been missing over the last few years.

Chen Yufei had warned about the Sindhu attack. But Yamaguchi, unfazed always, needed to taste it for herself. It was like biting into a huge chunk of green chilli.

The spice came from not just the regal crosscourt statement smashes. Those are never enough against the Japanese. It needed punk-headed persistence in punishing rallies and the use of two tormenting weapons - her height and the looming storm to the net for smash follow-ups.

Since her Olympics silver, Sindhu has relied on sky-high tosses to destabilize the two short-framed Japanese. So the World No 10 kept the shuttle in stratosphere by any method possible: the clears, the tosses, the lifts, everything was geared towards blurring Yamaguchi's hitting radar, as the shuttles went long and wide. The net follow-ups seen from the Yamaguchi eye-level were like an approaching tornado.



PV Sindhu won the final in straight games. BWF/BADMINTON PHOTO

Sindhu trailed 9-11 in the first, but even that was ominous. A tiny, tasty trend had shown up quite early: mirrored aggression. When Yamaguchi, a World No 3 smashed on Sindhu's body to get to 6-5, Sindhu immediately retaliated with a similar body smash the

very next point. The theme would play out recurrently. So when the 28-year-old home favourite took the lead at 11-9 going over Sindhu's head with a lob, Sindhu's immediate reaction coming out of the break was to lift over the Japanese' moptop to go to 11-10. You don't

Number Plate

1 PV Sindhu is the first Indian shuttler to win a title at the Japan Open since the inception of the tournament back in 1982

train to execute grudges like those. The Indian simply had the weapons for immediate vengeance.

Early exchanges were short, but at a punishing pace that never subsided till the first long rally of 36 shots came up at 11-11. Yamaguchi had a delectable low pickup backhand cross slaloming the net for 12-9, but it was Sindhu all the way thereafter. From 16-12 down to 16-15, the Japanese got her only plan right: targeting Sindhu's far forehand corner. But the Indian was undeterred, and with an explosive net game, she raced

to take the opener.

Yamaguchi's last real throw of the dice came when she was 15-17 down. An unforgettable point played out right after she had done a 360 and collapsed trying to intercept a straight bullet whizzing past her - needing the 360 because the Indian had hit it so savagely, it went past her in a tizzy. On the next point, Sindhu smashed at her ribs, but Yamaguchi's reflex parry ballooned and fell on the front court.

Relentless attack

But Sindhu's attack remained relentless. Later Yamaguchi told BWF, Sindhu's attack, aggression and power on her smashes, were impossible to deal with.

The attack has a flip side. "More of my strength is attack. Since I'm moving well it's important that I stop making too many unforced errors," Sindhu explained to BWF. "With top athletes you can't take it easy, even though you are leading. It was

important I maintained the same aggressiveness," she said. Both were exhausted and doubling over when the second set started. But Sindhu vs Japan is always about hitting the wall and finding a second wind. Sindhu found a gust. She led from start to finish though a wobble saw Yamaguchi reach 17-19 even after she was 7-14 down.

Yamaguchi doesn't have three World Championship titles for no reason. She amped up the altitude, and started reporting to Sindhu's high-tos game with high clears of her own -- the plan being to deny Sindhu the ideal smashing length. It worked for three points exactly - 8-4 to 8-7. But Sindhu guarded her lead zealously.

And though 14-7 became 18-17, the late surge from the Japanese was never going to be enough. Her end came sending one of those tall tosses that drifted long. Sindhu knew she had the win despite needing a challenge.

With the axe hanging, Rohit's Lord's innings says he isn't done

Selectors have already decided his ODI career is over. In what could be his last innings, former India captain batted like a man refusing to accept it

Venkata Krishan B
Chennai, July 19

THE SUSPENSE around Rohit Sharma's future might continue till India's next assignment in September unless there is an official word. But with an emphatic 138 off 110 deliveries at Lord's in the third ODI against England, the 39-year-old showed he isn't going anywhere without a fight. If there is anyone waiting to take his spot, the call should come from the selectors. Chasing 388, more than Rohit, it was a knock that India needed badly. As he slog-swept Adil Rashid for a boundary off the 84th delivery he faced, there were no animated gestures or over the top celebrations. He pumped the fists, embraced Virat Kohli, who uttered few words in his ears which brought out a smile and out came the bat, pointing to the dressing room and to his family in the stands.

The lead-up to the series decider had firmly been on Rohit. As reported by The Indian Express, the selectors have already informed him about their decision to move on. The message was relayed to him before the series, and prior to the outing at Lord's, Rohit had seldom appeared the batsman one had got used to. Both at Edgbaston and particularly at Cardiff, he had appeared a batsman who was perhaps playing with a cluttered mind. The result of it was, no matter how much he tried, he struggled for rhythm.

But on Sunday, Rohit came across as a different batsman.

Number Plate

39

At the age of 39, Rohit Sharma became the oldest Indian to score an ODI century, surpassing Sachin Tendulkar (38 years and 327 days)

Not that he didn't struggle. His innings was scratchy at the start, but he showed the hunger to fight it out. And once he got to his fifty at run-a-ball, he appeared a different batsman, accelerating to his century off the next 34 deliveries as he entered the Lord's honours board for the first time and possibly in his last innings at the iconic venue. It was an innings that had lessons for the new gen batsmen in terms of how to construct an innings in an ODI.

On a pitch where England's batsmen piled on 387 - the highest ODI score at the venue, the host seamers didn't make it easy for Rohit. With their tight lines and movement off the surface, they asked questions repeatedly. There was an instance where Rohit tried to break the shackles by stepping out and hitting over the straight field, and edged it over slip for a boundary.

Beyond that, he wouldn't take any undue risk. He would show the respect the deliveries merited. There would be times he would be beaten and respond with a cheeky smile. There would be occasions when he would get the bat down only



Rohit Sharma scored 138 runs off 110 balls, hitting 17 fours and 5 sixes. CREIMAS FOR BCCI

at the last fraction of a second, with the willow making a sound that revealed the connection was far from the sweet spot. It was almost like the sound of the ball hitting the bat, not the other way round. But Rohit wasn't minding any of it.

With Rohit showing the courage to fight it out, he would reap the rewards as well. In the seventh over as Josh Tongue came on, he offered a few bad deliveries. First up, Rohit would flick him fine before following it up with his trademark pull. The Lord's crowd, not for the first time in the day, will start chanting his name.

Two deliveries later in the same over, Rohit would deposit one into the square-leg stands - a short delivery, the batsman picking up the length early, and pulling it with total disdain. Suddenly, despite a sedate beginning, Rohit was outscoring the captain.

The road though wouldn't

be smooth. Tongue would tie Rohit down with a maiden. Off three deliveries in that over, as the seamer kept attacking the stumps, he would bring out his flick, but such is the form that all of it went straight to the fielder at mid-wicket. The frustration grew, but the 39-year-old didn't commit hara-kiri.

As Sam Curran came on, Rohit wouldn't let him settle. At Cardiff, the left-arm seamer had troubled him, but here Rohit would get down and sweep him off the stumps. When Curran tried to alter his length by digging one short, Rohit would pounce on it, with a front-foot pull deep into the stands.

With Gill farming a majority of the strike, the rhythm continued to desert him, before successive boundaries off Gus Atkinson - first a sweep and then a scoop, bringing up his fifty. From there on he was a different batsman.

The initial years of Rohit's

batting in ODIs is built in the old fashioned way - start slowly, pace the innings and accelerate once he has the hang of the attack and conditions. Here, he followed the template, although the improvisations were visible every now and then. Between 50 to 100, Rohit's inning was as commanding as any big knocks he has played. When Jofra Archer came back for a spell, he took him head on, but it was the two consecutive sixes off Tongue that showed Rohit was in the mood. Up until then, there was a bit of self doubt.

But as Tongue delivered one in the slot, with a still head, he tonked it over long-on before hitting the next one over the bowler for another hold the pose shot. That six took him into the 90s, from where the century seemed inevitable as he went back to a standing ovation, wondering if he would get another opportunity and what more he should do.

Gukesh splits points with arch-rival Abdusattorov

Amit Kamath
Chennai, July 19

SOMETIMES In chess, a draw can feel like a lot more. Or a lot less. A day after world champion D Gukesh was left miffed with a draw against Dmitry Andreikin, the 20-year-old looked a relieved man after splitting points against arch-rival Nodirbek Abdusattorov. Finally, Chennai's new favourite chess son was smiling after three unhappy days in his hometown.

The Chennai Grand Masters in 2023 was Gukesh's first decisive step towards the world championship title, but in three rounds this year he had suffered only disappointment, with a loss to Alireza Firouzja, and draws against Nihal Sarin and Andreikin. However, splitting a point with the dangerous Abdusattorov would have brought a semblance of relief.

That is why, after three and a half hours of chess, Gukesh agreed to spend time in the fan zone, obliging them with autographs and fans.

With games starting at 3 pm, not many fans had been able to

make it for previous rounds, but Sunday was different. Hundreds of fans flocked to the ground floor fan zone, for two reasons. The first was former world champion Viswanathan Anand making an appearance for commentary duties. The other was the blockbuster clash between Gukesh and Abdusattorov.

On Saturday, a smiling Abdusattorov had waltzed into the media room after his third round game and said how he was bracing himself for a 'big fight' with the Indian. The duo have a storied rivalry, having fought tooth and nail in some nail-biters that inevitably turned in the Uzbek's favour.

"When we play against each other, there's always going to be some drama. An interesting game for sure. I don't remember us playing a calm, boring game. So I expect a crazy game," he had said.

Two matches

Over the course 2026, the duo had faced off twice already in classical tournaments. Abdusattorov had prevailed both times, first at the Tata Steel



D Gukesh (R) playing against Abdusattorov in Chennai. CGM

Masters in January and then at Prague Masters in March. The first reversal had been particularly heartbreaking for the Indian, after an uncharacteristic blunder.

On Sunday, however, there was not much drama. The clash ended in a stalemate in 41 moves. Playing with black pieces in a game where the

Queen's Gambit Declined made an appearance, Gukesh first nullified his opponent's slight edge out of the opening before shutting the door on any fresh chances. Both players had nearly 98 percent accuracy in the game.

As the duel ended the middle game phase, the conversation on the chess.com

commentary inevitably turned to the upcoming world championship match between Gukesh and Uzbek challenger Javokhir Sindarov, primarily because Abdusattorov had told media that he would be a part of his compatriot's team. With the kind of intrigue that exists around world championship prep, Gukesh's mentor Anand was asked if there was a chance we were seeing some ideas for the world championship being tested in Chennai.

"So little is known (about what's going on behind the scenes). For all you know, Gukesh is probably doing it himself (testing the waters with his world championship ideas). And Nodirbek could be playing Sindarov's prep and nobody would know," Anand said.

The draw meant Gukesh is half a point behind Abdusattorov in the standings, but in a three-way tie for the last spot in the eight-player field. With all four games ending in draws on Sunday, the leaderboard remained unchanged with Firouzja half a point ahead of India's Arjun Erigaisi at the top.

Feels like we're all beating Gukesh on the head, says Vishy Anand

Amit Kamath
Chennai, July 19

EVEN AS the rest of the chess world seems to be fixated on world champion Gukesh's bad form in the 18 months since he became world champion, five-time world champion Viswanathan Anand has expressed hope that the 20-year-old will be able to steer the ship around in time for the world championship title defence against Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov at the end of this year.

Gukesh is yet to win a single tournament since becoming world champion in December 2024 at the age of 18. The ongoing Chennai Grand Masters tournament too seems to not going his way, with Gukesh winless after four rounds in the seven-round event. The three draws and a loss have seen Gukesh slump to the last spot in the eight-player standings which he shares with two others.

When Anand, who had turned up at the Westin Chen-

nai Velachery hotel to make the ceremonial first move for round 4 on Sunday, was asked about Gukesh's run of form since becoming world champion, the Indian chess legend said: "He must be disappointed with the results, but anyway he will play some more games. Right now it feels like we're all beating him on the head with this. He's had a bad streak for a while, but he can snap out of it even before. Hopefully, the Chess Olympiad (in Uzbekistan in September) inspires him. He still has the chance to do it here."

After the recent Norway Chess tournament had ended in another last-place finish for Gukesh, he had spoken about having a loss of motivation in the immediate months after becoming world champion too.

"It was a longer stretch, right? But yeah, I too had moments like that (after the 2010 world championship triumph over Bulgaria's Veselin Topalov). For me, 2011 was a slow year in general," Anand said.

Anand also addressed his decision to not run for the Deputy President post of FIDE in the upcoming elections with incumbent president Arkady Dvorkovich. The Dvorkovich campaign has already mentioned that Anand remains a part of the team, but he will not be the Russian's second-in-command. "I simply wanted to have more time at home. My son will probably go to university in three years. I thought these are the years I should be here and I think that was kind of a big motivation to get a different role. But I'm still very much part of the team and I would contribute what I can," said Anand.

After he became the world champion in 2024, Gukesh had credited Anand's guidance in his campaign to become the world champion. This time around too was Anand going to help him? "I can't tell you. If I tell you, you can't believe me. What can I say," Anand chuckled.



Ben Duckett hit a total of 19 boundaries in his innings of 141 runs of 135 balls. CREIMAS FOR BCCI

He began fluently but with an escalating run rate, needed to up the ante further. Rohit, despite cramping, took it upon himself to clear the boundary and, after some lusty blows, fell trying to go for one shot too many, bowled by Jacob Bethell for an excellent 138.

But the match turned decisively in England's favour in the 44th over when Ishan Kishan and Shreyas Iyer both fell to Sam Curran's change of pace, and when Kohli fell to the same bowler in the 46th over for 74, it meant curtains for India.

Earlier, on a placid surface under blue skies, India's bowling attack sans Jasprit Bumrah was taken to the cleaners. Duckett's 141 off 135 balls and Bethell's 92 laid the platform for a mammoth score.

Bumrah's absence left a big void in the attack, but it also offered the rest of the bowling unit an opportunity to deliver. None of them did.

BRIEF SCORES: England 387/3 in 50 overs (Ben Duckett 141, Jacob Bethell 92, Joe Root 74 not out; Prasad Krishna 2/69) beat India 360/7 in 50 overs (Rohit Sharma 138, Shubman Gill 77, Virat Kohli 74; Sam Curran 4/75) by 27 runs